

Documentary film techniques

From Wikipedia, the free encyclopedia

A documentary film is a film story concerning factual topics (i.e. someone or something). These films have a variety of aims: to record important events and ideas; to inform viewers; to convey opinions and to create public interest. A number of common techniques or conventions are used in documentaries to achieve these aims.

Actuality in relation to documentary films

Actuality is the term for raw film footage of real life events, places and people as opposed to fictional films which use actors, scripted stories and artificial sets. Documentaries are not pure actuality films - rather they combine actuality with explanation, commentary, and perhaps even dramatisation.

Voice-over

The voice-over in a documentary is a commentary by the filmmaker, spoken while the camera is filming, or added to the soundtrack during the production. Through this the filmmaker can speak directly to the viewer, offering information, explanations and opinions...

Direct and Indirect Interviews

The interview is a common documentary technique. It allows people being filmed to speak directly about events, prompted by the questions asked by the filmmaker. An interview may take place on screen, or off screen, on a different set. Interviews in a documentary give the viewer a sense of realism, that the documentary maker's views are mutually shared by another person or source, and thus more valid. To achieve this much detail from what may be a one-hour interview, clips of only a few minutes are shown. Interviews on opposing sides of an issue may be shown to give the viewer comprehensive information about a topic.

Archival footage

Archival, or stock footage, is material obtained from a film library or archive and inserted into a documentary to show historical events or to add detail without the need for additional filming.

Reenactment

Reconstructions are also often used in documentaries. They are artificial scenes of an event which has been reconstructed and acted out on film based on information of the event. Reconstructions generally provide factual information, and give the viewer a sense of realism, as if the event really happened in front of them live. They often indicate that the footage is not real by using techniques such as blurring, distortion, lighting effects, changes in camera level, and color enhancement within the footage.

Montage

A montage sequence conveys ideas visually by putting them in a specific order in the film. Narrative montages involve the planning of sequence of shots used to indicate changes in time and place within a film. Ideational montages link actions with words, and are often used in documentaries.

A different positioning of shots conveys different ideas to the viewer. For example, a montage containing a negative theme followed by a positive theme may give the viewer the idea that the positive theme is the main theme of the montage.

Montages in documentaries are usually linked with words that characters say. This visual representation of the characters thoughts helps position the viewer in the story, and helps the viewer better understand what the character is saying. It visually presents a progression of ideas on a screen.

Exposition

In a documentary, the exposition occurs at the beginning and introduces the important themes of the film. It is important because it creates the viewer's first impression and introduces the viewer to the content.

Dramatic segments of the documentary are specially chosen in order to catch the viewer's attention. These shots are specifically positioned, such that the montage positions us to believe a certain theme presented by the documentary and this the documentary presents its view much more persuasively to the viewer.

Documentary Film

Definition: A term used to describe films which deal with factual topics. John Grierson, a British film-maker, defines documentary as "the creative interpretation of reality" so, we should remember that they are a constructed text and therefore only offer a particular version of reality. Filmmakers may work to persuade an audience to accept the version reality they offer; to do this they will use persuasive techniques.

Aims: To record important events and ideas, inform viewers, convey opinions and/or to create public interest about a topic.

Techniques

Unlike fictional films, documentaries often have to convey large amounts of factual information. Over the years documentary film-makers have developed a range of techniques for presenting people, ideas and events on-screen.

Actuality: Actuality is the term for film footage of real-life events, places and people. This is unlike fictional film which uses actors, artificial sets and scripted stories. Actuality footage is a record of real events as they unfold.

Voice Over: The voice-over is a commentary by the documentary maker, spoken while the camera is filming or added to the soundtrack during production. Through this commentary, the film-maker can speak directly to the viewer and offer information, explanations and opinions.

Music and Sound FX: Music is often used to create mood or atmosphere. It might also tell a story which is relevant to the topic or have some symbolic meaning. Sound FX are added in post-production to enhance the effect of a particular scene.

Interviews: Interviews are a basic documentary technique. They allow people being filmed to speak directly about events, often in response to questions asked by the film-maker. Interviews may take place on or off-screen with one or both of the speakers shown.

File Footage: Material obtained from a film library or archive, inserted into a documentary to show historical events or to add detail without the need for additional filming.

Captioning: Captioning means placing written text on the screen to give additional information to the viewer. Captions may be used to give names of people interviewed, to give the time or location of an event, or to provide other relevant information.

Graphics: Images designed to convey an idea visually. They may be simple, such as lists of names, graphs, maps or written documents. Or they may be very complex, such as computer generated images of a difficult scientific concept such as gravity. Do not confuse these with captions!!

Re-enactment: When real events cannot be filmed as they happen, film-makers will sometimes re-create the event. Re-enactments can be minor (eg. Asking someone to repeat an action so it can be filmed more clearly) or major (eg. Hiring actors and building sets to imitate an historic event or occasion).

Montage: A montage is a technique used in which a series of short shots are edited into a sequence to condense space, time, and information. Watch the documentary extract from Not all documentary film-makers use these codes in the same way, or to the same extent but most documentary films contain some combination of these basic elements.

<http://englishmindariesc.weebly.com/documentary.html>

Documentary Storytelling Techniques

Creative ideas to help tell your story



The key to choosing the right storytelling techniques for your documentary is to know who your primary audience will be and where/how it will be viewed.

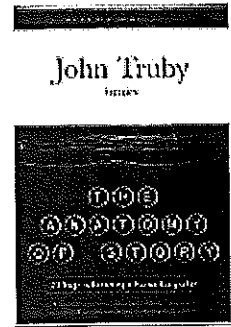
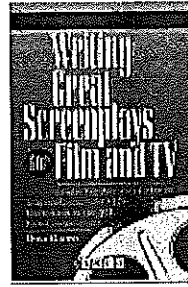
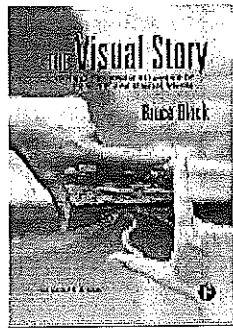
If your audience is a group of third graders, you may choose a very different technique than you would for a group of college fraternity brothers or for a group of senior citizens.

Another way to choose your storytelling technique is to think about your subject matter.

If your documentary is about war, you might choose a very different storytelling style than if your documentary is about adopting puppies.

The idea is that you want to create the proper setting and tone to create an experience for your audience. You want to build the story in such a way to keep the audience engaged and following the story.. you don't want them to get bored nor do you want to overstimulate.

Scriptwriting Resources



Storytelling Techniques

Narration – This is a traditional style of storytelling using a narrator who is off-camera and never seen. This generic “voice” is an objective storyteller. This style is often used in news type documentaries like PBS's Frontline.

Host – This is a style of storytelling where you learn the story through a guide or a host. You see this person on camera and they take you through the story in their own words. The host could be you, it could be a celebrity or a professional host or just a person who has some connection to the story. This is a great technique for a travel documentary. I used this technique in my documentary *Briars in the Cotton Patch* with former UN Ambassador Andrew Young as the host.

No Narration – These are my favorite type of documentaries where there is no narration. The story is pieced together using only clips of interviews, raw footage, on-screen text and graphics. *The Cove* is a compelling example of this style.

Recreations/Drama – This storytelling technique is often used in historical documentaries where important events have already taken place and there is no existing footage. Or there are pieces of the story missing that need to be dramatized. A great example of a documentary using this technique is *Man on Wire*.

Follow One Character – This is a style of storytelling where you choose one person to follow for your story. The filmmakers that made the documentary *An*

Inconvenient Truth took this approach by following Al Gore to tell a big and complicated story.

Cartoon Animation – A lot of documentaries in recent years have been using this technique including *Searching For Sugar Man* and *Blood Brother*. The cartoon animation is used sparingly throughout the documentary to capture a particular event or mood. For example in *Blood Brother*, cartoon animation was used to tell the story of how the lead character dealt with a dying cat.

Stop Motion – My guess is that you would not want to use stop motion for your entire documentary, although anything is possible in filmmaking. Probably, this would simply be one element in your movie. The guys who made *King Corn* used this technique brilliantly using pieces of corn. *King Corn* is a documentary worth watching and full of creative storytelling techniques. You can even watch the “cut scenes” on the DVD to see other ideas they came up with but ended up not using in the final film.

Talking Heads – This is a technique where you interview a lot of people and edit their quotes together one right after the other. The documentary-short *So Where's Home? A Film About Third Culture Kid Identity* is an example.

Chronological Order (or not) – You may choose to tell a story in “real time” as it happened, or you can shake it up a bit by putting the “end” of the story first and then go back in time to explain what happened leading up to that event. This can be a great technique to keep the audience guessing. You could even choose to keep looking back in time throughout the film and then have it all come together at the end.

Personal Point of View – Your voice narrates and tells the story from your personal perspective, like an opinion piece. These types of films can be very compelling if done right. Michael Moore's documentaries, such as *Fahrenheit 9/11* are great examples. This style can be particularly effective when dealing with a very sensitive issue or personal story.

Observational – This is a technique where you just let the camera roll and let the action speak for itself. There is no narration, no “talking heads”, no interviews telling the story. The camera is basically a “fly on the wall”. There is still editing involved to set the tone and pacing, but the filmmakers allow the

action and people in the situation reveal the story in their own timing. I worked with a friend on such a project where we set up a camera in a barber shop and just quietly filmed as one character after the next walked in to reveal a fascinating patchwork of stories. The footage was later edited down into a 20-minute documentary short.

Photo Slideshow – Photos can be a wonderful storytelling technique. As the saying goes, a photo is worth a thousand words. Photos can be put to music, narration or quotes for a sophisticated and compelling documentary. *War Photographer* is a documentary I highly recommend. Although photos are certainly used throughout the documentary, notice the technique the filmmakers used with tiny video cameras attached to the photographer's camera creating a fascinating "personal point of view" perspective.

Drawings/Animation – This is another creative way to tell your story. Say you have a young girl who was abused and you don't want to show her face as she's talking. What about getting an artist to draw a childlike sketch of a young girl and have her walking along the street. It's the same idea as when you flip the pages of a book fast and it reveals a "moving" scene even though each image is a drawing. A compelling documentary that used drawings in the most amazing way is *Operation Homecoming - Writing the Wartime Experience*.

Chapters – Divide the documentary into "chapters" or segments, each with its own title. It keeps it simple for you and simple for your audience. I used this technique in my documentary *Briars in the Cotton Patch*.

Participatory – This style or technique might be used in an educational or children's documentary. Ask the audience to do certain tasks: "Okay, now stand up and do this.." or perhaps it's an instructional type documentary where you need to show how to do CPR or emergency procedures. This style is basically a show and tell.

Those are a few ideas for storytelling techniques.

Learn the entire process of making a documentary from beginning to end, including how to craft a compelling story, in our 7-Day Documentary Crash Course.

Visual Language

<http://englishmindariesc.weebly.com/visual-language.html>



Some of the earliest visual records discovered are preserved on cave walls in Northern Australia and Lascaux in France. These cave paintings display images of hunters, animals, gods and people. Some of these images became so commonly used they formed the basis of our alphabet.

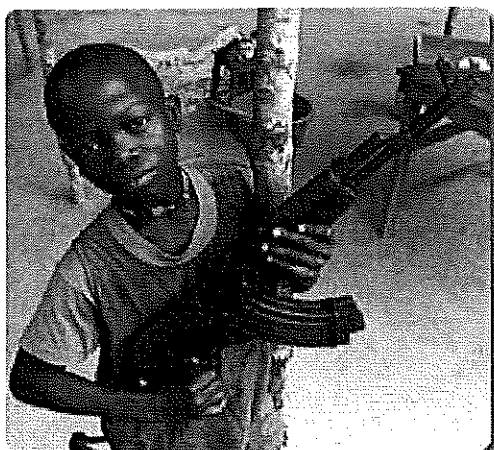
Visual language has a set of codes and conventions that influence the way we interpret different images. There are two types of images: still images and moving images.

Still images

- Posters
- Cartoons
- Photographs
- Billboards
- Illustrations
- Paintings

Guidelines for reading still images

Subject Matter



Begin by describing what you see. Describe the main elements of the image and explain the impact it has upon you as a viewer.

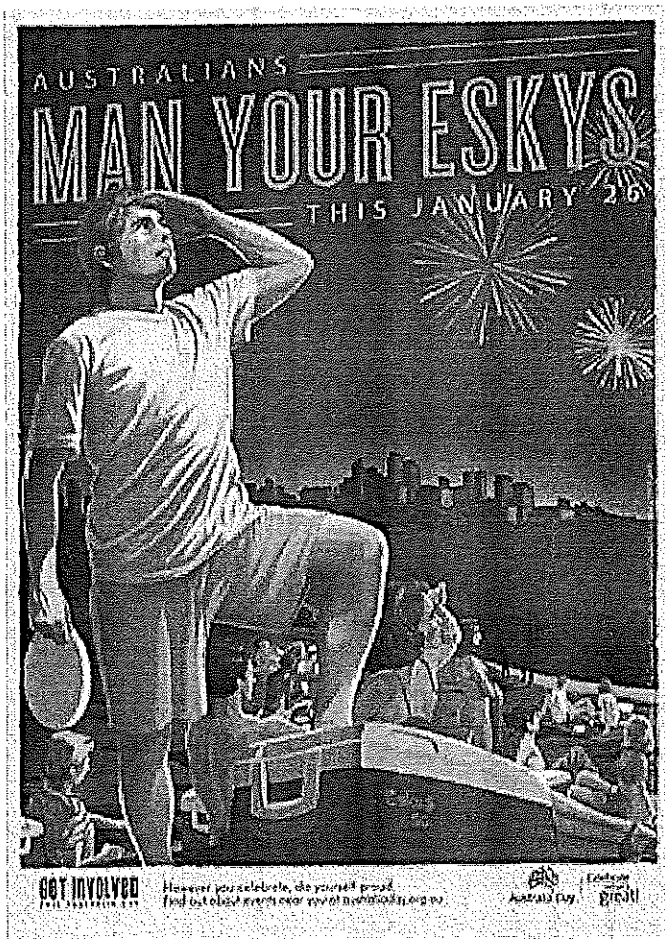
What do you SEE here??

- Boy
- Gun
- Tree
- Chair

Composition

The way the elements of the image are arranged in the frame is called composition. Which elements are the largest/smallest? Which elements are in the foreground/background? What is central to the image? Which elements are at the edges of the image? Elements that appear larger, in the foreground or centrally are often seen as important. Elements which are smaller, in the background or positioned near the margins seem less important or 'marginalised'.

Man your eskys!



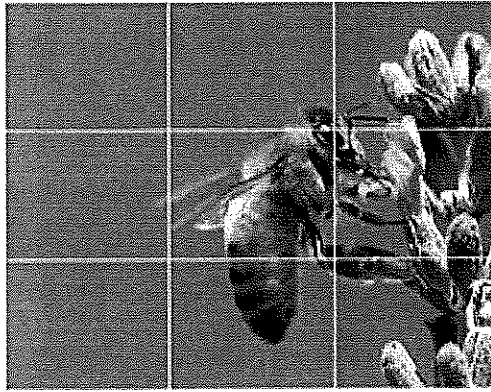
In this image the man is larger and in the foreground. Even though he is not in the centre of the image it is enough for us to consider the young white male to be the most important element in the image.

What is positioned in the centre is the esky. The esky is also positioned in the foreground which delivers a message to the viewer that an esky is particularly important for one reason or another. Although consumption of alcohol has been restricted at the Australia Day celebrations an esky is rarely used for hors d'oeuvres - here we slip into symbolism a little as an esky is used most often and represents Australian's connection to alcohol.

From this we can conclude that Australia values a white male society and that we are essentially a society of drinkers. Although this may not have been the intention of the creator, as a viewer it is our job to pull out the values and attitudes presented to us by dissecting these visual elements.

The Rule of Thirds

The rule states that an image should be imagined as divided into nine equal parts by two equally-spaced horizontal lines and two equally-spaced vertical lines, and that important compositional elements should be placed along these lines or their intersections.

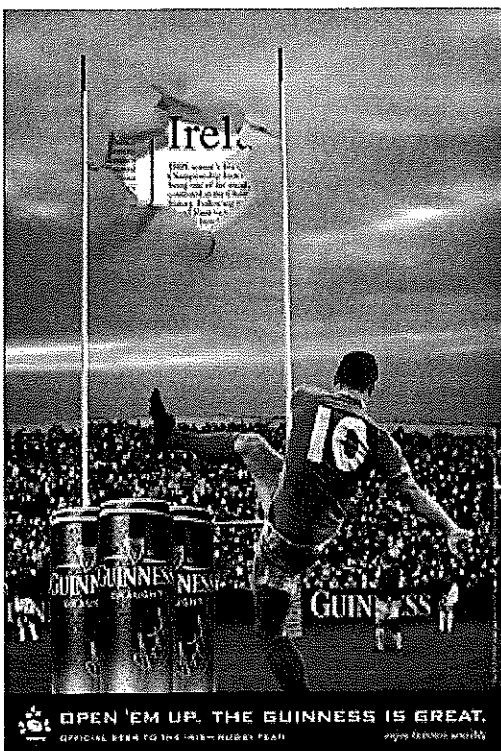


Aligning a subject with these points creates more tension, energy and interest in the composition than simply centering the subject would. Here it appears as if the bee has flown from "somewhere", the left hand column of the image is 'blank'. This might tell a story rather than just being a photo of a bee.



Here the puppy is placed to the right. It appears that he is looking at something out of the frame. Again, this may tell a story (What is he looking at? Is he going to run after something?) rather than being just a dog in some grass.

Leading lines

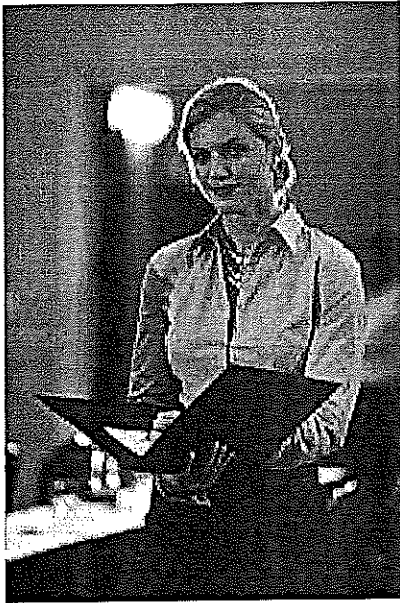


Images are composed of dots, lines and shapes. The eye is often drawn to the most important elements of the image

through the use of 'leading lines'. These can include, but are not limited to, roads, horizons, fences, people pointing in a certain direction or objects arranged to draw your eye across the page. Lighting and shade lay also be used in a similar way.

In the image to the left, the first thing you might see is the tear in the sky. It is the whitest part of the image so they eye is immediately drawn toward it. If we follow the lines of the goal post to the bottom left of the image we can see the cans of Guinness. The cans are also conveniently framed by the legs of the rugby player. The bottom of the cans is lit from below which also draws our attention to, "Open 'em up. The Guinness is great. Official beer of the Irish rugby team".

Juxtaposition



Juxtaposition:

1. an act or instance of placing close together or side by side, esp. for comparison or contrast.
2. the state of being close together or side by side.

In images juxtaposition means the relation of one element to another. If a woman is juxtaposed with a warm, inviting kitchen we would read that differently to an image where a woman is juxtaposed with an high powered boardroom.

The way we interpret an image also relies on the meanings different elements have in relation to one another.

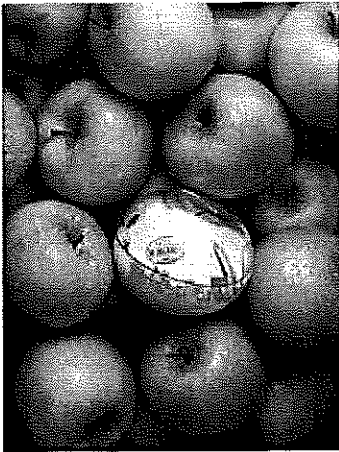
Look at the images below. How does the juxtapositioning effect your interpretation of each relationship?



Notice how you interpret the proximity of the same people differently depending on the context of the image. Both images show a group of boys next to a man, or men. In the first image, we interpret this grouping as 'family'. The boys are dressed and arranged in the style of a family portrait and the body language (hands on shoulders, knees touching) adds to this interpretation. In the second image there are 12 boys and 2 men, therefore our interpretation is most likely 'team'. The context; cricket whites, the bat and shin pads, the number of boys, men who are likely coaches, support

the cricket notion. The body language, arms crossed, hands on knees also supports the idea that it is a team photo rather than a portrait.

Colour



Colour has a great impact upon our viewing. As viewers we must determine which of the colours is most dominant. Is there is something in the image which then becomes more dominant, or important, as a result of being represented in this way? Consider the symbolic use of colour. What effect does an image have if it is in black and white? Consider the idea that not all black and white images are taken this way because the photographer simply couldn't afford colour, or the technology wasn't invented at the time. Often black and white images require the viewer to focus on shapes and textures rather than colour.

Lighting



The way light is used in an image may result in some images being cast into shadow and some being highlighted. Light can increase the importance of an element or character. Shadows can be used to create an atmosphere of danger or suspicion. Lighting will, more often than not, affect your response to characters and other elements.

Look at the lighting in the image to the right. What interpretation is encouraged here by the shadows cast upon this character's face?

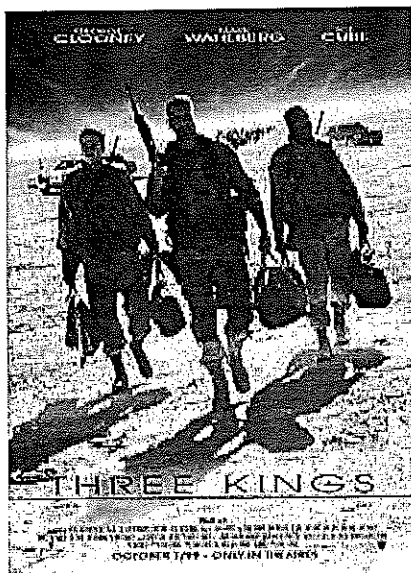
Symbolism



The objects in an image may have symbolic meanings in addition to their functional meanings. For example an apple is food (functional), but also love, desire, temptation and knowledge (symbolic).

[Click here for more information on symbols.](#)

Costume and make-up



Clothing can suggest much about a character or person within an image. Look for outfits which either reinforce or challenge particular gender roles. For example; a woman wearing a feminine outfit, like an evening gown, shows that she conforms to the ideas surrounding gender expectations of women. If she is wearing a tuxedo instead she might be seen to challenge the expectations of her gender.

Uniforms also indicate something about the wearer. Soldiers and police officers wear a distinctive uniform which encourages a reading of power and control.

Make-up can be used in several different ways. Most commonly it is used to enhance the features of a female character or subject. Thick lips and long lashes emphasise femininity and reinforce a woman's adherence to gender expectations.

Make-up can also be used for effect or to create characters who otherwise couldn't exist. Scroll back to the image of 'the Joker'. Make-up is used to create this psychotic character and enhance his malevolent and violent nature. His make-up is not applied accurately and suggests that this character might be unhinged.

Props



Props can also be considered symbols. Look at the image from *Three Kings* above; the men possess guns which indicates their control of the situation. A woman holding a gun might be seen to break the gender stereotypes associated with women and she may take on more masculine qualities.

The image of film character 'Domino', played by Kiera Knightly, to the right shows a female character in possession of a gun and ammunition. She appears to be confident and relaxed around this kind of weapon, however, she still wears make-up so, doesn't lose her femininity entirely.

Body language, gestures and facial expression



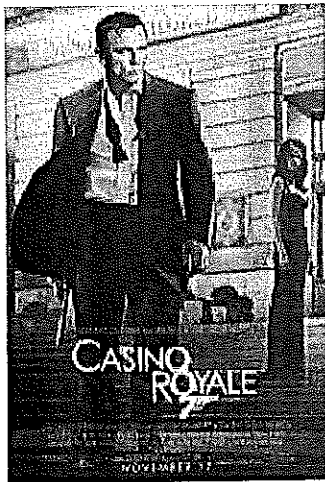
People presented in images and their posture or gestures will often provide some meaning for the reader. Posture will tell the reader much about a character and their possible role. If a character or person is standing upright, perhaps with their chin slightly raised, exuding confidence, we can assume that this person is dominant and has much of the power in the image. Look for body language which suggests a power relationship, or a relationship of equality, like the one to the left.

Gestures are mainly the domain of the hands which indicate a person's thoughts and feelings. They may be self-directed, like grooming or touching the face, or they may be directed at others, like slapping someone on the back or shaking a fist in rage.

You interpret facial expressions all the time probably without even knowing it. A smile, a quivering lip or a frown are easy ways of discerning how someone is feeling about a particular issue or situation. You might also consider the **gaze** of the person or character in an image. If someone is looking out of the frame it might suggest that they are deep in thought, disinterested in what is happening within the image and perhaps preoccupied with something we cannot see as a viewer. If the person is looking confidently and directly at us, we may feel confronted by the person within the image. If a person's body language suggests vulnerability, they may look at us but cover themselves in shame, embarrassment or try to protect themselves from our gaze.

For more information on the gaze, [click here](#).

Action

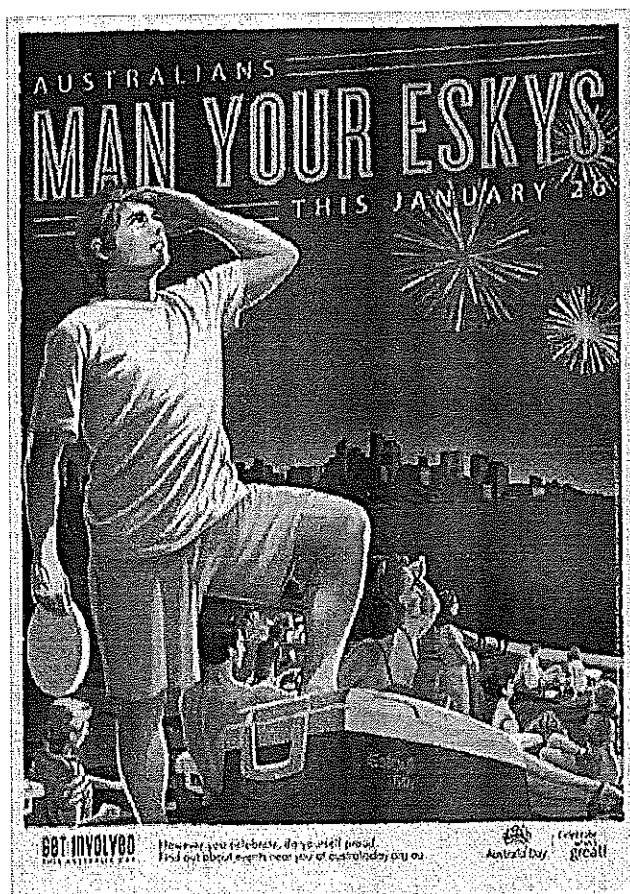


Action is fairly easy to interpret in film, but still images can also *imply* action. Even though still images are precisely that, still, they are able to capture a moment in time and it is up to the reader to suggest what may have happened before or after this image.

The image of James Bond to the right is a still image; however, there is a sense of movement as Bond walks towards the camera. There is a certain determination in his gait and his facial expression suggests he is on some kind of mission. His gun is at the ready and his jacket is flowing also, suggesting movement and a sense of direction.

Written codes

Just because you are analysing the visual elements of a text doesn't mean you should completely discount the written codes. Often the written text within an image will give you a deeper insight into its purpose or meaning. Consider the written codes evident on the image for Australia Day viewed above.



Australian's indicates inclusivity. It suggests that everyone who is Australian should be involved in this celebration. **Man your eskys** is a play on words. Men in the military are often ordered to 'man your battle stations', indicating that Australia has fought for its freedom. It also links strongly to the ANZAC spirit and the image of the man reinforces this idea. This is interesting as it excludes women, either deliberately or not and suggests that Australia is a patriarchy. **Get involved this Australia Day**. Again the call to be involved in this celebration is reiterated. It is very important that

we show our patriotism.

However you celebrate, do yourself proud. Australia Day is all about being proud of our fine nation, the man saluting to the sky complements this idea. It also subtly reminds Australians, who are very fond of drinking, to take it easy with the booze. 'Do yourself proud' ie: don't do anything stupid because you're drunk.

Celebrate what's great! By the time we get to this I think it's pretty clear how the creator, or whoever commissioned the advertisement, feels about Australia. The exclamation mark further reinforces the enthusiasm surrounding this notion.

As you can see, the written conventions wholeheartedly support the visual conventions and provide support for any argument you may provide about the elements of the image

John Pilger Interview: White Australians Would Like Aboriginal People to Disappear

Sunday, 18 January 2015 00:00 By Mark Karlin



John

Pilger (right) working on the documentary *Utopia*. (Photo: Bullfrog Films)

Noted journalist John Pilger directed and is the lead investigator in an extraordinary documentary, *Utopia: An Epic Story of Struggle and Resistance*.

Pilger incisively and tenaciously reveals the brutal conquest and continued racist treatment of the Aboriginal people in Australia. Against this appalling historical documentation of conquest, discriminating and neglect, Pilger also highlights the continued resistance of the original inhabitants of the land stolen by British settlers.

You can obtain the 2-disc DVD set now with a contribution to Truthout by [clicking here](#).

The following is a Truthout interview with John Pilger about *Utopia*.

Mark Karlin: Needless to say, one understands the irony of titling the film *Utopia* from very near the beginning of the documentary. Can you provide some details about the town and area and what you show of its abject neglect in the film?

John Pilger: The irony of *Utopia* isn't mine. It's the name given a vast, forbidding expanse of Australia's north by the British. What did they imagine? Perhaps, demented by the ferocity of the heat and dust, they intended to turn it into an English garden. More realistically, they understood that great wealth lay beneath the land. Certainly, their disregard for the people who had lived there for thousands of years - arguably the longest continuous human community - was typical of the attitudes that came with the colonial invasion of Australia. The indigenous people were at one with the harshness of the land; they knew where to find water and food; this was their physical and cultural home.

For more than two centuries, white Australians have tried to expel them - they've driven them into fringe camps, corralled them in reserves, stolen their children, imposed cruel and petty rules. Denied basic services most Australians take for granted, the people of *Utopia* suffer the kind of deprivation and disease associated with Africa; for example, Aboriginal children go blind from trachoma, a preventable disease eradicated in many third world countries. White Australia would like them to disappear; the First Australians not only refuse to disappear, they resist, often heroically.

There were so many horrifying details of daily life in *Utopia*, but I couldn't help but become physically queasy when a person charged with trying to improve life at the settlement talked about commonly finding cockroaches in the ears of aboriginal people. How did you react to this revelation?

Yes, that's not uncommon. Many of the children in these communities suffer from otitis media, an ear infection that leads to deafness. It's a disease of extreme poverty. You ask about my reaction. As one born and brought up in Australia, my reaction is always a mixture of anger and shame.

Can you provide us with some historical context to the conquest of the Aboriginal people in what is now known as Australia Day and how to this day the nation of Australia has not acknowledged the native ownership of the continent by First Nations' peoples?

On January 26, 1788, a British naval fleet of ships, known as the First Fleet, dropped anchor in what is now Sydney Harbor. Australia was to be a penal colony following Britain's loss of its American colonies. The poor, the petty criminal, the rebellious of England and Ireland would be sent to the end of the earth - my great-great grandparents were among them, convicted of 'uttering unlawful oaths.'

The victims soon included the native people, whose land was appropriated. Indigenous people all over the world share a common suffering as a result of colonialism and immigration. This is not to deny there have been hard-won advances. For example, the High Court of Australia has acknowledged "Native Title" - prior ownership - but it's a paper recognition over which the great mining companies operate an effective veto.

You offer excellent interviews with Australian government officials who claim that it is - more or less - "a new day" for Aboriginal people in the nation, but your film directly disproves those assertions. Were you surprised at their brazen assertions?

No, I am never surprised by the lies and cynicism of those who watch over the designs of colonialism - in Australia, anywhere.

Can you briefly describe the so-called "emergency " government intervention that occurred in the "Northern Territory National Emergency Response" under the government of Prime Minister John Howard in 2007? It was so racist and such a cover for government control of Aboriginal land that might have minerals that it represented much of Canberra's mistreatment of the people that they conquered.

This was presented by John Howard as a vote-gaining crusade to "save" indigenous children from pedophiles in their communities, which were said to be operating in "unthinkable" numbers. It was a political con on such a scale that I suspect it could have happened only in Australia. The principal allegations were found to be baseless by the Northern Territory Police, the National Crime Commission, the Central Australian medical specialists' association, even by the author of a report whose recommendations the government claimed it was acting upon. The media played a central, shameful role, as the film reveals.

You spend a good deal of time on the theft of Aboriginal children in a government attempt to integrate them into European-centric culture. This is called the "stolen generation," but you contend the seizure of Aboriginal babies is still occurring, even in hospitals just after they are born, is that right?

Official statistics show that more Aboriginal children are being taken from their families and communities than at any time in Australian history. In the state of New South Wales, 10 percent of indigenous children have been taken, many of them placed with white families and unlikely to see their mothers and communities again. This is assimilation and little different in principle from the crude paternalism of the 19th and 20th century, which, in the infamous words of one official, sought to "breed out the color" of Australia's First People.

Similar to most colonial conquests, the Aboriginal people were considered subhuman, often killed and imprisoned. The lucky ones were just ignored to live, if they could survive, in the arid and beastly hot interior of the nation.

There is another, insidious element. A very small but significant section of Indigenous Australia has been co-opted by white authority - rewarded with education and bureaucratic largesse. This has produced a "transmission" colonial class of the kind that Franz Fanon wrote about and which oversees a divide-and-rule policy that ensures the majority remain at or near the bottom.

In 1901, the first prime minister of Australia, Edmund Barton, led the passage of what became known as "the White Australia Policy." The Immigration Restriction Act 1901 was based on what an Australian MP at the time said: "William McMillan spoke about the desire 'to prevent any alien or servile races from so occupying large territories in Australia, as to mix and interfuse, not merely among themselves, but with our own people.' " (That's a quotation from the Australian Parliament website.) Where does Australia legally stand today, and where does it stand in fact?

The White Australia Policy is long gone; officially, there is no race discrimination in Australia. Certainly, in my lifetime the composition of the immigrant society has changed from that of predominately Anglo-Irish to one of the most multicultural in the world. Yet, racism runs like a current through much of Australia. Ask any indigenous person. They will often describe what amounts to a human contempt for them, for the truth of their past and their culture. At the very least, many Australians display an invincible ignorance of the one human feature of their country that is unique: the original people.

You have a segment in the film where you interview white Australians celebrating the nation's birthday. The range of responses to you asking the party-goers about the conquered indigenous population ranges from befuddlement to outrage at your question. From that random sample, the plight of the Aboriginal people appears to be a topic that spoils the fun, doesn't it?

That's a concise way of putting it.

You've done other documentaries on the plight of the aborigines, the racist superciliousness and indifference of the Euro-centric descendants, and the utter blighted existences of most aborigines. Has anything changed over the years that you have been covering this racial discrimination in your native Australia?

Australia remains a vivid expression of the way colonial power - from the 18th century to the present-day - regards and treats those whose land it steals. I made a film about the Native Americans, and the similarities are striking. My own belief is that until we, the colonizers and the immigrants, give back the nationhood of those whose lives our forebears so disrupted and destroyed, we can never claim our own.

Mark Karlin

Mark Karlin is the editor of BuzzFlash at Truthout. He served as editor and publisher of BuzzFlash for ten years before joining Truthout in 2010. BuzzFlash has won four Project Censored Awards. Karlin writes a commentary five days a week for BuzzFlash, as well as articles (ranging from the failed "war on drugs" to reviews relating to political art) for Truthout. He also interviews authors and filmmakers whose works are featured in Truthout's Progressive Picks of the Week. Before linking with Truthout, Karlin conducted

interviews with cultural figures, political progressives and innovative advocates on a weekly basis for ten years. He authored many columns about the lies propagated to launch the Iraq War.

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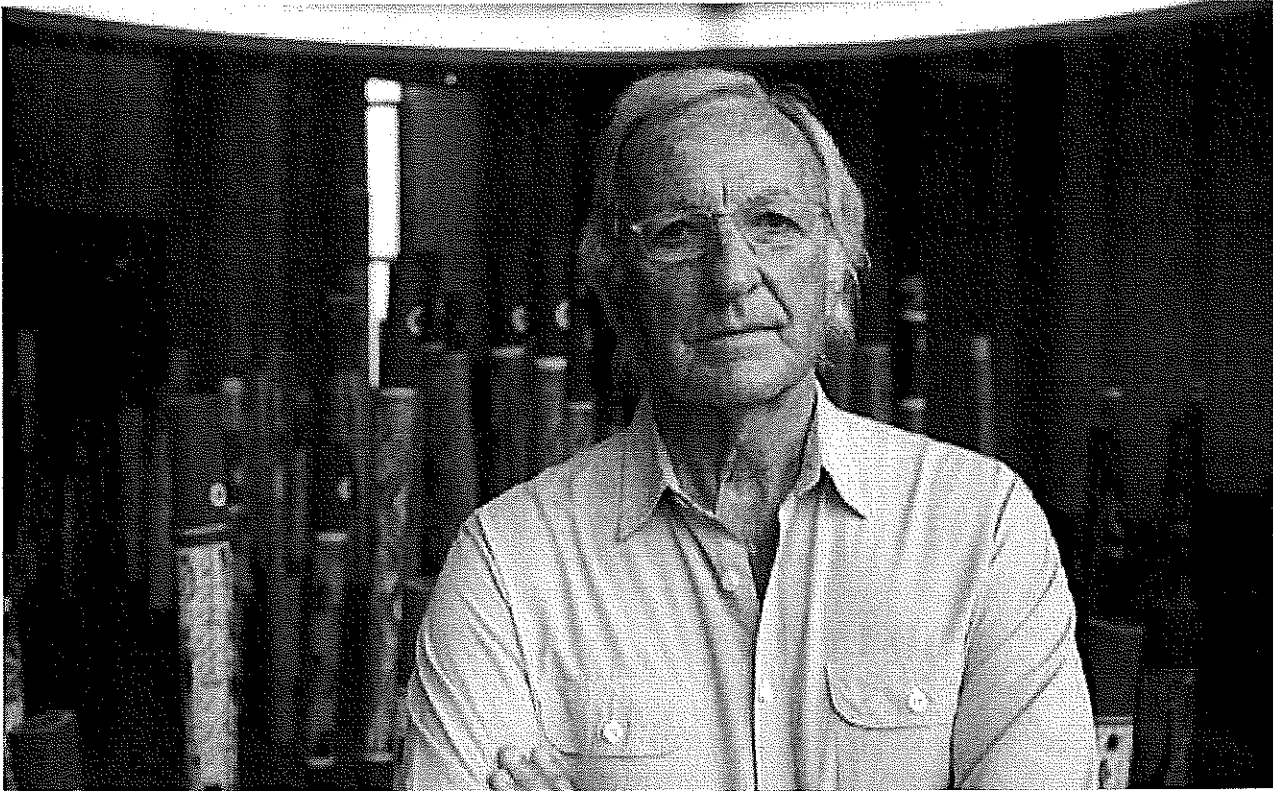
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John Pilger, Utopia

5 November, 2013 | By Andreas Wiseman



Veteran journalist and BAFTA-winning filmmaker John Pilger returns to the screen with new documentary *Utopia*, about the plight of indigenous Australians.

Pilger, who has reported discrimination against Australia's first people since the 1970s, describes his new film as "a journey into a secret country" describing "not only the uniqueness of the first Australians, but their trail of tears and betrayal and resistance – from one utopia to another."

Interviewees include Aboriginal leaders, human-rights campaigners, academics and politicians, among them former prime minister John Howard.

Never one to shy away from controversy, the film will be released in Australia on Australia Day (or 'invasion day', as Pilger also calls it) and will play at indigenous festivals including Sydney's Yabun Festival.

Executive producer Christopher Hird of Dartmouth Films, also producer of Pilger's last documentary *The War You Don't See*, praised the role of UK distributor Network Releasing in getting the film made: "Utopia would not have been possible without the very, very substantial support of Network."

Utopia is in cinemas Nov 15 and is available on DVD from Dec 2. Dartmouth Films is releasing theatrically in association with Network, which is handling DVD and iTunes.

ITV has UK TV rights and will broadcast in December while SBS will broadcast in Australia.

You say in the film that there is an apartheid taking place in Australia today?

Well, one of my interviewees, the distinguished Aboriginal film producer and actor Patricia Morton Thomas, made clear that she regarded Australia as an apartheid society and that's the view of most

indigenous people I've spoken to. As she said, the signs may not say whites or blacks only but that was never the essence of apartheid in South Africa. The divisions were always economic, cultural and in many respects simply race-based, and that's all true in Australia.

And it's something that you personally believe?

Apartheid is a very potent African word, which literally means separate development. That was the euphemism used in South Africa. It was a word and policy that distinguished the majority from the controlling minority. That's reversed in Australia - it's a controlling majority and an outcast minority.

The point of the film is that there are two worlds. One is the world in which people have a very good life, a very good material life. For example, according to one recent report, Australia was declared the richest country in the world. That material life is assured for the majority, not all, but the majority.

That majority conforms to a particular ideology, to which most of the indigenous people of Australia do not conform. Some of them do, of course, but the people I filmed in remote areas do not. The word 'reconciliation' is used in Australia, and really that means come over to us and be like us.

Is Australia unique in the way it treats its indigenous communities?

I don't think it's unique at all. I think indigenous people are treated in a very similar way in all those societies that have been colonized. The United States, Canada, South America, New Zealand, certainly South Africa, there's a similarity in all those cases in the aggressive take over that colonialism always presents to indigenous people.

What makes Australia unique was highlighted in a good report by an academic, professor Paul Kauffman, in which he compared all the western societies that have indigenous populations, and found that all indicators put Australia last. The reason for that is that Aboriginal people have never had a treaty. They never had the very basic right, the very basic mechanism to negotiate their own way of life and the right to live differently.

But also the right to share the natural riches and opportunities in a country like Australia. The first British settlers in Australia declared the country an empty land. They simply eradicated the very reality before their eyes. And that was built into the Australian legal system. It was only in the 1990s that that notion was overturned and there have been limited land rights for Australia's first people.

In the Northern Territory it was almost an accident that indigenous people were given land rights. Successive governments have tried to call those rights back because of the mining opportunities in the area. It has enormous deposits of uranium and is considered a very materially valuable part of Australia.

Governments don't want to negotiate with the indigenous people, who quite rightly want a part of the spoils, yes, but more than that they want to live in the way they want to, to express their difference. And it's that difference that is not acceptable.

The film lays bare how Aborigines' belief-system made them easy prey for the colonists...

The nature of Aboriginal people is very attractive. I'm not romanticising them, but it's a very inclusive nature. It's quite trusting, it's wise and it's very confident.

It has a confidence that westerners find difficult to understand, the confidence in being at one with your surroundings and with life.

When the first invaders arrived - before a lot of the Aboriginal people got together and started fighting them, and they really did fight them - they would often welcome them because they had no concept of anyone arriving taking land because the land didn't belong to anybody.

What surprised you most when making the film?

I'm not too surprised by many things these days, especially the imposition of power on vulnerable people. I suppose I was surprised at the level of enduring cynicism that is expressed in the way Australian government treat aboriginal people.

I was surprised at the way that arcane, self-perpetuating bureaucracy is still imposed on Aboriginal people. They are trapped in a maze of bureaucracy. During the famous 'intervention' the Government spent something like 40 million dollars on inventing a way of controlling about 30 thousand people.

They invented something called a BasicsCard, which to me was an equivalent to a South African Pass Book. It meant you had to shop in certain shops and you could pay your bills on this card. It was a means of controlling you. And this basics card cost millions for controlling a very, very small number of people.

So they invented that rather than dealing with the basic poverty in these communities. Housing, for example.

One of the things I would have liked to have had in the film, which was in it originally, was an explanation of white industry going for the black dollar.

Aborigines make a lot of money for the white people, billions of dollars actually. There are plenty of white contractors who get government contracts to go and do things in Aboriginal communities, which they do badly. They jerry-build. Whole teams of construction workers are put up in hotels to build a couple of poorly erected houses.

You said at one point that there was rape by early white Australians of Aboriginal children but you didn't go into it in any detail or evidence of that.

Well, that was the basis of *The Stolen Generation*. It probably needed more explanation, but I think that's a story that's been well and truly told.

The majority of Aboriginal people are mixed race. And many are mixed race because the first settlers, like settlers all over the world in colonial countries, took a lot of the women.

There are well-documented stories of rape of Aboriginal women who were sometimes tethered outside work camps.

How much sympathy do you think there will be for the film in Australia?

I don't think sympathy is the word. As somebody said to me recently: 'There's no out in this film'. And that pleases me because it gives an Australian audience no out. The film is obviously made primarily for the Australian audience. What they do with it is entirely up to them, but of course there will be plenty of discussion and debate.

I think the last thing Aboriginal people want is sympathy, frankly. I think they need action. Though people in the film do invite sympathy, there are also inspiring stories. Arthur Murray is one example [after Murray's son died in police custody, both Murray and his wife become vocal campaigners for change]. There have been great acts of resistance [some are touched on in the film].

There is a kind of wilful indifference in Australia to this issue. There is a lot of blame of the victims: 'Ah, we're always throwing money at them and they're always drunk, they're scroungers...' You get a sense of that from the vox pops in the film.

Not everyone thinks that, there are a lot people who really believe there should be justice for Aboriginal people, but they haven't made their voices heard politically.

You have been documenting this struggle for decades. What change would you most like to see next?

One word: treaty. That's the beginning.

Offered by the government...

Yes, but it also has to be accepted. It has to be constitutional; it has to be built into the very fabric of Australia's laws and it has to be achieved through genuine negotiation and consultation. At the moment Aborigines have no power within the framework of modern Australia. It's patronage, co-option and hand-outs. Nothing really will change until there's a treaty.

I was surprised not to see the film at the London Film Festival...

Well, I was asked. But I decided I'd prefer to show it at the old NFT, the BFI. I prefer my films to stand alone. The LFF is an excellent festival, but I've always shown my films at the NFT.

What's next for you?

I've got a collection of books that I'm working on and I've got another film in mind. It will touch on WikiLeaks and Julian Assange. We'll probably make that next year.

Utopia is in cinemas Nov 15 and is available on DVD from Dec 2

Dartmouth Films is releasing theatrically in association with Network, which is handling DVD and iTunes.

Oscar-nominated HIV documentary *How to Survive a Plague* is released by Dartmouth Films in the UK this week.

<http://www.sbs.com.au/movies/blog/2014/05/30/why-you-should-watch-utopia>

Utopia is a deeply ironic title for John Pilger's documentary, which tackles Australian racism head on. Watch it now.



By

Sandy George

30 May 2014 - 11:17 AM UPDATED 20 Mar 2015 - 12:06 PM4

It is shocking

Utopia says many shocking things in support of its central argument that Australia is completely failing its indigenous citizens. The most shocking is that within this group of Australians almost one in three die before the age of 45. I want to ask: "Isn't that grounds for the declaration of a national emergency?" But some will argue that's exactly what "the intervention" by the Federal Government in 2007 was all about. But all was not what it seemed according to *Utopia*.

Acceptance is a good thing

I've watched *Utopia* three times in the last few months and each time it left me feeling gutted by what feels like an overwhelming truth: that chronic racism is one of mainstream Australian society's intrinsic characteristics. Pre-*Utopia*, in my mind, overt racism was something of the past not the present. I now accept that I live in a country that has a gigantic blind spot about its deep-seated racism. If the first step towards fixing a problem is recognition that a problem exists, then the value of this documentary is inestimable. But only if it is seen widely so please gather up your friends and family and make a night of it.

Heed the messages

These days many Australians seem to use any excuse to enter into a public brawl rather than engage in constructive debate, which is why I can't get rid of the niggling worry that many viewers won't be affected by *Utopia* like I've been because of its polemic style. Filmmaker John Pilger is an indisputably fearless, award-winning journalist who has spent his career tackling important issues, but his take-no-prisoners style and the sarcasm that particularly surfaces during his interviews with politicians, may make some viewers retaliate in kind. (Personally I think his attitude is understandable given that he believes things have worsened since he made *The Secret Country*, which had similar themes, in 1985.) My main point is this: please engage with the message not the nature of its presentation.

Take the advice of Adam Goodes

If I've not convinced you to watch *Utopia*, please read [this](#). It is a response to the documentary by Australian of the Year, AFL player for the Sydney Swans and Andjambatha/Narungga man Adam Goodes. He says the film should be required viewing for every Australian.

Watch Utopia now:

'Utopia' by John Pilger

The important movie "Utopia" by the outstanding expatriate Australian humanitarian journalist John Pilger exposes the horrendous circumstances of the Indigenous (Aboriginal) Australians. The following review summarizes the main points raised in "Utopia" and in doing so attempts to quantify and document these horrendous abuses of the ongoing Aboriginal Genocide by what John Pilger describes as Apartheid Australia.

Before detailing the substance of this important movie, it is useful to summarize the main features of the ongoing Australian Aboriginal Genocide and Aboriginal Ethnocide. Before the British Invasion in 1788, Indigenous Australians had been living in Australia for about 60,000 years. There were 350-750 different tribes and a similar number of languages and dialects, of which only 150 survive today and of these all but about 20 are endangered. After the brutish British Invasion, the Aboriginal population dropped from about 1 million in 1788 to about 0.1 million in the first century through introduced disease, deprivation and genocidal violence.

The last massacres of Aborigines occurred in the 1920s but no Treaty has ever been signed. Indigenous Australians were only counted after a referendum in 1967 and were finally given some protection by the 1975 Racial Discrimination Act. In the 20th century up to 1 in 10 Aboriginal children were forcibly removed from their mothers, the so-called Stolen Generations. In 2000 about 9,000 Aborigines out of an Aboriginal population of 500,000 died avoidably every year but this had declined to about 2,000 annual avoidable deaths out of a population about 670,000 by 2011. Indigenous Australians are far worse off than White Australians in relation to housing, health, wealth, social conditions, imprisonment, avoidable death and life expectancy [1-4].

There is an ongoing Australian Aboriginal Genocide and Aboriginal Ethnocide, noting that "genocide" is defined by Article 2 of the UN Genocide Convention as "any of the following acts committed with intent to destroy, in whole or in part, a national, ethnic, racial or religious group, as such: a) Killing members of the group; b) Causing serious bodily or mental harm to members of the group; c) Deliberately inflicting on the group conditions of life calculated to bring about its physical destruction in whole or in part; d) Imposing measures intended to prevent births within the group; e) Forcibly transferring children of the group to another group."

Javier Sethness-Castro comments in relation to "intent" in relation to the related phenomenon of "climate genocide" that similarly arises from racist First World greed and depraved indifference: "Dominant relations can hence be characterized as governed by what Chomsky calls "depraved indifference" to human life. Australian scientist Gideon Polya has termed the current situation "climate genocide", while Bangladeshi climatologist Atiq Rahman similarly labels it "climatic genocide". The phrases are accurate if the word genocide is to be understood as murder of persons belonging to particular classes and social groups, as originally formulated by Raphael Lemkin, the concept's inventor. If the definition is extended to membership or residence in particular geographic regions – a collective of sorts – the term fits better, even if the question of intent for such eventualities is left unresolved: Under the internationally accepted definition, acts of genocide occur only if governed by conscious intent. Against this view, Chomsky is right to suggest that those concerned with such problems focus on "predictable outcome as evidence for intent". Not to work to undermine global capitalism is effectively to be complicit with the genocide of southern peoples. Jean-Paul Sartre put it well in a statement he issued as president of the International War Crimes Tribunal on Vietnam: "The genocidal intent is implicit in the facts. It is not necessarily premeditated." [5]. It is clear that the knowing, deliberate introduction of disease, dispossession, deprivation, massacres, ethnocide, and forced removal of children were (a) realities for the conquered Indigenous Australians, and (b) knowingly intentional as are the continuing Aboriginal Genocide and Aboriginal Ethnocide today in an Apartheid Australia [1].

Finally, one notes that a politically correct racist (PC racist) racist White Australia has extensive Apartheid policies applied not just to its Indigenous subjects but also variously to non-Indigenous and overseas Australian subjects as detailed by Gideon Polya [6] and by John Pilger [7].

"A picture says a thousand words" and, as outlined below, the movie "Utopia" by John Pilger provides a shocking account of the appalling Aboriginal living conditions and the unforgivable maltreatment of Aboriginal Australians by one of the world's richest countries (my comments below are given in parentheses).

1. The movie begins with video footage of the late mining magnate Lang Hancock making the seriously genocidal suggestion that drinking water should be doctored to sterilize Aborigines unable or unwilling to assimilate (this was an explicit, racist call for Aboriginal Genocide and Aboriginal Ethnocide).
2. We are then confronted with appalling, dirty, crowded, unhygienic, worse-than-Third-World living conditions of Aborigines in "Utopia" in the Northern Territory of Australia in makeshift humpies or derelict housing that would be condemned in White Australia (these conditions - that greatly saddened and angered great African-American singer and humanist Paul Robeson on his visit to Australia in 1960 - are still prevalent).
3. The appalling Aboriginal health conditions and differential life expectancy linked to poverty and crowded housing are revealed and contrasted with luxury Australian holiday accommodation for \$30,000 per week (currently Aboriginal health problems are variously 2- 7 times higher than for White Australia and male and female life expectancies are 12 and 10 years less, respectively, than for White Australian.², 000 Indigenous Australians die avoidably every year [1, 4]. John Pilger: "In the town of Wilcannia, New South Wales, the life expectancy of Aboriginal people is 37 — lower than the Central African Republic, perhaps the poorest country on Earth, currently racked by civil war" [7]).
4. "Utopia" reveals the scandal of how a public servant made incorrect and horrifying assertions about child sexual abuse in Northern Territory Aboriginal communities that were broadcast by the ABC TV Lateline program. These incorrect assertions led to a media frenzy that horribly defamed Indigenous Australians and ultimately led to a military invasion of Northern Territory Aboriginal communities and removal of Northern Territory Aborigines from the protection of the 1975 Racial Discrimination Act (a subsequent expert report entitled "Little Children Are Sacred" found (p57) that "it is not possible to accurately estimate the extent of child sexual abuse in the Northern Territory's Aboriginal communities", while reporting (p235) that 34% of Australian women and 16% of men have been subject to sexual abuse as children [8], a matter scrupulously ignored by PC racist Mainstream media in Australia).
5. "Utopia" reveals from a health and welfare perspective that the racist, military intervention in the Northern Territory that was backed by the 2 major political groups, the Liberal –National Party Coalition and Labor (aka the Lib-Labs or Liberal-Laborals) was not helpful (communities were not consulted and were grossly defamed e.g., by signs have been erected outside "occupied" communities indicating that "pornography" was banned by the Federal Government).
6. "Utopia" reveals that Aborigines are hugely over-represented in Australian prisons (while Aborigines represent 3% of the Australian population they represent about 30% of the Australian prison population [9]).
7. Deaths in custody of Indigenous Australians led to a national inquiry but this tragedy continues. "Utopia" deals movingly with the search for justice for their dead son by an Aboriginal couple (in an appalling example, an Aboriginal leader was literally cooked to death while being transported across hundreds of kilometers of hot desert in an unventilated prison van by staff of the G4S organization that was subsequently involved in running Australia's privatized off-shore concentration camps for refugees).
8. "Utopia" deals with the Stolen Generations and reveals that the rate of removal of Aboriginal children from their mothers is now higher than before the "Sorry" for the Stolen Generations delivered by PM Kevin Rudd to the Australian Federal Parliament in 2008 (one notes that PM Rudd ruled out any compensation and failed to mention "racism" or "genocide" in his apology [10, 11]. Paddy Gibson, University of Technology Sydney: "For each of the last five years, approximately a thousand Aboriginal children have been coming into the 'out-of-home care' system long-term. This is a higher number than were removed during any time in the twentieth century. Half of the children have not been placed with kin or relatives. We are fast approaching the Stolen Generations removal rate cited by Rudd: between 10 and 30 per cent of all Indigenous children. A 2011 annual report from the Department of Family and Community Services found that 9.6 per cent of Aboriginal children in NSW were in out-of-home care. Across Australia, nearly 6 per cent of Indigenous children are in out-of-home care. If current trends continue, the figure will exceed 10 per cent by the end of the decade. While Kevin Rudd was apologizing for the past Aboriginal children were being taken in numbers greater than at any time in the 20th Century" [11]).
9. "Utopia" gets to the heart of Australian indifference to the Aboriginal Genocide with a segment about "Australia Day" that White Australia celebrates as the anniversary of the British Invasion on 26 January 1788 but which Indigenous Australia marks as "Invasion Day". White Australians "patriots" interviewed by

John Pilger come out with the usual Australian indifference and jingoism e.g. "Aussie. Aussie. Aussie, oi, oi, oi", "get a job", and expressions of patriotic disgust (no regard for the extraordinarily complex pre-Invasion Indigenous culture).

10. An extraordinary part of "Utopia" deals with Rottnest Island off the coast of Western Australia where a tourist holiday resort has been created out of what was formerly a deadly 19th century concentration camp for Indigenous Australians (just imagine the outcry if the cell blocks of former Nazi death camps were refitted for luxury tourist accommodation).

11. In "Utopia" John Pilger interviewed many people including ordinary Australians, European and Aboriginal community and health workers, politicians and journalists. In particular he interviewed Chris Graham (former editor of the National Indigenous Times) and researcher Paddy Gibson (who exposed the ongoing creation of the "new", post-"Sorry" Stolen Generation [11]).

12. "Utopia" finally deals with the long-standing issue of Aboriginal land rights that came to prominence with the 1966 walk-off by 200 Aboriginal stockmen, house servants, and their families from the UK Vestey's Wave Hill cattle station on their traditional land as a protest against discriminatory low wages. Australian pastoralists historically used Aborigines as effective slave labor, paying them in tea, flour, sugar and tobacco. In the famous Mabo Decision in June 1992, six months after Eddie "Koiki" Mabo's death, the High Court of Australia upheld his claim that Murray Islanders held native title to land in the Torres Strait and thus struck down the English invaders' claim of Australia as a "terra nullius" ("an empty land"). However John Pilger trenchantly criticized the Hawke Labor Government for not adequately supporting land rights. Thus, according to the Sydney Morning Herald's review of "Utopia": "Pilger reminds the viewer that Bob Hawke in the 1980s walked away from genuine land rights in the face of a racist scare campaign from the mining industry" [12]. (Labor in 2010-2013 similarly walked away from climate change action and budget surpluses in the face of a concerted Mining Industry and Big Business campaign. Labor and Coalition Governments have made provision of decent housing for Northern Territory Indigenous Australians conditional on their leasing their hard-won land. Thus University of Technology Sydney Jumbunna: "Following consistent failure to secure these leases, the Commonwealth compulsorily acquired all Aboriginal township land through the Northern Territory National Emergency Response Act 2007, for a period of five years. This required the suspension of the Racial Discrimination Act 1975" [13]).

Conclusions

John Pilger's "Utopia" is an important, must-see film about the continuing Aboriginal Genocide and Aboriginal Ethnocide by an Apartheid Australia. What can decent people do? Decent people should (a) inform everyone they can, and (b) urge and apply Boycott, Divestment and Sanctions (BDS) against all people, parties, politicians, companies and corporations complicit in this ongoing, genocidal and ethnocide Apartheid Australian maltreatment of Indigenous Australians. We cannot walk by on the other side.

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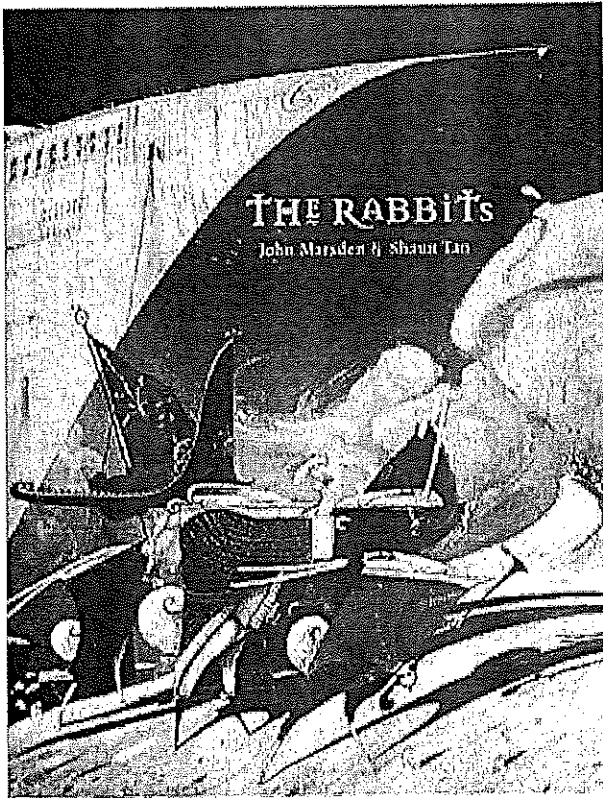
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Allegory and Artwork in John Marsden and Shaun Tan's "The Rabbits"

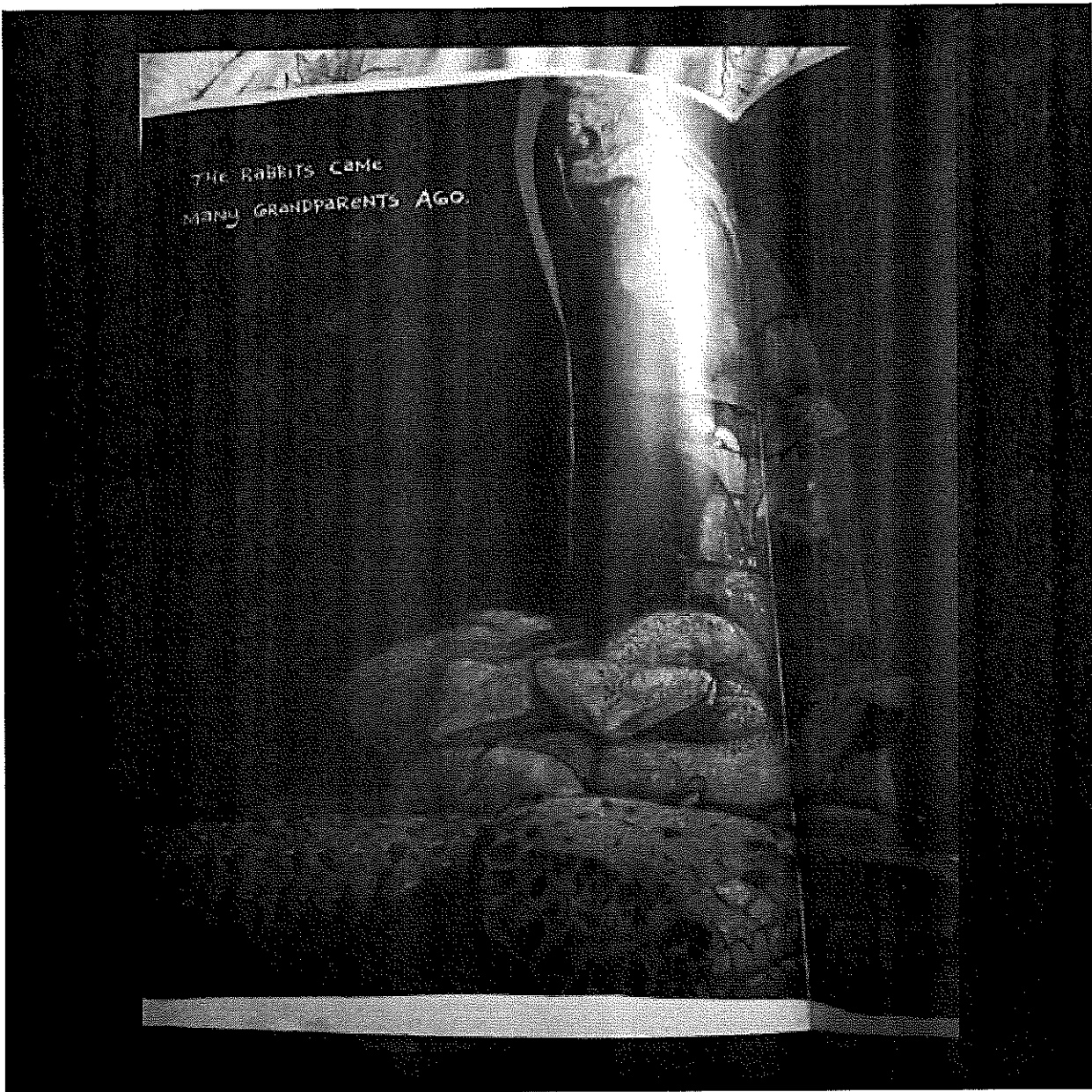
Posted on July 11, 2012 by Myra GB in [Asian Literature and Immigrant Experience](#), [Award-Winning, AWB \(Award-Winning-Books\) 2012](#), [Book Reviews](#), [GB Challenges](#), [GB Reading Themes](#), [Immigrant Stories Challenge 2012](#), [Picture Book Challenge 2012](#), [Picture Books](#), [PoC Reading Challenge 2012](#), [Reading the World 2012](#) // 13 Comments



I didn't realize when we launched our bimonthly theme "Festival of Asian Literature and the Immigrant Experience" – that it would lead me to amazing books such as the one recommended to me by Benjamin Farr from Tanglin Trust School (check out their [library here](#)). I thought I have read all of Shaun Tan's books – apparently I missed out on a few, such as this one.



In most of the books that we have read which dealt with the immigrant experience, too often the stories are written from the perspective of the immigrant, the newcomer, the foreigner in the land. The reader is very seldom privy to what goes on in the heads of the 'natives'.

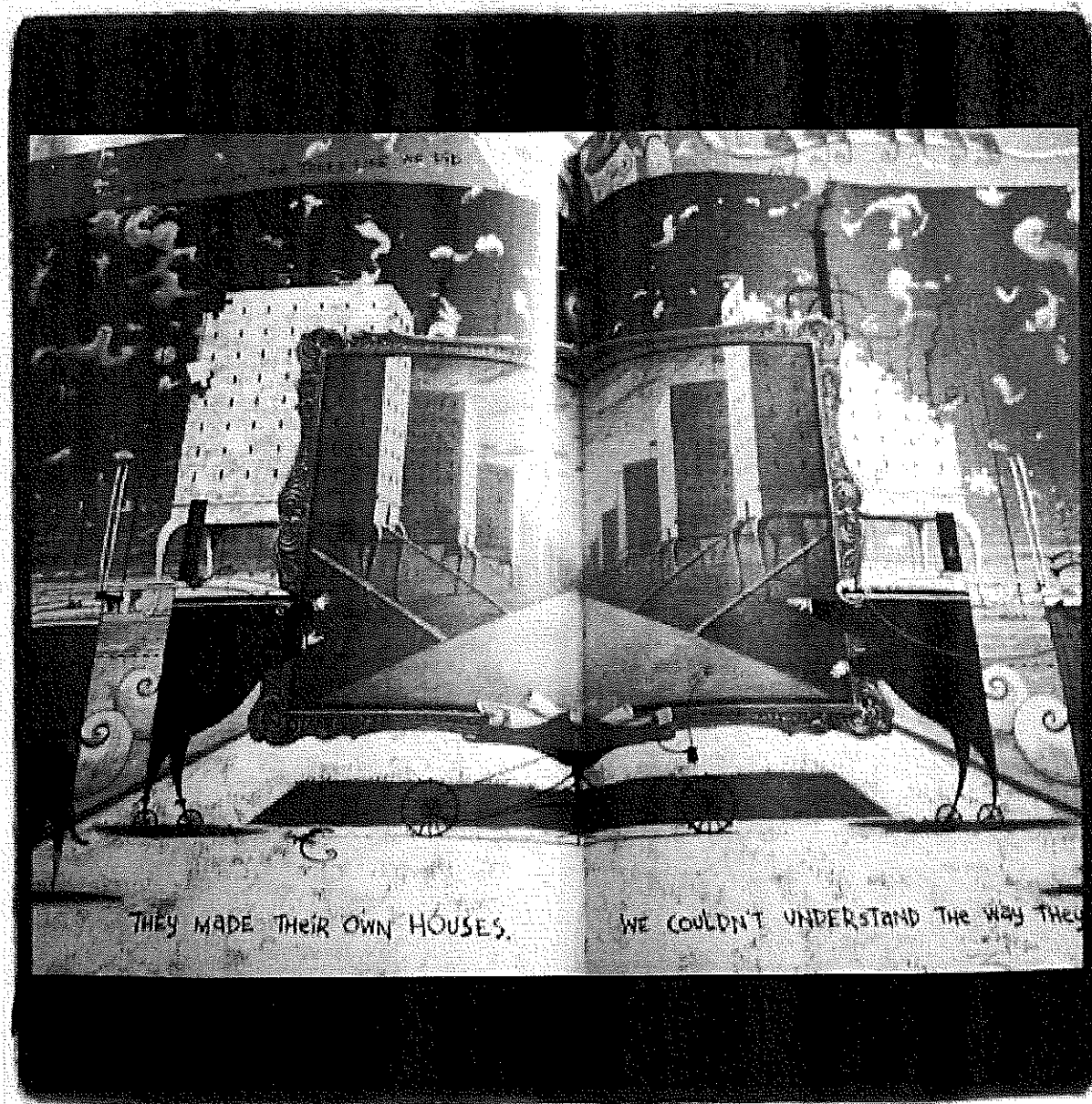


In John Marsden's *The Rabbits* one hears the sharp, no-nonsense, powerful voice of the natives (depicted here as numbats) who regard the 'rabbits' with a measure of distrust, caution, resentment, defeat, despair, and overwhelming sense of disquiet – all spoken in a matter-of-fact tone that pierces one's being to the core.

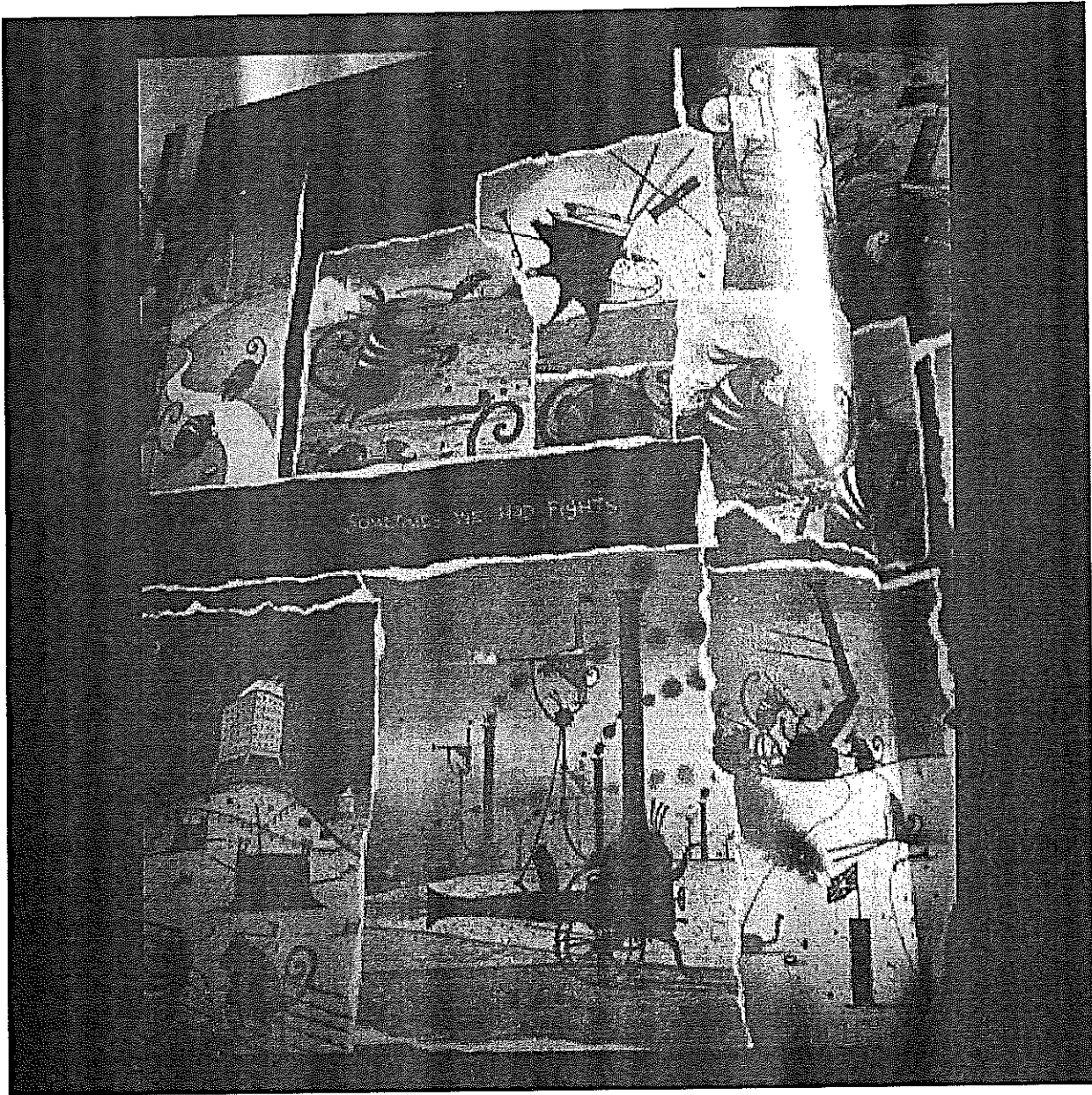
The narrative shows a linear, sequential progression with the rabbits arriving many grandparents ago (as seen in the photo above), and how the "*old people warned us: be careful. They won't understand the right ways*" (see photo below) – to the rabbits slowly coming in by water, then through various means – as they bring new food and other animals – and how they spread across the countries – and the fights, oh, the fights which the numbats lost.



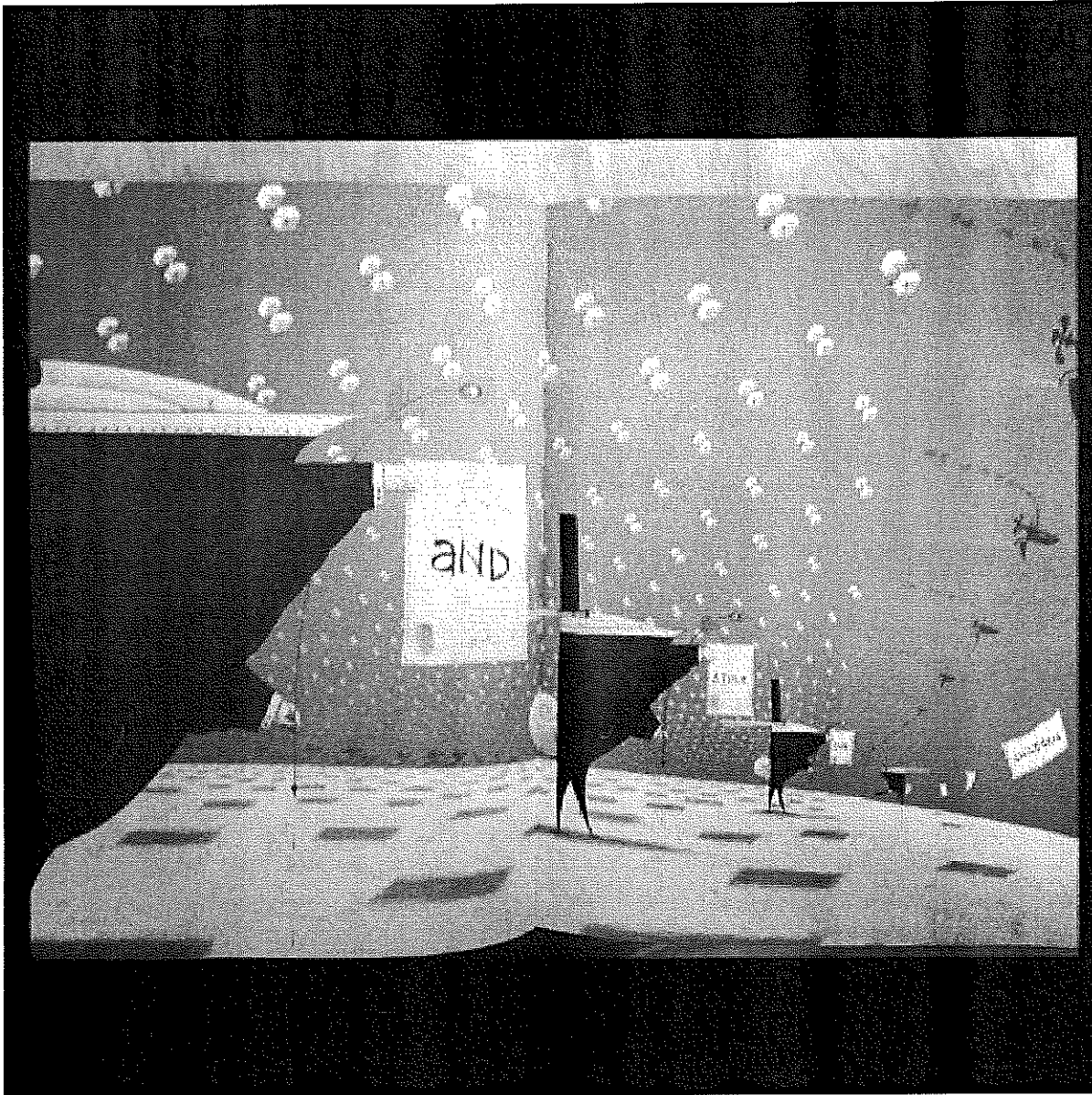
The rabbits after all looked high and mighty with their stiff, starched collars; pointed, upright ears; and their guns, cannons, high-tech weaponry firing in perfect formation – while the numbats carried spears and lived on trees and were subsequently outnumbered and outpowered.



The straightforward, deceptively-simple retelling of Australia's history is matched perfectly by Shaun Tan's amazingly-stunning artwork that complements the narrative with dark black spaces, monochrome illustrations of how the rabbits have overtaken the entire country (*"Rabbits, rabbits, rabbits. Millions and millions of rabbits. Everywhere we look there are rabbits."*), the sepia-toned undercurrents of loss and tragedy,



and the deliciously-surreal representation of all that is right and unjust, pure and sullied, and what it means to stand one's ground (regardless of how shaky and small and crumbling it is). The book is a reminder, as well, of what we value as we cry out in anguish and claim ownership of what is rightfully ours – as one's entire world is overtaken, captured, and judged to be less than what it is. My heart skipped a million beats when I opened this page that made me gasp out loud:



... and stole our children.

I was in Sydney when I watched the film, *Australia*, with Nicole Kidman and Hugh Jackman, and this clear snow-flurried page with the rabbits holding these signs just broke my heart – as it reminded me vividly of the film and the anguish that I witnessed then.



This is one of the most powerful picture books I have read this year. Teachers would have a field day integrating this with their social studies or history class, playing with the metaphors and the allegories, as they struggle to understand history from multiple points of view. For those who want more resources to understand the story line and the allegory better, [here is an incisive scholarly piece](#) by Brooke Collins-Gearing & Dianne Osland as published in *The Looking Glass: New Perspectives on Children's Literature*.

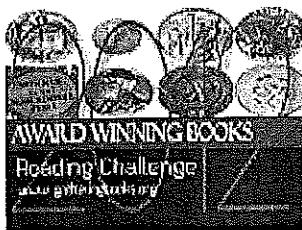
If you are expecting a neat and fine resolution, with all ends deftly tied – then you'd have to think again. I normally don't post spoilers here, since I don't want to ruin the book's experience for you, but I simply can't help but quote this plaintive cry found at the end of the book:

Where is the rich, dark earth, brown and moist? Where is the smell of rain dripping from the gum trees?

Where are the great billabongs alive with long-legged birds?

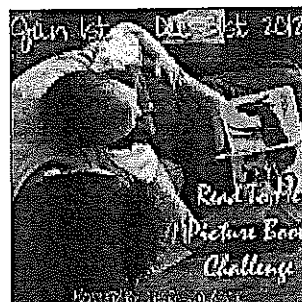
Who will save us from the rabbits?

Here is a video clip from Youtube as inspired by the book. Let me know what you think of it.



Picture Book of the Year – The Children's Book Council of Australia

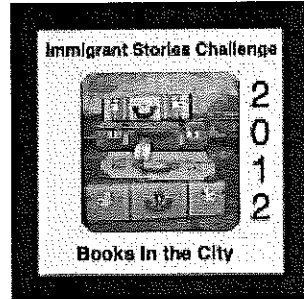
AWB Reading Challenge Update: 65 (35)



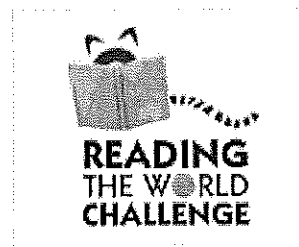
Picture Book Challenge Update: 69 of 120



PoC Reading Challenge Update: 26 (25)



Immigrant Stories Challenge Update: 13 (6)



Reading the World Challenge Update: 5 of 7, nonfiction/allegory, Australia

<http://gatheringbooks.org/2012/07/11/the-rabbits-by-john-marsden-and-shaun-tan/> - this has the youtube links on it

Passionate about picturebooks

Welcome to my blog about picturebooks in ELT.

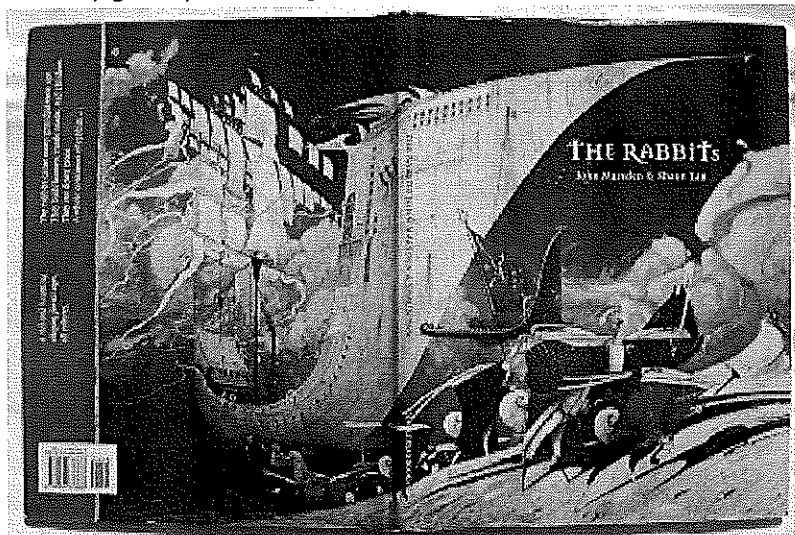
"A picturebook is text, illustrations, total design; an item of manufacture and a commercial product; a social, cultural, historic document; and foremost, an experience for a child. As an art form it hinges on the interdependence of pictures and words, on the simultaneous display of two facing pages, and on the drama of the turning page."
(Barbara Bader 1976:1)

My intention is to discuss picturebooks, in particular the pictures in them! Why? Because, in ELT we tend to select picturebooks because they contain words our students might know. I plan to write something a couple of times a month, sharing what I discover in my readings; describe new titles I come across; discuss particular illustrators and their styles and generally promote the picture in picturebooks.

From January 2008 to December 2011 I benefitted from a PhD research grant from [ECT](#), in Portugal.

Wednesday, March 07, 2012

The rabbits came many grandparents ago



Front and back covers

The Rabbits by [John Marsden](#) and [Shaun Tan](#) is one of those picturebooks that leaves you gaping from a mixture of shock and admiration. It was the third picturebook illustrated by Shaun Tan to reach my bookshelf and to be featured on this blog. I've featured [The Lost Thing](#) and [The red tree](#).

Both Marsden and Tan are Australians and through this picturebook make a very clear statement about cultural awareness, expertly creating an allegorical tale of colonialism. *The Rabbits* has been used in secondary schools since it was published in 1998 in areas of the curriculum that include English, Art and Technology, Philosophy, History, Geography and Environmental Studies. But has it been used in [ELT](#)? Let's see if I can convince the readers of my blog to consider its possibilities.

I've taken a photo of the front and back covers together - the image is so powerful: a huge ship with a pointed, harpoon-like prow. Napoleon-like creatures stalk around on pin legs, we

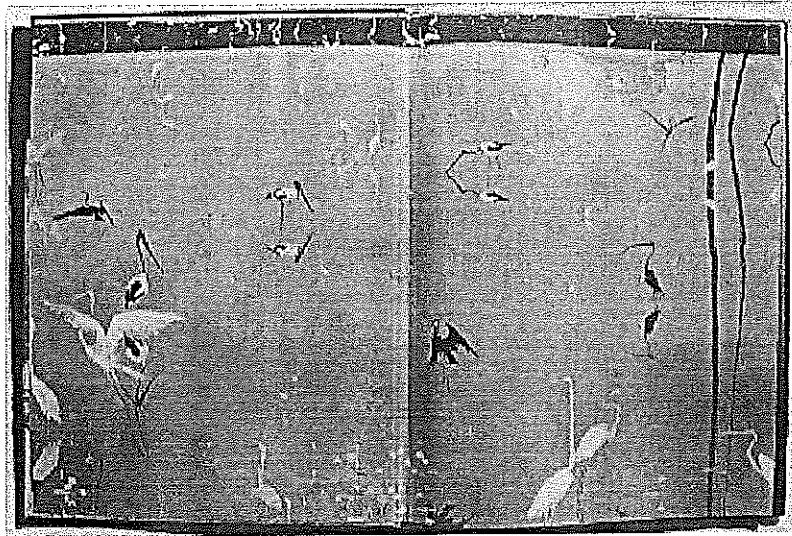
can't quite make out what they are... though from the title they have to be rabbits. That strip of red on the back cover is actually a collage, a piece of red cloth, fraying at the edges. Could it be from the flags? Or from the invader's coat? The words on this fraying piece read:

"The rabbits came many grandparents ago.

They built houses, made roads, had children.

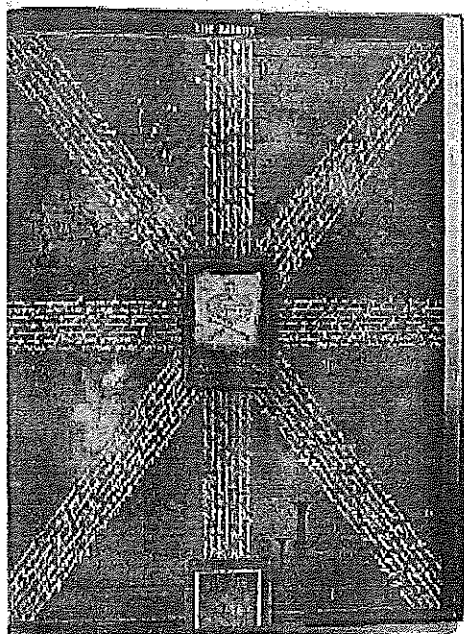
They cut down trees.

A whole continent of rabbits ..."



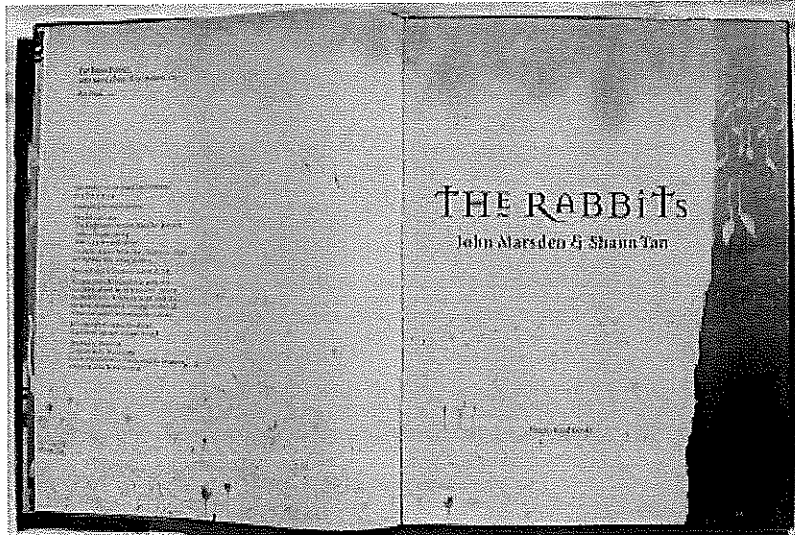
The front endpapers

The endpapers are a calm blue-lilac. Clean water, the home to graceful, long legged birds. What a contrast to the front cover. Is this the land these invaders have arrived at, that they will soon be invading?

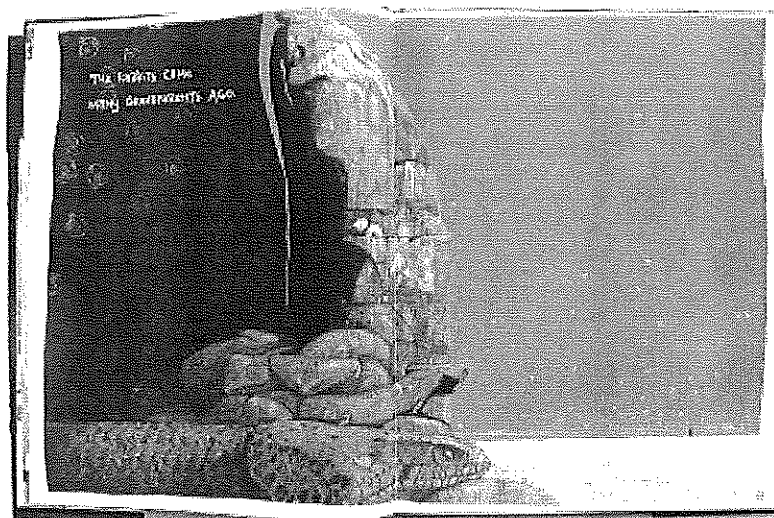


The half title page

The dark brown half title page imitates the format of a well known flag, with pen-inked squiggly writing and some sort of shield in the centre, superimposed over a map. You can peer and peer, but nothing can be discerned or made out.



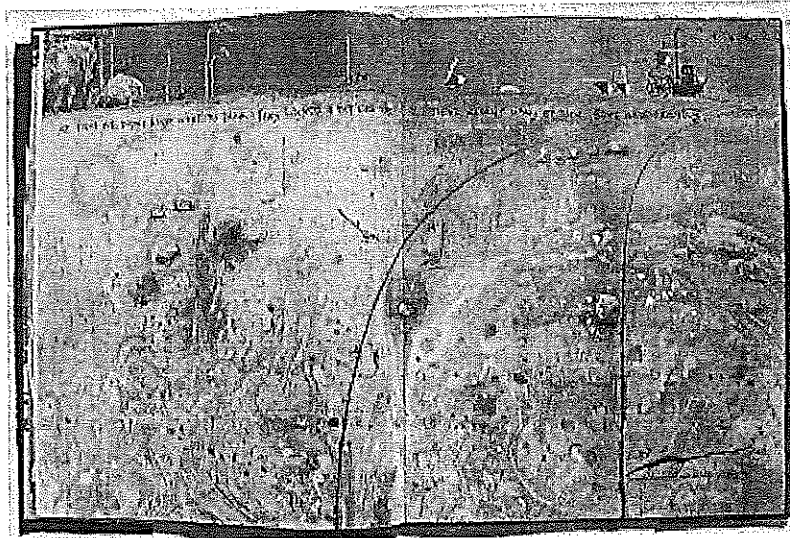
The title page comes next: a ripped sheet of paper, covering that blue-lilac bird-filled lake. We can see that some of the paper has begun to soak up the water, turning the white into a creeping grey, the birds are moving away from us, their backs are turned and they are all looking to the right, they've seen something we can't see yet. The white paper is both a cover as well as a vehicle for the pond life, as flowers are growing from its edges and dragon flies hum towards the dedications. The title font, as on the front cover, is not quite normal, the 'e' has a strange wave under it and the 't' is uncharacteristic. Are these letters from a past, letters that have changed over time to those we know and recognize today?



Opening 1

Opening 1 confirms our haunch, the birds are indeed fleeing, if the book had sound we would hear their calls of alarm, we would hear the snakes hiss in warning. What is that strange black chimney in the horizon? What are the fossil-like shapes in the dark cave behind the snakes? Does Tan want us to think of the time these fossils have taken to form?

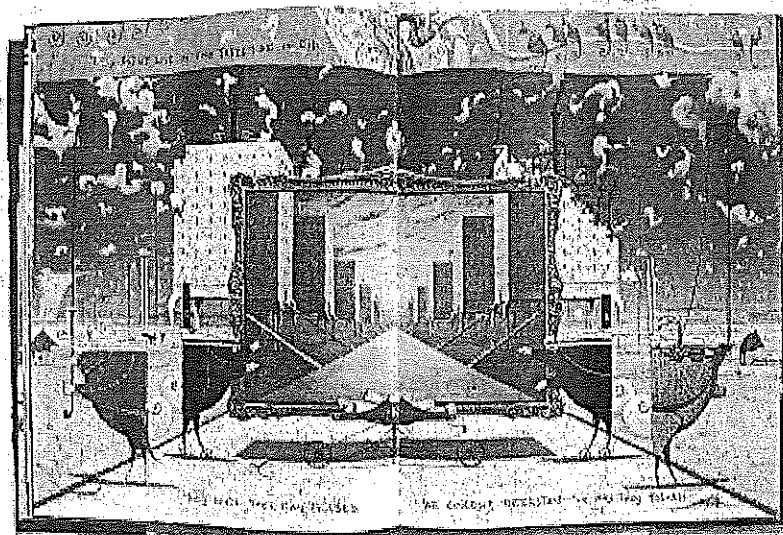
An age-old land. We read an invisible narrator's words, "The rabbits came many grandparents ago".



Opening 2

This illustration is of an immense land, home to tiny creatures, birds and insects. It has been marked by the wheels of a strange machine, which we can just make out on the horizon. Two worlds meet and wonder at each other: "They looked a bit like us ..." they were creatures, they had ears and tails, but they wore clothes and had strange machines... "There weren't many of them. Some were friendly."

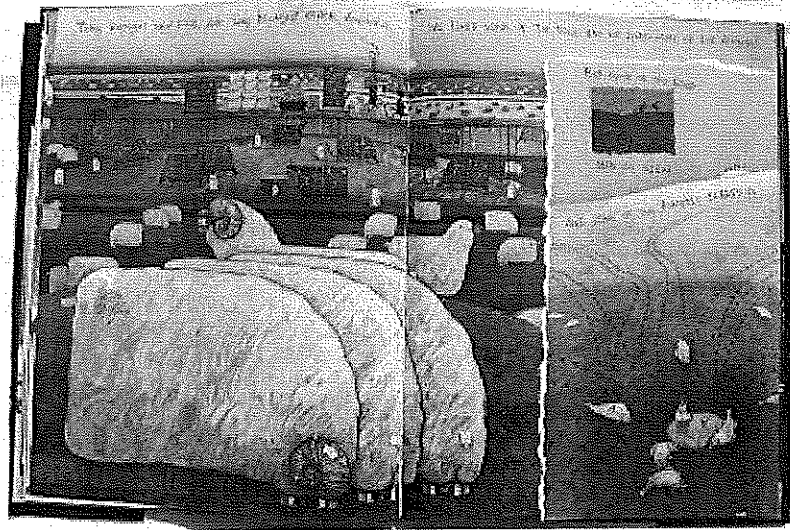
And soon more came, and the old people warned us all... "they came by water." And we see the front and back cover as a spread, even more frightening now as we have begun the story, we know the significance of these strange creatures. We are told and shown how different they are:



Opening 5

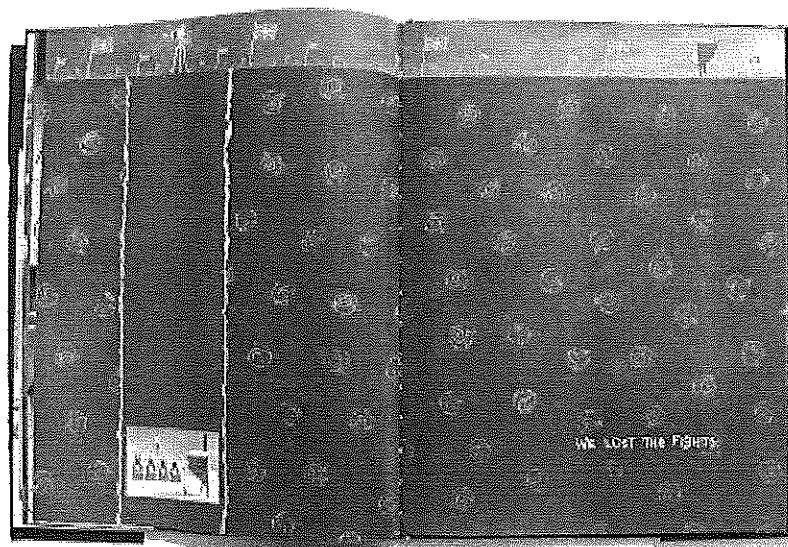
"They didn't live in trees like we did. They made their own houses." This particular spread gives us information in layers. The slightly lighter blue strip at the top is the original layer and belongs to the narrators. They are sitting in their trees, watching their world change. The darker blue is a superimposed layer, the result of the rabbits: we see both the buildings

being built and what they will look like. The buildings are like puzzles, already spewing black smoke. Everything is mechanical, even the rabbits seem so, the symmetry emphasizing the mechanical way they changed the world.



Opening 6

Not only were the rabbits' homes different, but "...they brought new food, and they brought other animals." The illustrations show us massive grass eating sheep, machines dressed in lambs' wool. Cows, already marked for the butcher's knife. The land is covered in these strange creatures, either in the fields or piled high on spindly locomotives. More words tell us that "... some of the animals scared us." But that's not all, "... some of the food made us sick" (the last three words turned upside down, as though rolling over with belly ache). The illustration shows a rabbit giving a bottle to the aboriginal creature collaged upon another illustration of a dried up water bed, littered with flapping, gasping fish. There was no stopping the rabbits, they spread across the country. There was fighting, "but there were too many rabbits"



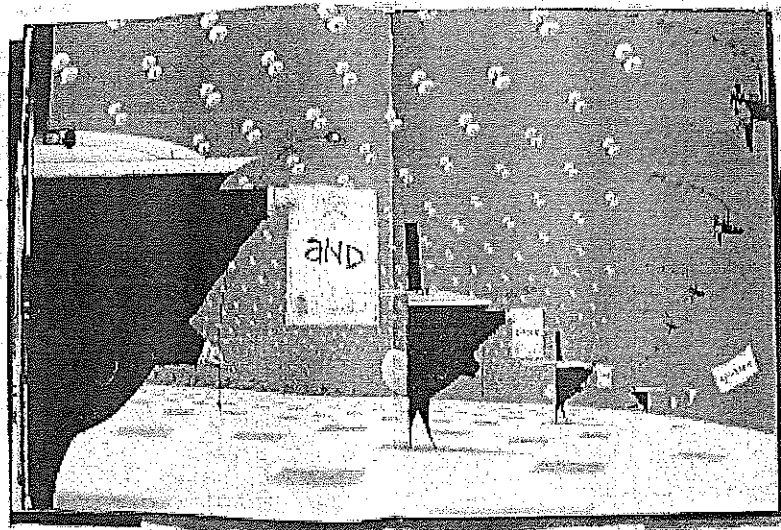
Opening 8

"We lost the fights." Those fossils we saw at the beginning, denoting an ancient world, dominated above by the rabbits' flags, the aboriginals, prisoners in their age old world,

defeated

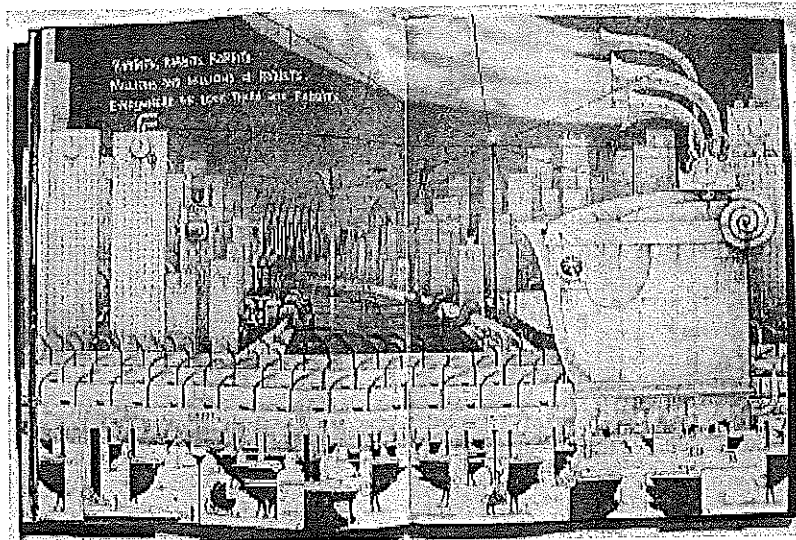
below.

The atrocities continue: "They ate our grass. They chopped down our trees and scared away our friends... "



Opening 10

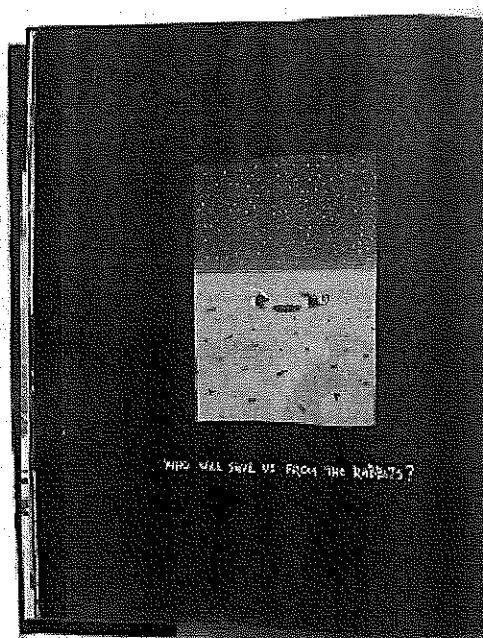
I find this spread the most shocking: hundreds of kites, with baby animals inside, being pulled by strange air machines. Mother creatures, as though dancing, hands raised towards their children, you can almost hear them moaning. And the rabbits, big and black, their vertical backs turned against the mothers. They have red and yellow eyes and the peacock feather pens mirror these evil eyes, dripping with the blood red ink they have just used to write on the certificates. These contain the verbal text of this page, each word on a separate sheet of paper, as though being spoken in jerks of distress, "and . stole . our . children."



Opening 11

"... everywhere we look there are rabbits." The statue in recto, a large rabbit, the motto MIGHT = RIGHT. A grey automated world, polluted and literally filled with rabbits, right to the very edges of the page. Can you see the only aboriginal creatures on the steps of the statue? The fallen kite? The rabbits holding masks? The gigantic curved chimneys, sucking in the blue sky and puffy clouds? A curious image, a frightening image. "The land is bare and brown and the wind blows empty across the plains. Where is the rich

dark earth brown and moist? Where is the smell of rain dripping from the trees? Where are the lakes, alive with long legged birds?" A final verso page shows a small cameo illustration against a black background. Two solitary creatures, a rabbit and an aboriginal.



Back verso

"Who will save us from the rabbits?". The land is wasted, littered with bones, lost and broken pieces of machinery and empty bottles. A small water hole reflects the stars in the sky. Can we read this as an image of hope? Is there any hope left? If we turn again to the back endpapers, we return to the bird-filled lake of cool lilac-blue water. A distant memory? A possible future?

When I first saw this picturebook I got goose bumps, and every time I look at it I get that goose bumpy feeling. It's quite something. A simple verbal text alongside such complex visual images, makes for much interpretation. There are many issues here and therefore lots of opportunities for talk and discussion. If you are teaching English through history, could this picturebook be of use? If your programme includes such topics as multiculturalism, could it be of use? Or, if you happen to have a group of interested teenagers, keen to talk and discuss, keen to put the world to rights, could this book be of use? I'd say 'yes' on all three occasions.

Suggested Reading/Viewing Order

1. Allegory and Artwork in The Rabbits.
2. Go to the link at the end of Allegory & Artwork.
3. Go to Rabbits 1. This discusses the text as allegory.
4. Next read Rabbits 2. This contains a link that will take you to teachers notes on the text and assist you to interpret it.
5. Move on to Rabbits 3 for an introduction to colonialism.
6. Now read The Looking Glass: Postcolonial Analysis.
7. Finish by reading the blog; it presents an in depth analysis of each page.

The Looking Glass : New Perspectives on Children's Literature

Who will save us from the rabbits?: rewriting the past allegorically

Brooke Collins-Gearing & Dianne Osland

Brooke Collins-Gearing is a Murri woman who teaches in Children's literature and Indigenous literature at the University of Newcastle. Her research has focused on representations of Aboriginality and non-Aboriginality in Australian children's literature.

Dianne Osland lectures in English Literature at the University of Newcastle, Australia, and her publications include work on the problems of identifying and interpreting metaphor in fiction. She is currently engaged in research on reading practices and cultural change.

In 1992, the Australian High Court recognised that the Murray Islanders held native title rights over their land, effectively debunking the doctrine of *terra nullius*. This became known as the Mabo Decision, as the key plaintiff was Eddie Mabo, a traditional custodian of the land. The Mabo Decision has been the most influential legal decision in this country in defining the rights of Indigenous Australians in a “post-colonial” society. Hence, pre-Mabo and post-Mabo have come to signify the strong colonial framework before 1992 and the legally altered one after the decision. But what Larissa Behrendt terms a *psychological terra nullius* continues to pervade non-Indigenous representations of history and colonisation (Behrendt 20). We argue in this paper that Australian children’s literature, in particular, is still coming to terms with this psychological *terra nullius*, leading to a clash of pre-Mabo metanarratives of settlement and post-Mabo awareness of invasion and dispossession. Post-Mabo, non-Indigenous representations face the dilemma of acknowledging the presence of Indigenous peoples within colonialist frameworks built on the doctrine of *terra nullius*. That is, myths of white settlement have been, and continue to be, the basis for ideological, institutional and societal practices and beliefs that centre non-Indigenous cultures and relegate Indigenous cultures to the margins. We have chosen John Marsden and Shaun Tan’s 1998 multi-award-winning text *The Rabbits* as the focus of our examination because of its attempt to enter into and reflect recent national and historical dialogues about the construction of Australia’s history. In this text that deals explicitly with colonisation as a form of invasion and dispossession, we wish to examine Australia’s psychological *terra nullius* in terms of how it tries to create and invoke a post-Mabo collective identity.

The Rabbits was a timely publication, capturing – indeed, some claimed it was capitalizing on – the growing momentum of public sentiment that would eventually result in the newly elected Prime Minister’s 2008 apology to Indigenous Australians. A picture book with sparse text, *The Rabbits* is an allegorical representation of colonization. Small numbat-like marsupials [1] are dispossessed of their families, their communities, and their country [2] by invading Rabbits who have taken domestication to a level of ruthless efficiency: the Rabbits arrive with all the trappings of European culture – its clothes, agriculture, industry, and economy – and proceed to exploit the land to the point of devastation. And they steal the Numbats’ children. The text’s allegorical nature extends its ability both to create and to evoke colonial “memories” of invasion and dispossession. *The Rabbits’* polemical nature, softened by the surreal images and spare text, informs the reader of the destructive power of colonisation.

While the images of the land and the creatures inhabiting it clearly locate the story in an Australian context, both the editorial blurb and Shaun Tan’s comments on his illustrations claim a broader reference. It is seen as “a rich and haunting allegory of colonization for all ages and cultures, told from the viewpoint of native animals” (*The Rabbits* publisher’s blurb) and a “partly allegorical fable about colonisation, told from the viewpoint of the colonised” (Tan “Shaun Tan”); internationally, readers seem to have little trouble generalizing beyond its regional particularity to identify a global significance in an allegory, not simply of colonization, but also of industrialization and ecological destruction more generally. It is a clever, earnest

book that seemingly presses all the right buttons; it has won awards nationally and internationally (including the Children's Book Council of Australia Picture Book of the Year in 1999), and it has quickly made its way into school curricula. But the simple language, striking illustrations, and Picture Book of the Year Award [3] do not disguise or divert attention from the contested dialogue about Australia's history that it has entered into, nor from the problematic notions of identity (both for Indigenous and non-Indigenous Australians) that it evokes. The narrative constructs dichotomous representations of the "coloniser" (Rabbits) and "colonised" (Numbats): strong, weak; modern, ancient; civilised, primitive; centre, peripheral; conqueror, victim. Such binary oppositions are a legacy of pre-Mabo colonialist discourses in Australian children's literature and reveal the text's seemingly neutral colonialist discourses to be rooted in colonialist ideologies and legacies. While the Rabbits in the illustrations look like Europeans (long ears excepted), walk upright like Europeans, and dress like Europeans, the marsupials look like small furry animals; they are, moreover, for the most part helpless bystanders. In *Reading Race*, Clare Bradford has argued that *The Rabbits* contributes to the history of "Aboriginalism" in Australian children's literature: "the first-person account of the events of colonisation constructs the Indigenous as stupid and helpless, locking them into the posture of victims... the indigenous creatures who tell their story are naked and vulnerable, always the objects of the gaze of the colonising Rabbits" (113) and Aboriginality is further essentialized by the idea that Indigenous peoples are "primitive victims incapable of assuming agency in their own interests, unable to adjust or adapt to new and troubling times" (114). While we wish to extend the analysis of this essentialised and Aboriginalist version of Australia's history as represented in *The Rabbits*, we also want to trace another consequence of white Australia's "psychological *terra nullius*" on the depiction of colonial occupation. It is not just the representation of the "Numbats" that is problematic, but also the text's struggle to depict and position the "Rabbits".

The Rabbits overtly acknowledges that the landscape was inhabited before colonisation: its narrative, illustrations and themes attempt to deal with the coming of the Rabbits, their impact on the land and its original inhabitants (including the stealing of children), the losing battle the original inhabitants face, and the final question of a needed saviour. While the white Rabbits represent the British colonisers, the Indigenous peoples are represented by a nameless marsupial – variously identified by reviewers as bandicoots, tree kangaroos, even "bush babies", but most closely resembling a numbat, a small, furry, white-banded creature, with a long bushy tail, that feeds mainly on termites and is currently classified, ominously enough, as an endangered species. The narrative is ostensibly from the original creature's point of view, yet in the telling the colonized are perceived from the colonisers' point of view, and, in the illustrations and in the outcome, the overall impact is one of the destructiveness of colonisation and the potential demise of the colonised. It is a one way, linear master narrative of history and events, an allegory of the dominance of the colonisers, their slow destruction of the land and its creatures and of the experience of loss, sickness and surrender by those who have been colonised. The Rabbits arrive, they conquer both the landscape and the "Numbats", and the "Numbats" are powerless to fight against them.

If we apply Behrendt's idea of psychological *terra nullius* here, we can see how the text struggles to subvert pre-Mabo narratives of Australia as an empty landscape and replace it instead with a narrative of invasion and dispossession. Non-Aboriginality is constructed on agrarian, pastoralist and scientific superiority, that is, the land was seen as empty because it was not being used the way the colonisers believed it should be. This belief provided justification for the taking of Indigenous land but the text somewhat subverts this by showing how the colonisers, with their superior ways, then destroyed the environment. The text struggles to come to terms with a non-Aboriginality that overpowered Indigenous Australians and a non-Aboriginality that acknowledges that dispossession. The post-Mabo struggle to place the Rabbits within the landscape sees them retain their power and force to the detriment of everyone and everything around them. The narrative acknowledges a post-Mabo awareness of dispossessing the original inhabitants, but is confined by a pre-Mabo collective memory of colonialist superiority that can conceive of only one kind of story to tell. It is a story that is framed by the act of colonisation. Both the illustrations and the text start with the arrival of the Rabbits and end with the dominance of the Rabbits. According to Tan, this was a conscious choice: the cover illustration mimics a nineteenth-century painting by E. Phillips Fox depicting the arrival of European settlement according to "a familiar ideology, all about progress and destiny, the planting of flags and the arrival of legitimate historical narrative" (Tan, "Originality and Creativity"). But even, ostensibly, in telling this story from the viewpoint of the colonised, it perpetuates that colonialist ideology (particularly for

readers – young and old – unable to recognise the ideological freight carried by the framing device). The narrative seems to suggest that this is the only version of history that needs to be told – anything before it is unnecessary. The telling of the tale “from the viewpoint of the colonised” thus becomes even more problematic, imposing on the original inhabitants of the land a decidedly Western temporal perspective. In contrast, Indigenous views of time as cyclical do not always separate these acts of invasion and colonisation from other important moments in Indigenous life and knowledges. That is, in concentric circles, colonisation, particularly the removal of children, remains close in time. It is not an event that happened in the past and is nearly or easily forgotten. But in *The Rabbits*, the original creatures appear only in relation to the act of colonisation; any notion of pre-existence is unnecessary and therefore pre-historical. This serves to reinforce the Western linear approach to time, movement from one period to the next and therefore movement further away from the original period: that is, the book starts with the arrival of the Rabbits and Numbats’ existence before this is now long gone and forgotten.

The illustrations also contribute to the narrative’s struggle to re-tell the story of invasion and ultimately reinforce the colonised perspective as the marginal one. Indeed, the Numbats are peripheral in most of the illustrations, and peripheral to the Rabbit’s society. In one particular, predominantly black and white, image, the Numbats are fringe-dwellers in the Rabbits’ world, homeless, on the grog (evidenced by discarded bottles), living rough out of cardboard boxes placed beneath a “Might=Right” sign. In the middle of the book there is a double page spread where the Numbats appear to be actively resisting the invasion of the Rabbits, “but there were too many” and the following page shows them curled up underground. In most of the illustrations and accompanying text the focus is on the Rabbits, their tools and power, their destruction of the land and all of its original inhabitants and their presiding dominance over the landscape: “Rabbits, rabbits, rabbits. Millions and millions of rabbits. Everywhere we look there are rabbits”. Towards the end of the book, all colour has slowly faded and blackness dominates the illustrations. The land changes from colour and abundance to “bare and brown” and empty. While the narrative tries to readdress pre-Mabo colonialist discourses that built on the doctrine of *terra nullius*, the illustrations contribute to the belief that if the land was not empty of “natives” before the arrival of the invaders, it became emptied of them soon after. The illustrations extend the pre-Mabo framework confining the narrative, only allowing them to position the Numbats as destitute and stricken. Outlines of the Numbats, curled in tight balls resembling the imprint of ammonite fossils, appear to be dotted underground, beneath the surface which is dominated by the Rabbits and their flags. The result is that the Numbats remain peripheral to the centred power of the Rabbits. What becomes important is what the Rabbits do, not what the Numbats do. Hence the text reverts to pre-Mabo colonialist structures and perspectives, even to the point of being reminiscent of colonial beliefs that the “natives” would eventually all die out.

While the narrative attempts to replace a pre-Mabo representation of “discovery” and “settlement” with a post-Mabo construction of invasion and destruction, it struggles to position the Rabbits in relation to both the Numbats and the land. The coloniser’s perspective is enforced in the text by the idea that the Rabbits conclusively defeated the Numbats. While the resistance of the “Numbats” is apparent in Tan’s double page illustration, in sepia-tinted cameos, of the Numbats sabotaging the Rabbits’ technology and engaging in sporadic or collective warfare, the following page blatantly states “We lost the fights”, as if subsequent ongoing fights for self-determination and sovereignty never occurred. By establishing the Rabbits as the dominant conquerors and the Numbats as the helpless victims, the Rabbits remain as invaders unreconciled with the landscape, yet it is their ideological and cultural norms that rule the land. If *The Rabbits* is portraying the history of contact, then it is a history that assumes that the Rabbits came out the winners and the Numbats still need saving. Throughout the text, in both the written narrative and the illustrations, colonisation is represented as a one way journey: the colonisers came in, they won the battles, they remain today the winners and those in positions of power: “They brought new food, and they brought other animals. We liked some of the food and we liked some of the animals. But some of the food made us sick, and some of the animals scared us”.

And what does this say about Aboriginal resistance and survival – then and now (to follow the linear idea of time as upheld by the text)? The images in the text attach colour and movement to the Rabbits’ side of the land, while the Numbats’ side is barren and brown. The barrenness of the Numbat’s world is compounded by their amorphous nonentity, they become little more than underground, fossilised skeletons. The use of a

nameless creature to represent the Indigenous peoples is potentially a powerful technique, as Indigenous Australians did not refer to themselves as “Indigenous” or “Aboriginal” prior to invasion. However, the clumping together of all Indigenous Australians as one group disregards cultural diversity and the different experiences of colonisation. By establishing a colonial dichotomy of “us” and “them”, “Rabbits” and “Numbats”, the narrative also ignores the influence of other migrant peoples since colonisation, and the effects of intermarrying. [4] Furthermore, the representation of the colonised people as living in trees is, to say the least, unfortunate. In the spirit of *terra nullius*, the original inhabitants are hardly distinguishable from the other native flora and fauna as represented in the book, and one is reminded of section 127 of the Australian Constitution pre-1967, where Aboriginal Australians were not classified as people but as part of the flora and fauna. While the Rabbits look like people and act like people, the “Numbats” never cease to be animals, which pre-empts any notion that the Rabbits could learn or gain anything valuable from the colonised. The erasure of all but an impotent few Numbats erases also the opportunity that always existed, and still exists, for dialogue between non-Aboriginal and Aboriginal voices. By establishing such strict and explicit boundaries between the Rabbits and the Numbats (modern and “natural”, destructive and overwhelmed, winner and loser) the narrative struggles to re-write pre-Mabo settlement myths with a post-Mabo awareness that the land was wrongfully taken and the colonisers’ have built a whole nation on this theft. It attempts to raise and employ post-Mabo awareness and concepts, but, in fact, its passive ideologies simply re-inscribe the perceived hopelessness of pre-Mabo Indigenous peoples as subjugated and victimised. While the text attempts to acknowledge some of the injustices done to the Indigenous peoples of Australia, it struggles to (re)define what this then means for the construction of “non-Aboriginality” and the colonisers’ relationship with place. In presenting the Rabbits as having the power to chain, ignore, represent and even speak for the Numbats, the narrative constructs the identity of the colonised as “the passive victim on display” (Chow 29). Raimond Gaita, in relation to coercive reconciliation, has argued that Good-hearted people find it intolerable that just treatment of the powerless should depend on the generosity of the powerful – on their pity or even on their openness to an appeal to justice. Since at least 1788, the refusal to accept this has driven the rhetoric of human rights in a noble attempt to bestow dignity on the powerless by creating the illusion that rights are a kind of moral force field, a metaphysical barrier to the indignity of being ruthlessly crushed. I do not need your pity. I do not need your justice gratuitously given. I will stand on my rights. That is the spirit of it, a spirit of defiance. It is an illusion, I fear. Unless an appeal to rights has force to back it, its acknowledgement depends entirely on the spirit of justice in those to whom the appeal was made. (304-5)

Marsden and Tan’s narrative identifies the “native” as lack – “someone from whom something has been stolen” (Rey Chow 31). Chow, employing the work of Fanon, examines how postcolonial fiction constructs the image of the “other’s” subjectivity through the gaze of the oppressor: “The image, then, is an aggressive sight that reveals itself in the other; it is the site of the aggressed. Moreover, the image is what has been devastated, left bare, and left behind by aggression” (31). And it is here that we see the text’s struggle with mainstream Australia’s psychological *terra nullius* in full colour: the presence of the Numbats, their loss and their lack is what defines the presence of the Rabbits: “Our fascination with the native, the oppressed, the savage, and all such figures is therefore a desire to hold on to an unchanging certainty somewhere outside our own ‘fake’ experience. It is a desire for being ‘non-duped’, which is a not-too-innocent desire to seize control” (53).

The final page serves to reinforce the Rabbits’ need to seize control and Numbats’ status as helpless and demoralised creatures in need of rescue: “Who will save us from the rabbits?” The text reinforces colonialist assumptions that Aboriginal Australians cannot determine their own lives or their own futures. Potentially the ending could be read as exposing the continual control Western society has over Aboriginal peoples and their lives; however, presenting the Numbats as in need of a saviour denies their ability to save themselves. Centring the colonisers’ perspective, and effectively colonising the original inhabitants’ voice, silences the colonised, denying their ability to speak for themselves, refusing them the right to their own identity and history. And while some may argue that this is an accurate reflection of the history of colonisation, the text’s attempt to acknowledge a post-Mabo landscape of invasion and dispossession is undercut by pre-Mabo suppression of Indigenous voices, leaving no space to address injustices and denial of Indigenous rights. The final illustration of the intruding blackness upon the two figures – one rabbit, one original creature, sitting opposite each other on the edge of a pond that is the last remnant of the great billabong – is

ambiguous at best. There is the potential to read this final image as a sign of hope, for the possibility of equal and shared communication between Rabbit and Numbat. However, the text implies that now both the Rabbit and Numbat need help – a saviour of some sort. It removes the option for the Rabbits to change their ways and acknowledge their power in what Gaita terms “the spirit of justice”: “The Aborigines have no power worth speaking of. If their voices are to be heard, if they dare speak from their hearts seriously to challenge our assumptions, be they assumptions of the Right or the Left, then it will be because we – the non-Aboriginal population – will have been moved by the spirit of justice to listen” (305).

As an allegory of colonisation, *The Rabbits* appears to be exposing the horrors of colonial exploitation, yet in its representation of “they came, they saw and they conquered”, even this post-Mabo perspective maintains the white metanarrative of history as war and winning. If the battle was fought and won (by the Rabbits) and the Numbats are only dwelling in the peripheral shade (both physically and historically), simply sitting back and waiting to be saved, [5] then this representation upholds the idea that modernity, civilisation, progress and the white man were unavoidable and remain so today, that the tools and knowledges of the Rabbits were too much for the poor nameless creatures to deal with, and therefore at some point progress was going to arrive.

The unspoken, and often unthinking, subtext of allegory is well-argued by James Clifford in his study of its use in ethnographic writing. In *Writing Cultures*, he points out that “Allegory (Gr. *Allos*, “other”, and *agorevein*, “to speak”) usually denotes a practice in which a narrative fiction continuously refers to another pattern of ideas or events. It is a representation that ‘interprets’ itself” (Clifford 99). In the case of *The Rabbits*, the text refers to patterns and ideas from Western colonisation and reinterprets not only what this means but the impact and power it has. So once again, the cultural framework for the narrative and its reader is a non-Indigenous, colonial, Western one. The power to construct the allegory and tell it has remained with “the Rabbits” and associated with this power is its intended interpretation and moral connotations. Clifford also states that “Allegory prompts us to say of any cultural description not ‘this represents, or symbolizes, that’ but rather, ‘this is a (morally charged) story about that’” (100). *The Rabbits*, in its depiction of the power of the Rabbits and their destructive power over the land, then becomes a morally charged retelling of the nation’s collective memory of colonisation. Pre-Mabo, the collective Australian psyche, and its doctrine of *terra nullius*, depended on being “morally” and legally right (the justification for invasion, protection, segregation, assimilation etc). Post-Mabo, the nation’s psychological *terra nullius* now has to come to terms with being morally “wrong”. However, the use of allegory, with its attenuation of the specifically Australian experience of colonisation, encourages selective blindness and political forgetfulness. The specific metaphor of colonisation (in this instance a rabbit plague) carries with it assumptions about the actual process – in this instance, as an unavoidable and essentially amoral natural phenomenon (what could be more natural than breeding like Rabbits?) that efface realities that can then be ignored.

Read as an allegory of colonisation, *The Rabbits* relocates the significance of the narrative beyond the specific context in which the story takes place, so that the particular and personal are appropriated and diminished, extinguishing a sense of personal investment and responsibility in the specific Australian context. It is a psychological *terra nullius* of a particularly insidious kind, emptying the land of meaning except as it “stands for” a bigger picture and larger historical, economic and environmental issues. The allegorical nature of the text and its embedded moral attachment also imply a “right” reading of the text. Allegory does require an active reader: the connections between the narrative and symbolic levels may be obvious, but they still need to be made by the reader – though the age at which children acquire the metaphorical competence to make such connections without guidance is still hotly debated. But more so than in other types of imaginative fiction, once the connection is established, interpretative options are severely curtailed. Tan denies that the book is didactic, arguing that “It’s up to the reader to draw whatever meaning they wish” (“Originality and Creativity”), yet reviews of the book that are critical of its heavy-handedness (most obvious, perhaps, in its reference to stolen children, which Tan seems to be trying to disengage from its jarringly literal historical context by an illustration that sees the children carried off in squadrons of box-kites) attack it for its “political correctness”, which implies not only a “closed” interpretation of the text but a “morally charged” one as well. The post-Mabo perspective relies on an allegory based on a pre-Mabo cultural framework that silences the possibility for Indigenous voices to engage in a dialogue with non-Indigenous ones.

Notes

1. For the purposes of this paper, the nameless creatures in the text will be referred to as numbats, which they most closely (though not exactly) resemble.
2. Prime Minister Rudd's "Apology to Australia's Indigenous People" makes specific reference to "the removal of Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander children from their families, their communities and their country" (Address to Parliament 13th February, 2008).
3. The book advertises itself as suitable "for all ages, all cultures" (back cover), though Tan claims it was "originally conceived as a book for older readers" ("Shaun Tan: Picture Books").
4. The analogy of colonisation to an invasion of rabbits not only disregards the cultural diversity of generations of colonisers but also glosses over instances of a more malevolent dispossession. Not all of the colonisers were instruments of merely collateral damage in their destruction of the Indigenous population in pursuit of economic imperatives. Some meant to do it.
5. Unsworth and Wheeler, in their positive analysis of *The Rabbits* (in which they refer to the original inhabitants as bandicoots), identify the way in which this passivity informs the language: "In several of the beginning illustrations the bandicoots are seen holding their spears just watching the rabbits. The rabbits, however, are seen as very active right from the start, driving, studying and measuring. This is mirrored in the text by the agentive roles taken by the rabbits and the bandicoots in relation to the kinds of processes represented by different verbs. The rabbits have active agentive roles with verbs like "made", "brought", "came", "spread", "ate", "chopped" and "stole". The bandicoots are less involved with words of action and more involved with communicative and mental process verbs like "warned" and "liked". When they are involved in action, it is significantly negative – "lost"." (72).

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Brooke Collins-Gearing and Dianne Osland

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"Who will save us from the rabbits?: rewriting the past allegorically" © Brooke Collins-Gearing and Dianne Osland, 2010.

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The Looking Glass: new perspectives on children's literature

<https://www.lib.latrobe.edu.au/ojs/index.php/tlg/article/view/227/225>

The Rabbits

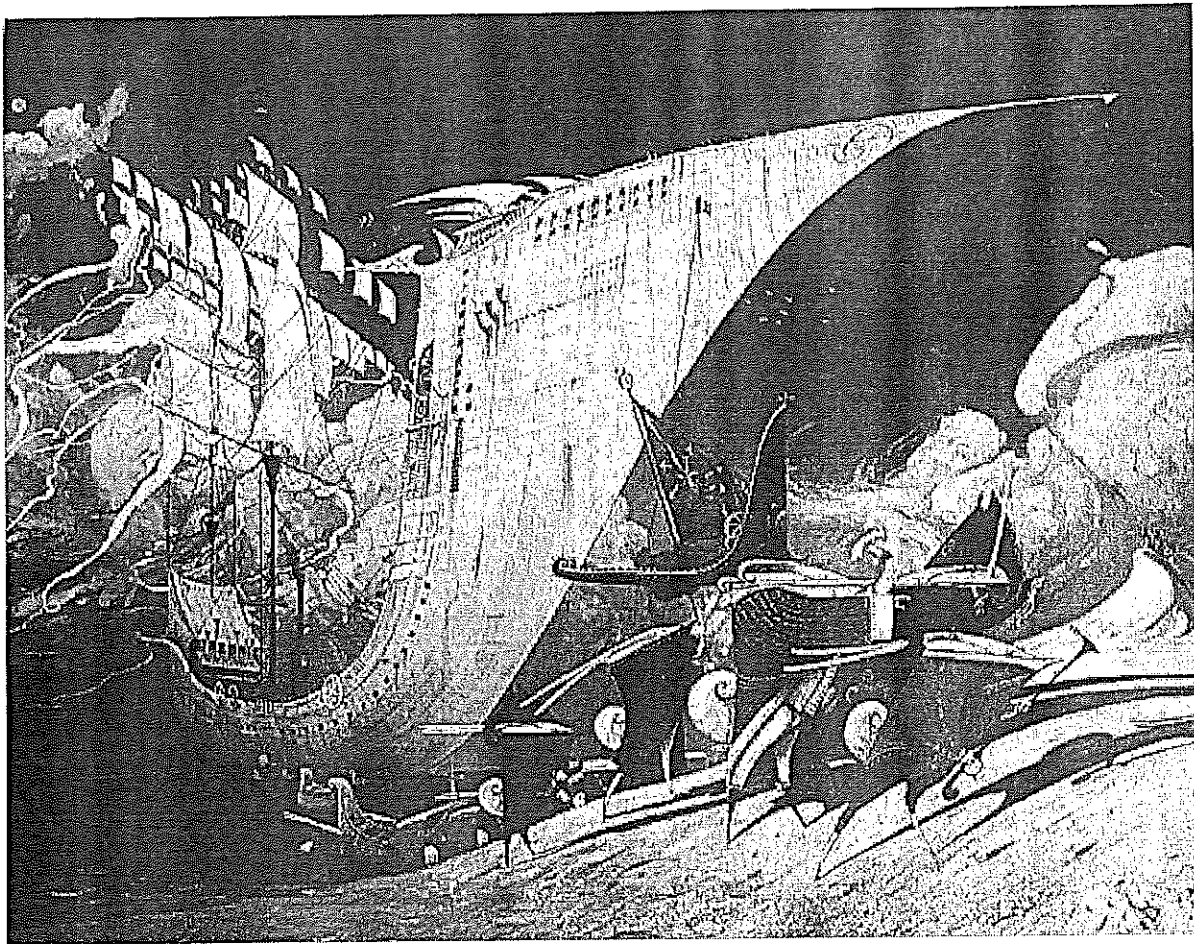
The Rabbits, written by John Marsden, is partly allegorical fable about colonisation, told from the viewpoint of the colonised. An unseen narrator describes the coming of 'rabbits' in the most minimal detail, an encounter that is at first friendly and curious, but later darkens as it becomes apparent that the visitors are actually invaders. The style of the book is deliberately sparse and strange, with both text and image conveying an overall sense of bewilderment and anxiety as native numbat-like creatures witness environmental devastation under the wheels of a strange new culture.

[> Click here](#) for further comment about *The Rabbits*.

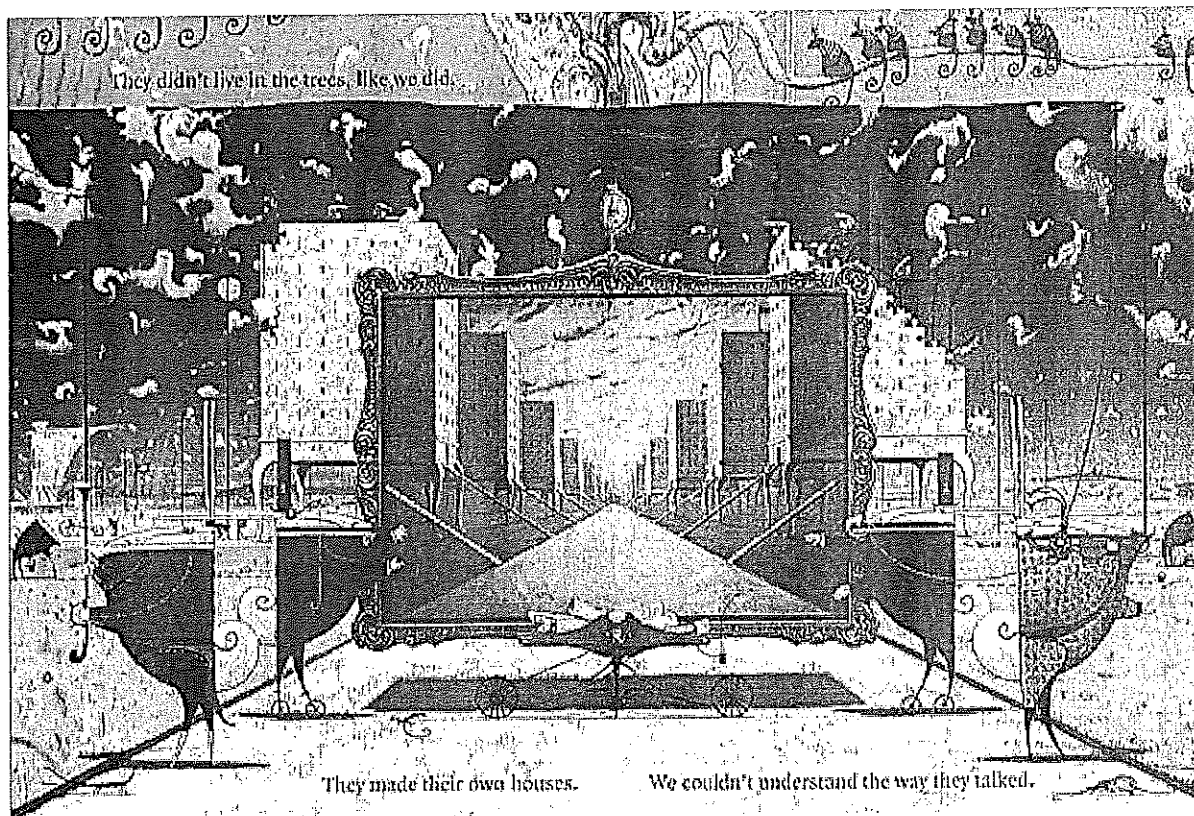
[> Click here](#) for a interview about *The Rabbits* from 1998.



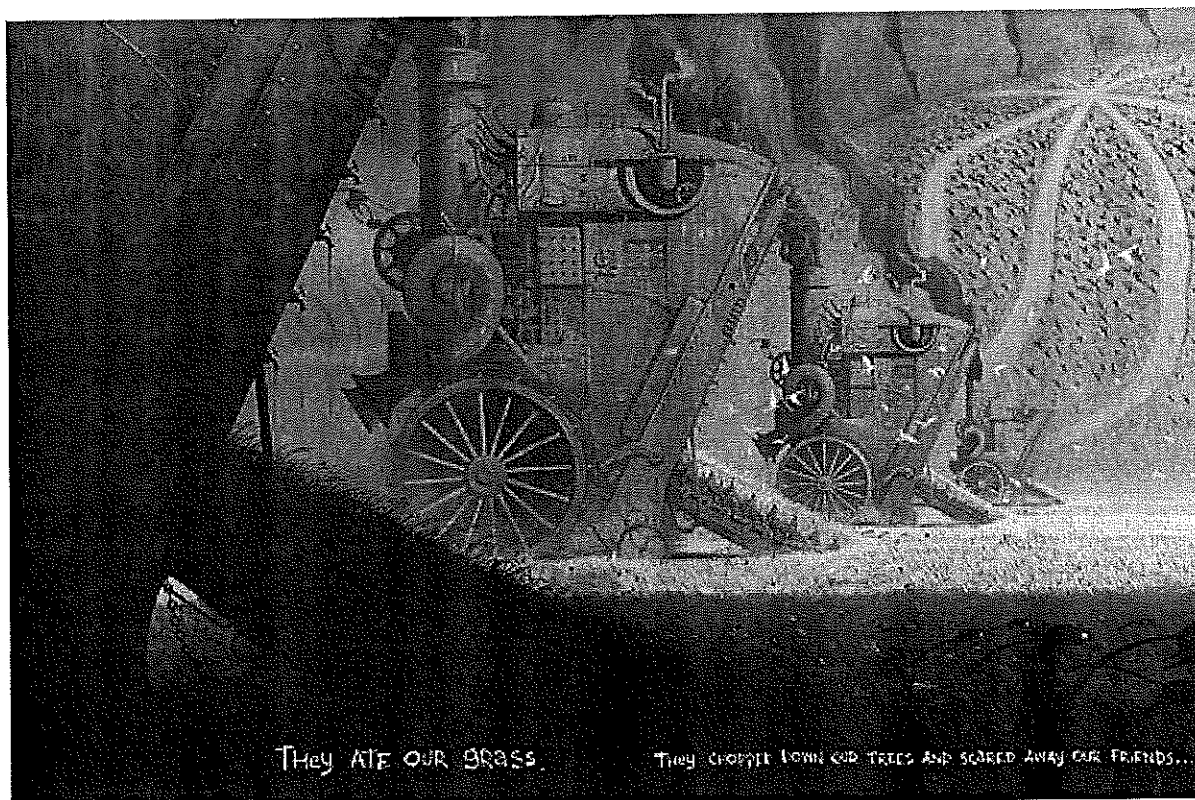
'The meeting on the hill' acrylic, gouache, ink and coloured pencil.



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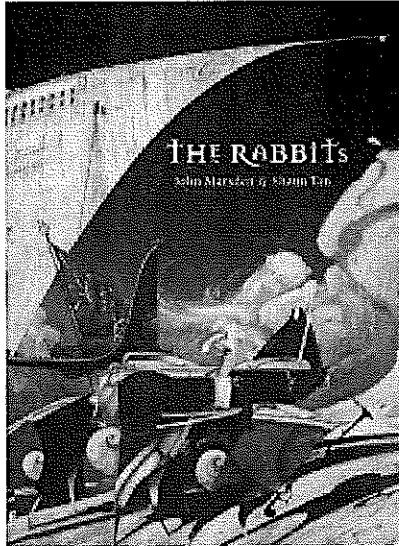
Comments on *The Rabbits*

The parallels with a real history of colonisation in Australia and around the world are obvious, and based on detailed research, in spite of the overt surrealism of the imagery and the absence of direct references. It was named Picture Book of the Year by the Children's Book Council, which in part generated some controversy due to its confronting themes, and was attacked on several occasions for being 'politically correct propaganda', but only by right wing conservatives of course. In spite of this (or because of it), the book went on to win numerous awards in Australia, the US and UK, and is studied widely in secondary schools. It would seem that some of my concepts and designs were unacknowledged inspiration for a section of the opening ceremony of the 2000 Sydney Olympics, although I've never been able to find out if this is true.

One reason for the initial controversy is that The Rabbits is a picture book, and therefore thought to be children's literature, and wrongly assumed to be didactic, whereas it had been originally conceived as a book for older readers, and generally difficult to categorise. Some children may get a lot out of it, but generally it defies most picture book conventions and is not necessarily a good choice for pleasant bedtime reading!

The Rabbits – Teachers Notes

http://www.thearrival.com.au/downloads/TG_TheRabbits.pdf



The Rabbits.

John Marsden. Illustrated by Shaun Tan.
Vancouver, BC: Simply Read Books, 2003.
32 pp., cloth, \$23.95.
ISBN 0-9688768-8-9.

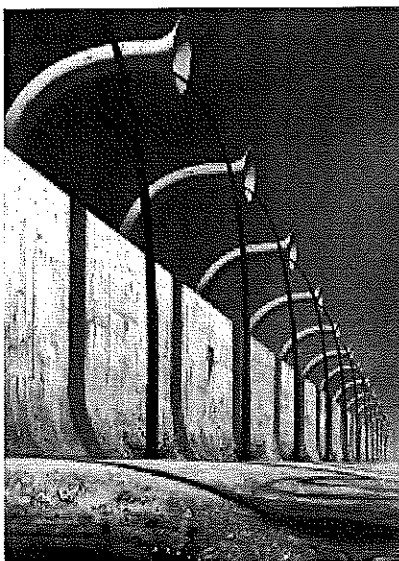
Subject Headings:
Rabbits-Juvenile fiction.
Imperialism-Juvenile fiction.

Grades 2 and up / Ages 7 and up.

Review by Sylvia Pantaleo.

****** /4**

The Rabbits is a compelling and disturbing allegory of colonization, industrialization and population growth. Many reviewers have used the word allegory to describe the book, but Shaun Tan, the illustrator, describes the book as a metaphor. Because Marsden is Australian, some have interpreted the story as the invasion of Australia by Europeans. However, the fundamental themes of the picture book are pertinent to humans throughout the world.



Text on the first verso reads, "The Rabbits came many grandparents ago." Initially, the inhabitants are tolerant of the newcomers, stating that, "At first we didn't know what to think. They looked a bit like us. There weren't many of them. Some were friendly." However, the elders' warning foreshadows the demise of the indigenous creatures and their land. As Rabbits continue to arrive in new and different ways, the original inhabitants begin to express concerns. A feeling of helplessness descends as the invaders take over and the illustrations communicate the imminent doom. On one double-page spread, Tan uses monochromatic colours to depict the conflict between the factions and the powerlessness of the native creatures. The collage-like appearance of this particular double-spread exacerbates the bleakness of the inhabitants' futures.

The Rabbits conquer the indigenous creatures. "We lost the fight." Tan juxtaposes the defeated native animals below the ground in bondage with the Rabbits above ground, their flags covering the land. The Rabbits continue to exploit the inhabitants and damage the environment. They commit the ultimate cruelty by stealing the children of the indigenous animals. An industrialized scene depicts the new status quo and the words "Might = Right" is inscribed at the bottom of a statute.

The Rabbits' legacy: destruction, desolation and despair. The book ends with the ultimate question, "Who will save us from the Rabbits?"

The text is minimal, yet the paucity of words is extremely effective. Tan uses colour and size symbolically in his stylized illustrations and the synergy between the text and illustrations is powerful. Many symbols are used throughout the text - the design on the Rabbits' flag, the clocks, and the arrows. The serenity of the end papers that depict waterfowl in a natural habitat are in stark contrast to the other illustrations in the book.

The Rabbits, first published in 1998, won the Australian Children's Book of the Year award in 1999. It also won the CBCA Picture Book of the Year Award. *The Rabbits* is an outstanding and sophisticated picture book that challenges and engages readers on multiple levels.

Highly Recommended.

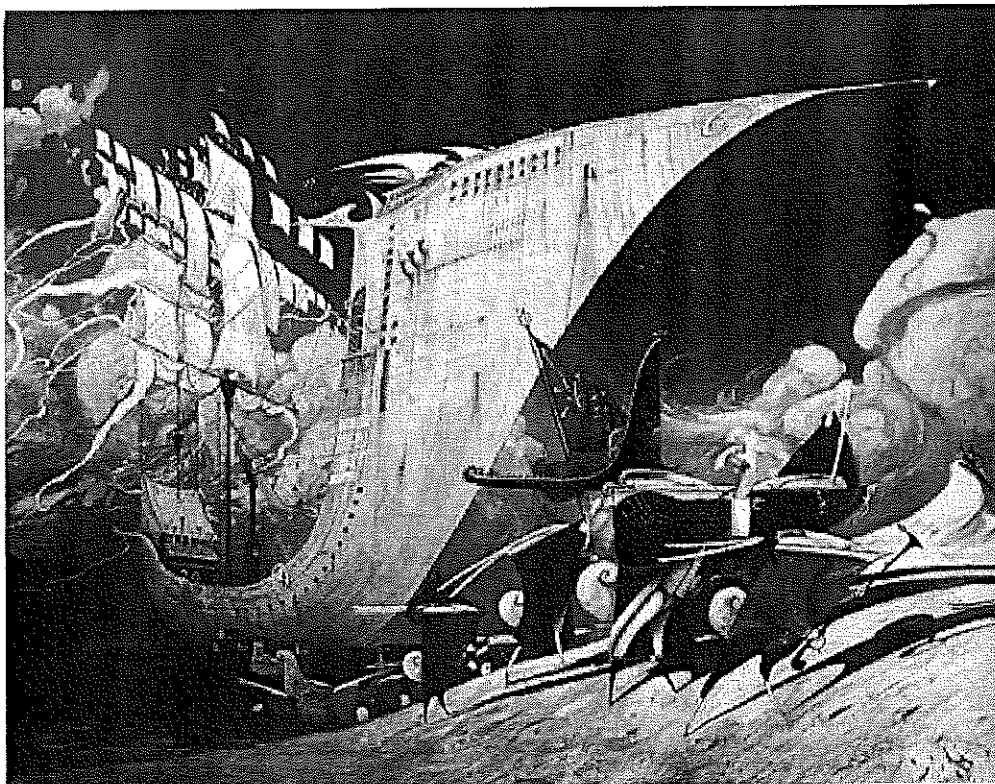
Sylvia Pantaleo is an Associate Professor of Language Arts in the Faculty of Education at BC's University of Victoria.

<http://www.umanitoba.ca/outreach/cm/vol10/no19/therabbits.html>

The Rabbits – John Marsden, illustrated by Shaun Tan

February 12, 2010 ~ Polly

I “met” Shaun Tan in the Byward Market in Ottawa when I was waiting for someone at the bookstore, and developed a serious crush on *The Arrival*, a story about immigration told entirely in pencil drawings. Then I learned about *The Rabbits*. And *Tales of Lost Suburbia*. And all of his other books, each more amazing than the last. In fact, I co-own all of them, thanks to a gift of a “complete set”. The set is “complete” until more books are published, and then I will just have to go out and re-complete it.



The Rabbits is a book about colonialism and its attendant evils (particularly environmental and cultural destruction), carried out with vigour and innocence by The Rabbits, who land in Australia and proceed to overrun it. Ecological history and human history meld. You could say that it's an obvious metaphor, or you could say that it's a brilliant parallel. I say “brilliant”.

Marsden uses words sparingly, and with effect. The sentences are clean and simple – there is dignity in them and a quiet despair. Tan, on the other hand, does not hold back with his illustrations. Sometimes simple, sometimes filled with activity, each one covers both pages. They are large, they are art, and in their colour and content they convey the various moods of Marsden's text.

Tan has a gift for using unusual shapes to convey strangeness or making the strange seem almost natural (he also does this in *The Arrival*). The Rabbits look so...strangely familiarly Victorian (perhaps only familiar to colonials?)...with their machines, their high collars, their wig-like ears, their monocles and perambulators, their dark suits and long dresses, their hugs chests and tiny feet. Their Australian counterparts seem more real. Less strange. The world of pre-Rabbit Australia is serene and natural; post-Rabbit Australia is a contorted cacophony.

I'm not going to lie: it's a scary book. It ends with tough questions, none of which have answers (ex. Who will save us from the Rabbits?). So if you like to know the answers, this may not be the book for you. But it is a book for me, and I'm glad to have it...especially so as it is extremely difficult to get your hands on it in North America and it more or less had to be special-ordered through Australia (or something ridiculous like that). I don't know for sure, I just know that of the "complete set", this book was delivered nearly a month after all of the others had arrived. It was well worth the wait.

I think *The Rabbits* is appropriate for people of many ages because although there aren't many words, this book generates a lot of thought and questions, and older readers might have a better understanding of "Rabbits aren't actually scary and bad, they are just a *symbol*." The illustrations also use techniques (simplicity, complexity, organization of shapes and – unless I am mistaken – are done in different media) that could be appreciated by a budding artist, and the book has a message that people of all ages can appreciate. It is one of my favourite Shaun Tan books.

Favourite Line: At first we didn't know what to think. They looked a bit like us. There weren't many of them. Some were friendly.

Reading Ages: 5 and up.

Rating: A

<https://vickyandpolly.wordpress.com/2010/02/12/the-rabbits-john-marsden-illustrated-by-shaun-tan/>

The Rabbits

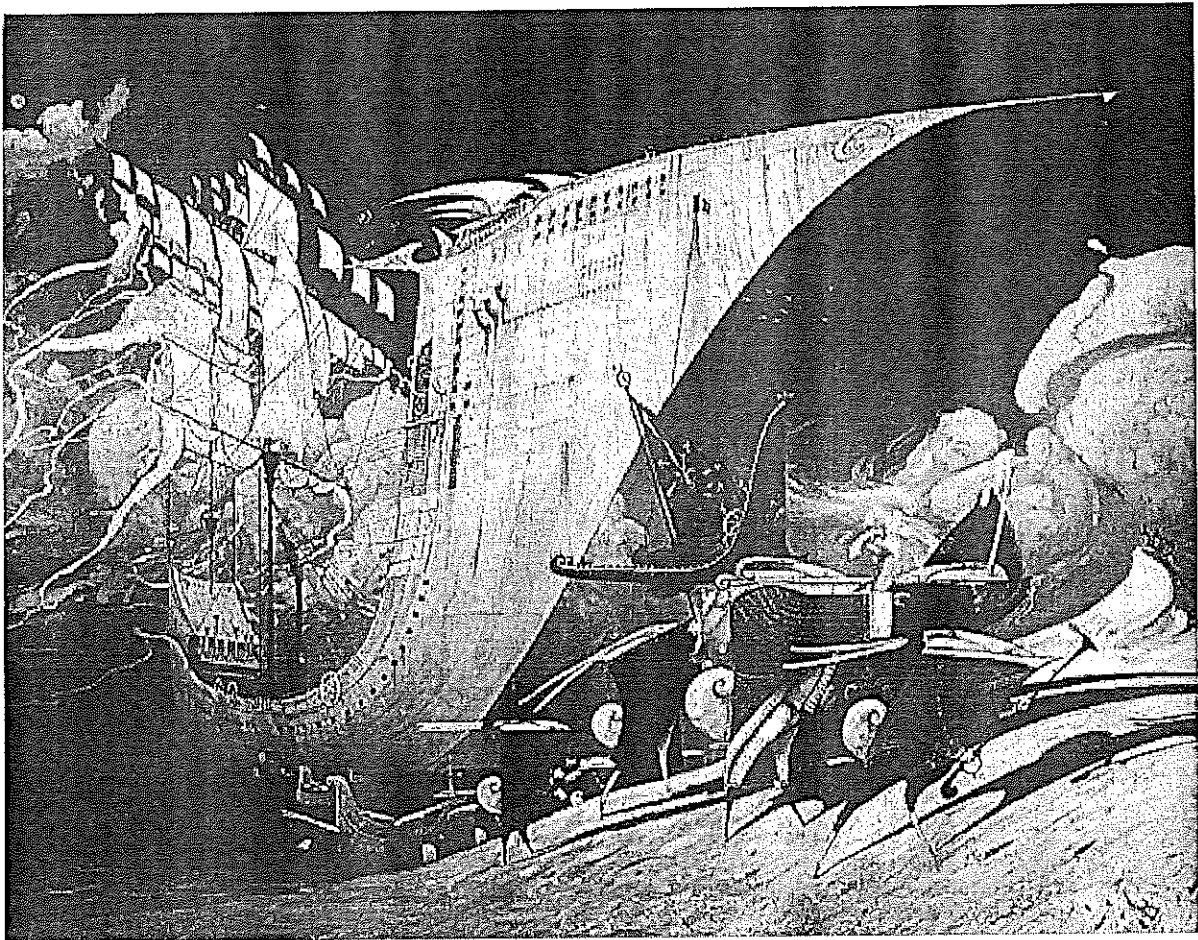
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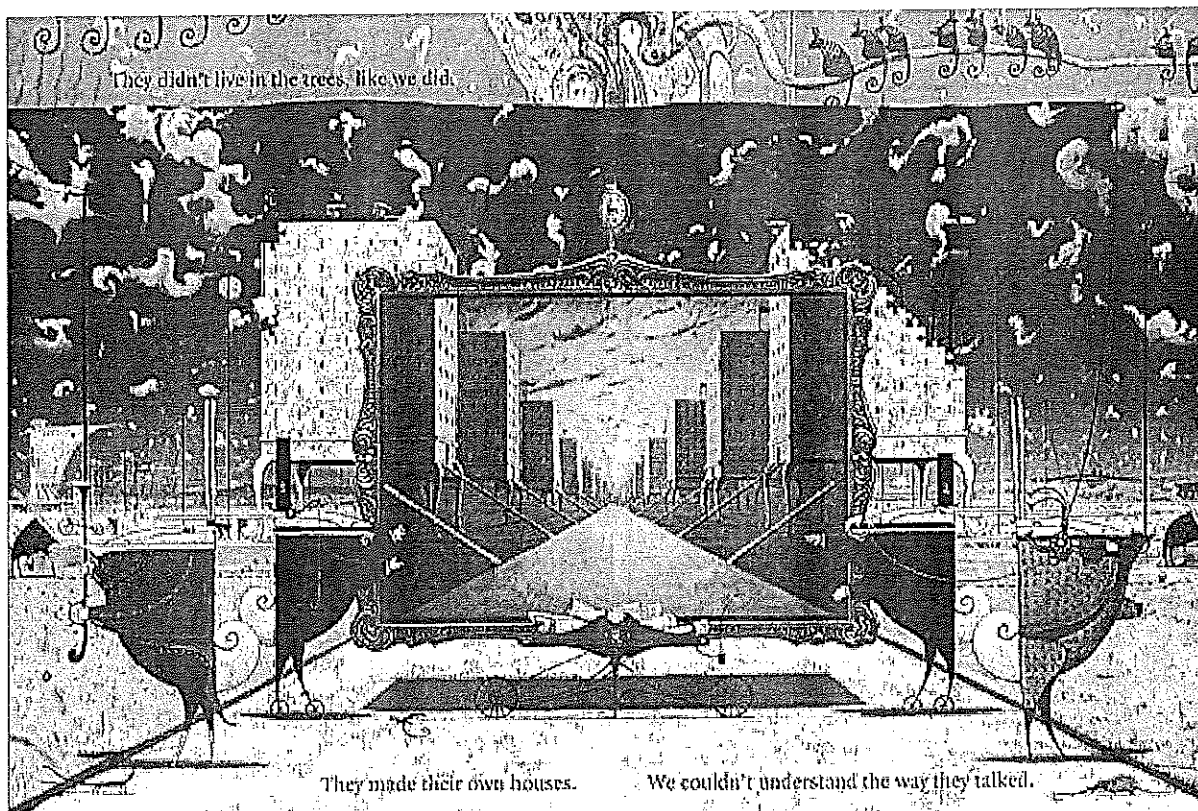
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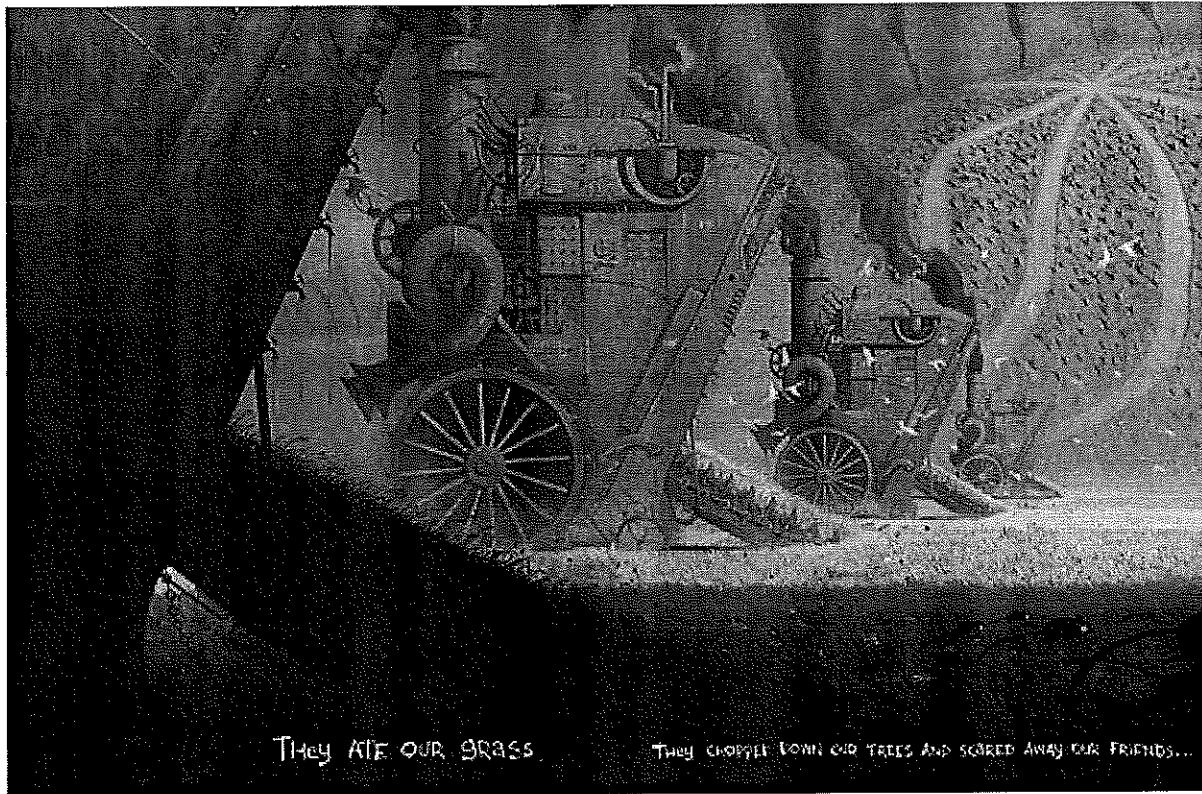
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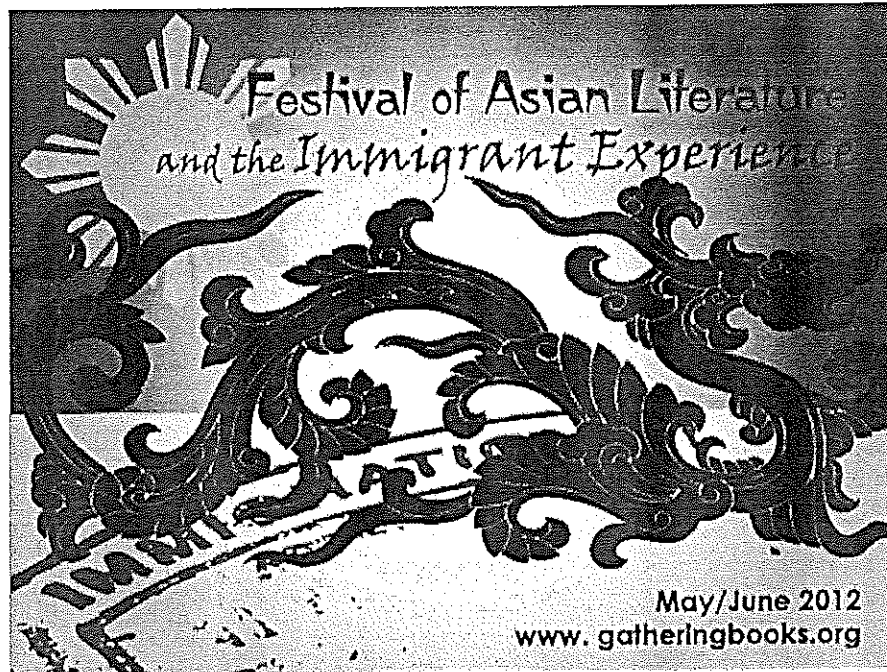
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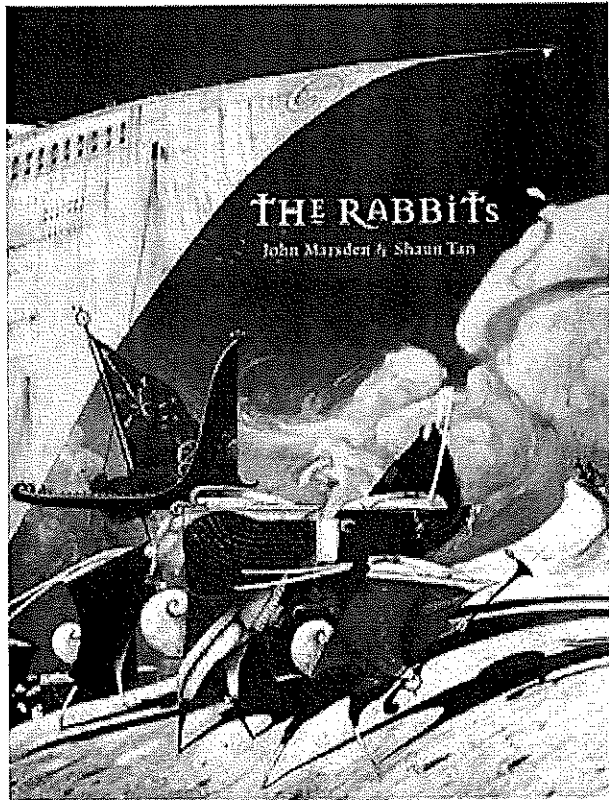
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Allegory and Artwork in John Marsden and Shaun Tan's "The Rabbits"

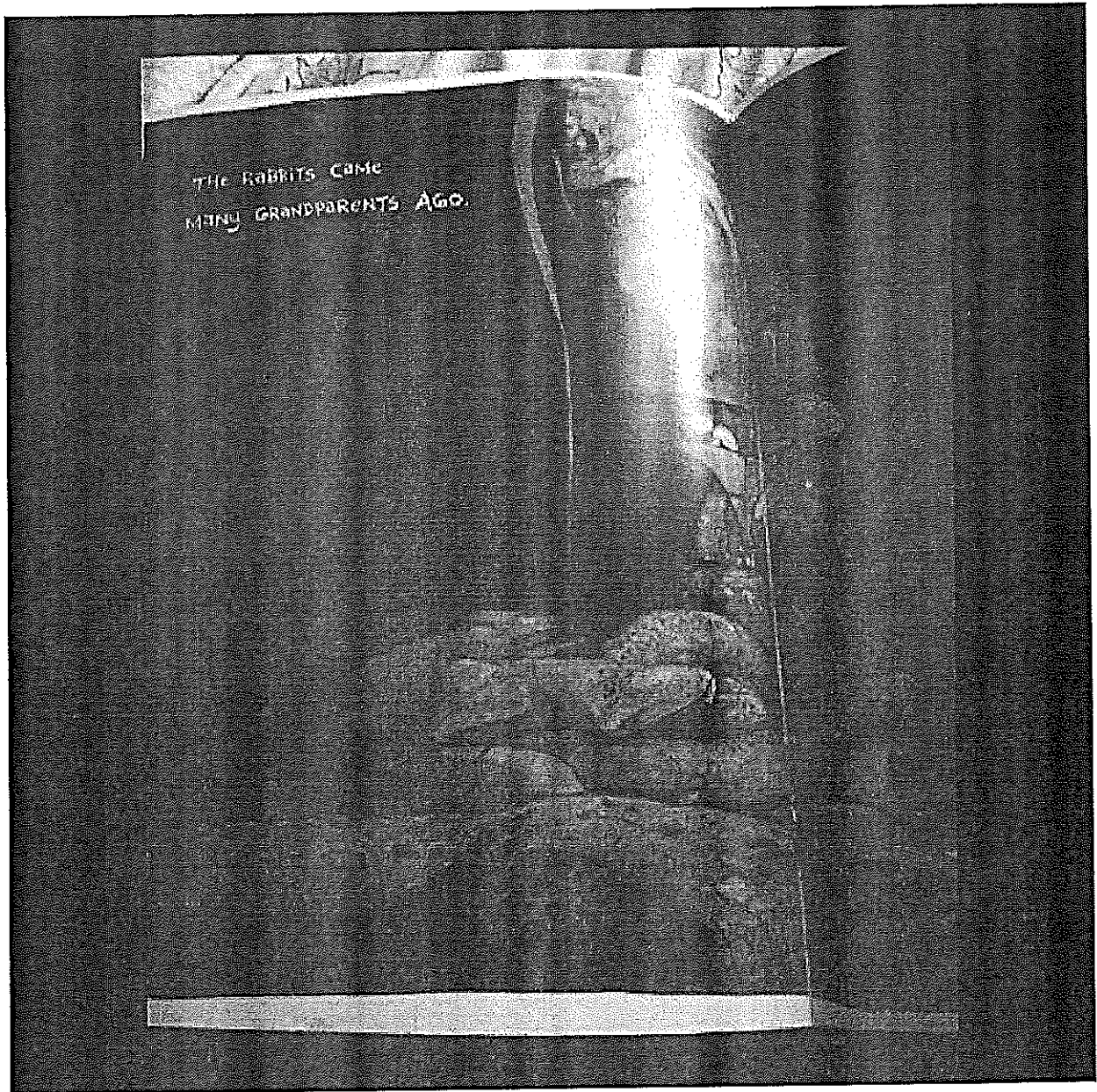
Posted on July 11, 2012 by Myra GB in [Asian Literature and Immigrant Experience](#), [Award-Winning](#), [AWB \(Award-Winning-Books\) 2012](#), [Book Reviews](#), [GB Challenges](#), [GB Reading Themes](#), [Immigrant Stories Challenge 2012](#), [Picture Book Challenge 2012](#), [Picture Books](#), [PoC Reading Challenge 2012](#), [Reading the World 2012](#) // 13 Comments



I didn't realize when we launched our bimonthly theme "Festival of Asian Literature and the Immigrant Experience" – that it would lead me to amazing books such as the one recommended to me by Benjamin Farr from Tanglin Trust School (check out their [library here](#)). I thought I have read all of Shaun Tan's books – apparently I missed out on a few, such as this one.



In most of the books that we have read which dealt with the immigrant experience, too often the stories are written from the perspective of the immigrant, the newcomer, the foreigner in the land. The reader is very seldom privy to what goes on in the heads of the 'natives'.

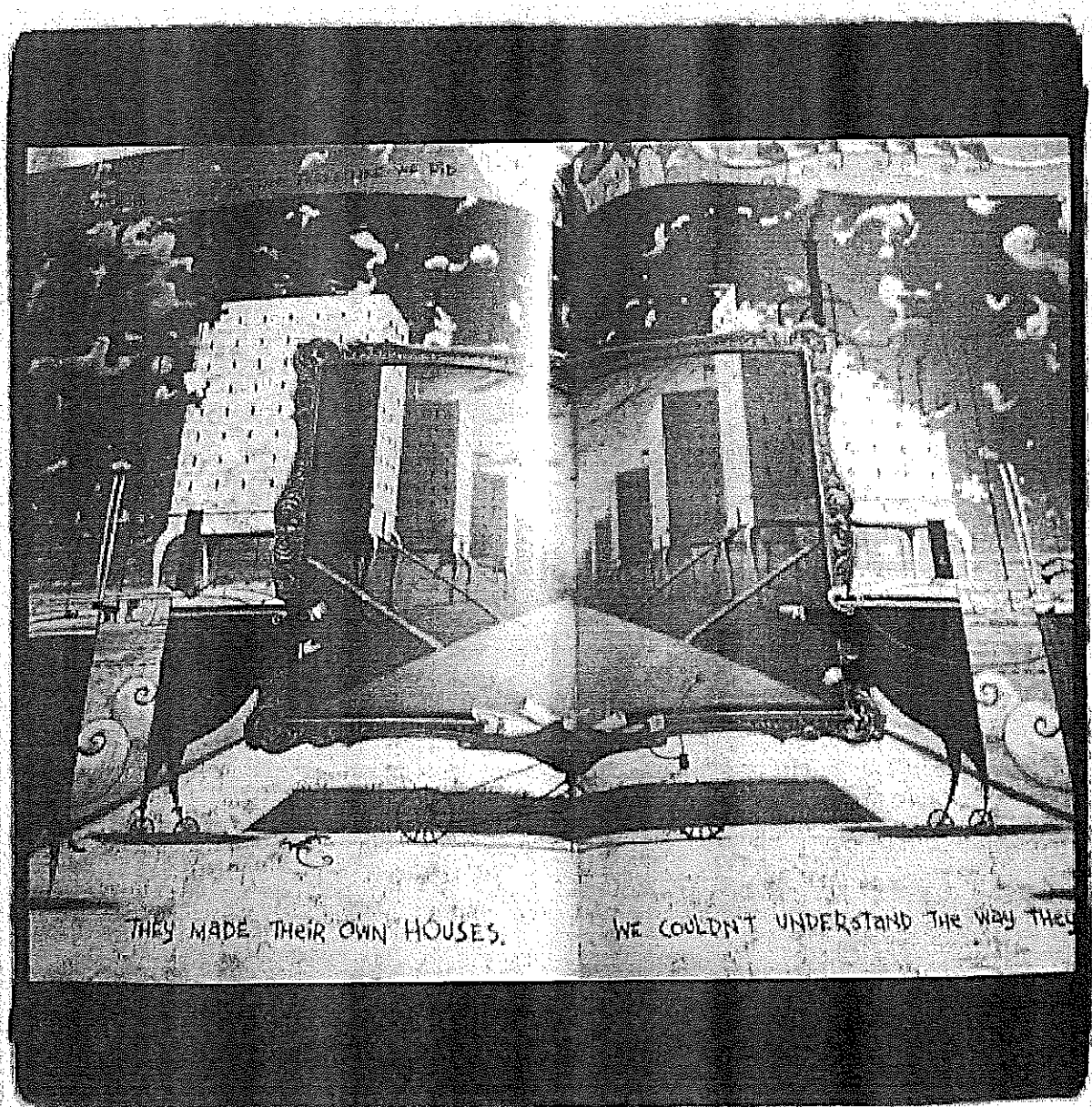


In John Marsden's *The Rabbits* one hears the sharp, no-nonsense, powerful voice of the natives (depicted here as numbats) who regard the 'rabbits' with a measure of distrust, caution, resentment, defeat, despair, and overwhelming sense of disquiet – all spoken in a matter-of-fact tone that pierces one's being to the core.

The narrative shows a linear, sequential progression with the rabbits arriving many grandparents ago (as seen in the photo above), and how the "*old people warned us: be careful. They won't understand the right ways*" (see photo below) – to the rabbits slowly coming in by water, then through various means – as they bring new food and other animals – and how they spread across the countries – and the fights, oh, the fights which the numbats lost.



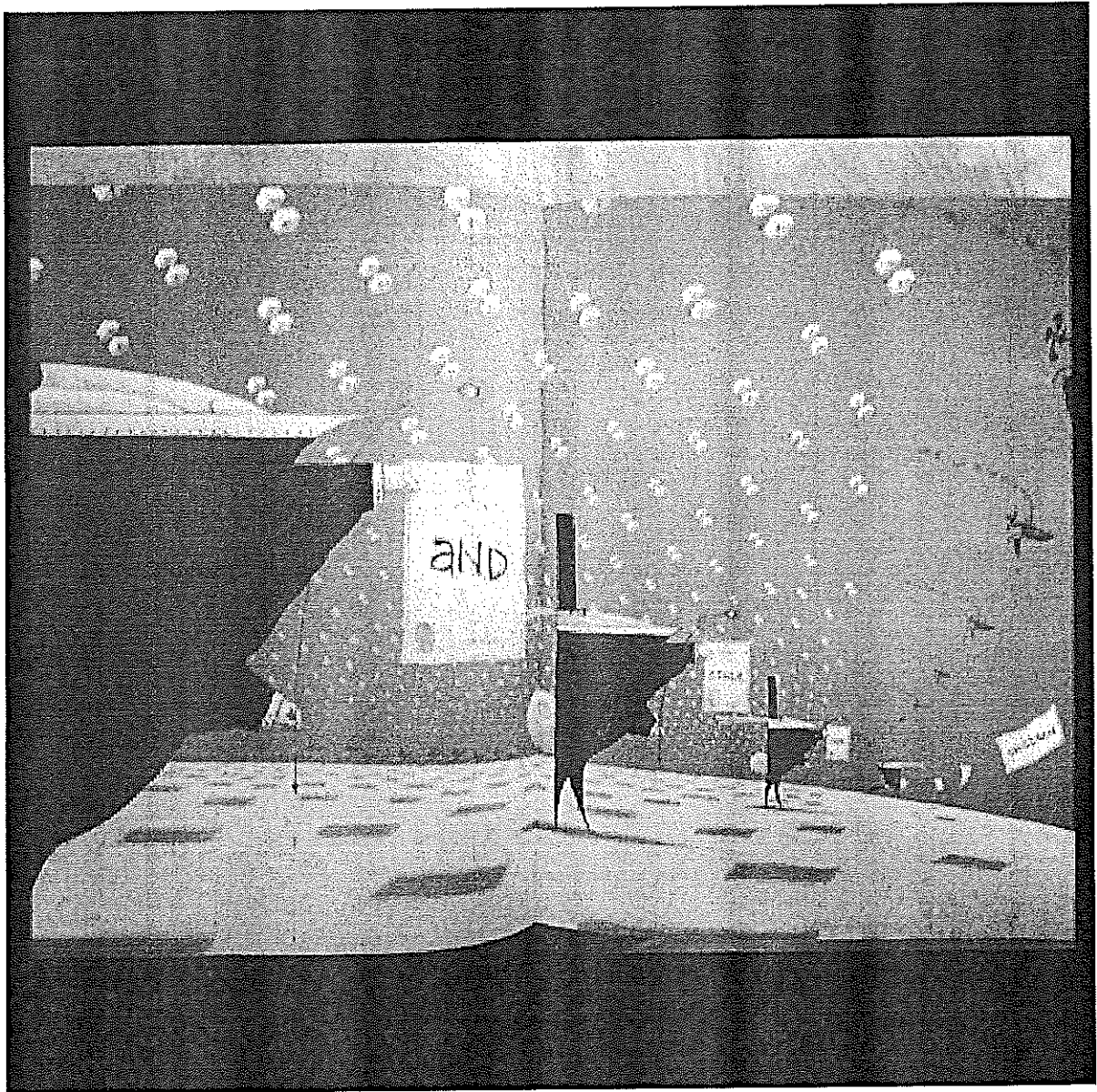
The rabbits after all looked high and mighty with their stiff, starched collars; pointed, upright ears; and their guns, cannons, high-tech weaponry firing in perfect formation – while the numbats carried spears and lived on trees and were subsequently outnumbered and outpowered.



The straightforward, deceptively-simple retelling of Australia's history is matched perfectly by Shaun Tan's amazingly-stunning artwork that complements the narrative with dark black spaces, monochrome illustrations of how the rabbits have overtaken the entire country (*"Rabbits, rabbits, rabbits. Millions and millions of rabbits. Everywhere we look there are rabbits."*), the sepia-toned undercurrents of loss and tragedy,



and the deliciously-surreal representation of all that is right and unjust, pure and sullied, and what it means to stand one's ground (regardless of how shaky and small and crumbling it is). The book is a reminder, as well, of what we value as we cry out in anguish and claim ownership of what is rightfully ours – as one's entire world is overtaken, captured, and judged to be less than what it is. My heart skipped a million beats when I opened this page that made me gasp out loud:



... and stole our children.

I was in Sydney when I watched the film, *Australia*, with Nicole Kidman and Hugh Jackman, and this clear snow-flurried page with the rabbits holding these signs just broke my heart – as it reminded me vividly of the film and the anguish that I witnessed then.



This is one of the most powerful picture books I have read this year. Teachers would have a field day integrating this with their social studies or history class, playing with the metaphors and the allegories, as they struggle to understand history from multiple points of view. For those who want more resources to understand the story line and the allegory better, here is an incisive scholarly piece by Brooke Collins-Gearing & Dianne Osland as published in *The Looking Glass: New Perspectives on Children's Literature*.

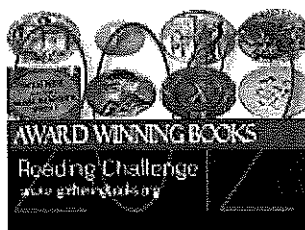
If you are expecting a neat and fine resolution, with all ends deftly tied – then you'd have to think again. I normally don't post spoilers here, since I don't want to ruin the book's experience for you, but I simply can't help but quote this plaintive cry found at the end of the book:

Where is the rich, dark earth, brown and moist? Where is the smell of rain dripping from the gum trees?

Where are the great billabongs alive with long-legged birds?

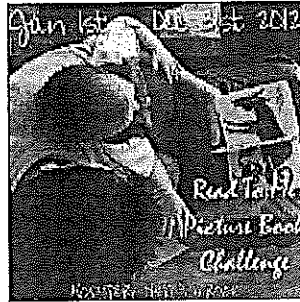
Who will save us from the rabbits?

Here is a video clip from Youtube as inspired by the book. Let me know what you think of it.

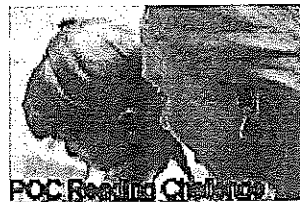


Picture Book of the Year – The Children's Book Council of Australia

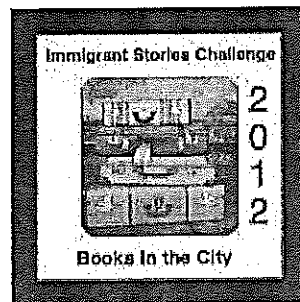
AWB Reading Challenge Update: 65 (35)



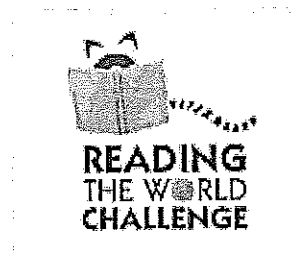
Picture Book Challenge Update: 69 of 120



PoC Reading Challenge Update: 26 (25)



Immigrant Stories Challenge Update: 13 (6)

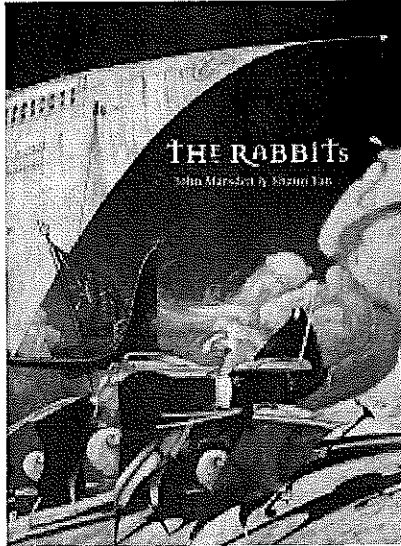


Reading the World Challenge Update: 5 of 7, nonfiction/allegory, Australia

<http://gatheringbooks.org/2012/07/11/the-rabbits-by-john-marsden-and-shaun-tan/> - this has the youtube links on it

The Rabbits – Teachers Notes

http://www.thearrival.com.au/downloads/TG_TheRabbits.pdf



The Rabbits.

John Marsden. Illustrated by Shaun Tan.
Vancouver, BC: Simply Read Books, 2003.
32 pp., cloth, \$23.95.
ISBN 0-9688768-8-9.

Subject Headings:
Rabbits-Juvenile fiction.
Imperialism-Juvenile fiction.

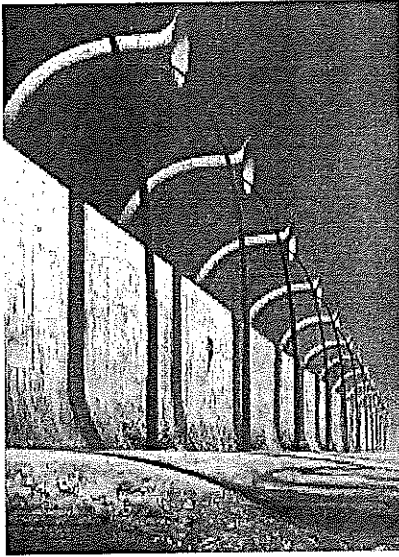
Grades 2 and up / Ages 7 and up.

Review by Sylvia Pantaleo.

****** /4**



The Rabbits is a compelling and disturbing allegory of colonization, industrialization and population growth. Many reviewers have used the word allegory to describe the book, but Shaun Tan, the illustrator, describes the book as a metaphor. Because Marsden is Australian, some have interpreted the story as the invasion of Australia by Europeans. However, the fundamental themes of the picture book are pertinent to humans throughout the world.



Text on the first verso reads, "The Rabbits came many grandparents ago." Initially, the inhabitants are tolerant of the newcomers, stating that, "At first we didn't know what to think. They looked a bit like us. There weren't many of them. Some were friendly." However, the elders' warning foreshadows the demise of the indigenous creatures and their land. As Rabbits continue to arrive in new and different ways, the original inhabitants begin to express concerns. A feeling of helplessness descends as the invaders take over and the illustrations communicate the imminent doom. On one double-page spread, Tan uses monochromatic colours to depict the conflict between the factions and the powerlessness of the native creatures. The collage-like appearance of this particular double-spread exacerbates the bleakness of the inhabitants' futures.

The Rabbits conquer the indigenous creatures. "We lost the fight." Tan juxtaposes the defeated native animals below the ground in bondage with the Rabbits above ground, their flags covering the land. The Rabbits continue to exploit the inhabitants and damage the environment. They commit the ultimate cruelty by stealing the children of the indigenous animals. An industrialized scene depicts the new status quo and the words "Might = Right" is inscribed at the bottom of a statute.

The Rabbits' legacy: destruction, desolation and despair. The book ends with the ultimate question, "Who will save us from the Rabbits?"

The text is minimal, yet the paucity of words is extremely effective. Tan uses colour and size symbolically in his stylized illustrations and the synergy between the text and illustrations is powerful. Many symbols are used throughout the text - the design on the Rabbits' flag, the clocks, and the arrows. The serenity of the end papers that depict waterfowl in a natural habitat are in stark contrast to the other illustrations in the book.

The Rabbits, first published in 1998, won the Australian Children's Book of the Year award in 1999. It also won the CBCA Picture Book of the Year Award. *The Rabbits* is an outstanding and sophisticated picture book that challenges and engages readers on multiple levels.

Highly Recommended.

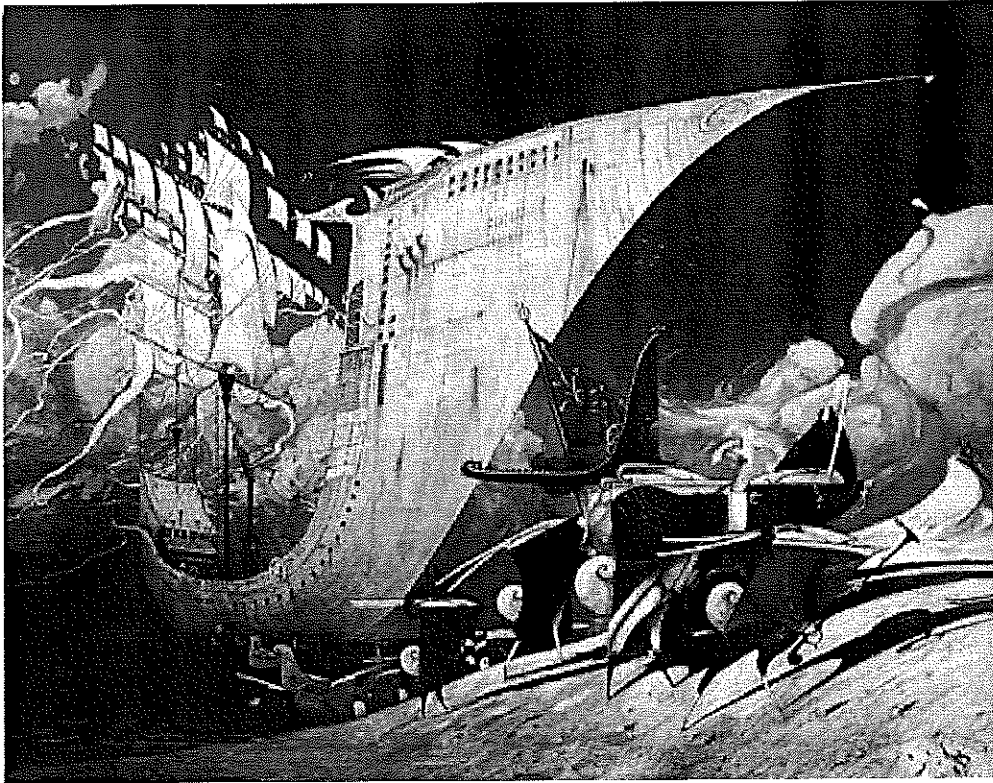
Sylvia Pantaleo is an Associate Professor of Language Arts in the Faculty of Education at BC's University of Victoria.

<http://www.umanitoba.ca/outreach/cm/vol10/no19/therabbits.html>

The Rabbits – John Marsden, illustrated by Shaun Tan

February 12, 2010 ~ Polly

I “met” Shaun Tan in the Byward Market in Ottawa when I was waiting for someone at the bookstore, and developed a serious crush on *The Arrival*, a story about immigration told entirely in pencil drawings. Then I learned about *The Rabbits*. And *Tales of Lost Suburbia*. And all of his other books, each more amazing than the last. In fact, I co-own all of them, thanks to a gift of a “complete set”. The set is “complete” until more books are published, and then I will just have to go out and re-complete it.



The Rabbits is a book about colonialism and its attendant evils (particularly environmental and cultural destruction), carried out with vigour and innocence by The Rabbits, who land in Australia and proceed to overrun it. Ecological history and human history meld. You could say that it’s an obvious metaphor, or you could say that it’s a brilliant parallel. I say “brilliant”.

Marsden uses words sparingly, and with effect. The sentences are clean and simple – there is dignity in them and a quiet despair. Tan, on the other hand, does not hold back with his illustrations. Sometimes simple, sometimes filled with activity, each one covers both pages. They are large, they are art, and in their colour and content they convey the various moods of Marsden’s text.

Tan has a gift for using unusual shapes to convey strangeness or making the strange seem almost natural (he also does this in *The Arrival*). The Rabbits look so...strangely familiarly Victorian (perhaps only familiar to colonials?)...with their machines, their high collars, their wig-like ears, their monocles and perambulators, their dark suits and long dresses, their hugs chests and tiny feet. Their Australian counterparts seem more real. Less strange. The world of pre-Rabbit Australia is serene and natural; post-Rabbit Australia is a contorted cacophony.

I’m not going to lie: it’s a scary book. It ends with tough questions, none of which have answers (ex. Who will save us from the Rabbits?). So if you like to know the answers, this

may not be the book for you. But it is a book for me, and I'm glad to have it...especially so as it is extremely difficult to get your hands on it in North America and it more or less had to be special-ordered through Australia (or something ridiculous like that). I don't know for sure, I just know that of the "complete set", this book was delivered nearly a month after all of the others had arrived. It was well worth the wait.

I think *The Rabbits* is appropriate for people of many ages because although there aren't many words, this book generates a lot of thought and questions, and older readers might have a better understanding of "Rabbits aren't actually scary and bad, they are just a *symbol*." The illustrations also use techniques (simplicity, complexity, organization of shapes and – unless I am mistaken – are done in different media) that could be appreciated by a budding artist, and the book has a message that people of all ages can appreciate. It is one of my favourite Shaun Tan books.

Favourite Line: At first we didn't know what to think. They looked a bit like us. There weren't many of them. Some were friendly.

Reading Ages: 5 and up.

Rating: A

<https://vickyandpolly.wordpress.com/2010/02/12/the-rabbits-john-marsden-illustrated-by-shaun-tan/>

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[Home](#) > [Vol 14, No 2 \(2010\)](#) > [Collins-Gearing](#)

Alice's Academy

Caroline Jones, editor

Who will save us from the rabbits?: rewriting the past allegorically

Brooke Collins-Gearing & Dianne Osland

Brooke Collins-Gearing is a Murri woman who teaches in Children's literature and Indigenous literature at the University of Newcastle. Her research has focused on representations of Aboriginality and non-Aboriginality in Australian children's literature.

Dianne Osland lectures in English Literature at the University of Newcastle, Australia, and

her publications include work on the problems of identifying and interpreting metaphor in fiction. She is currently engaged in research on reading practices and cultural change.

In 1992, the Australian High Court recognised that the Murray Islanders held native title rights over their land, effectively debunking the doctrine of *terra nullius*. This became known as the Mabo Decision, as the key plaintiff was Eddie Mabo, a traditional custodian of the land. The Mabo Decision has been the most influential legal decision in this country in defining the rights of Indigenous Australians in a “post-colonial” society. Hence, pre-Mabo and post-Mabo have come to signify the strong colonial framework before 1992 and the legally altered one after the decision. But what Larissa Behrendt terms a *psychological terra nullius* continues to pervade non-Indigenous representations of history and colonisation (Behrendt 20). We argue in this paper that Australian children’s literature, in particular, is still coming to terms with this psychological *terra nullius*, leading to a clash of pre-Mabo metanarratives of settlement and post-Mabo awareness of invasion and dispossession. Post-Mabo, non-Indigenous representations face the dilemma of acknowledging the presence of Indigenous peoples within colonialist frameworks built on the doctrine of *terra nullius*. That is, myths of white settlement have been, and continue to be, the basis for ideological, institutional and societal practices and beliefs that centre non-Indigenous cultures and relegate Indigenous cultures to the margins. We have chosen John Marsden and Shaun Tan’s 1998 multi-award-winning text *The Rabbits* as the focus of our examination because of its attempt to enter into and reflect recent national and historical dialogues about the construction of Australia’s history. In this text that deals explicitly with colonisation as a form of invasion and dispossession, we wish to examine Australia’s psychological *terra nullius* in terms of how it tries to create and invoke a post-Mabo collective identity.

The Rabbits was a timely publication, capturing – indeed, some claimed it was capitalizing on – the growing momentum of public sentiment that would eventually result in the newly elected Prime Minister’s 2008 apology to Indigenous Australians. A picture book with sparse text, *The Rabbits* is an allegorical representation of colonization. Small numbat-like marsupials [1] are dispossessed of their families, their communities, and their country [2] by invading Rabbits who have taken domestication to a level of ruthless efficiency: the Rabbits arrive with all the trappings of European culture – its clothes, agriculture, industry, and economy – and proceed to exploit the land to the point of devastation. And they steal the Numbats’ children. The text’s allegorical nature extends its ability both to create and to evoke colonial “memories” of invasion and dispossession. *The Rabbits*’ polemical nature, softened by the surreal images and spare text, informs the reader of the destructive power of colonisation.

While the images of the land and the creatures inhabiting it clearly locate the story in an Australian context, both the editorial blurb and Shaun Tan’s comments on his illustrations claim a broader reference. It is seen as “a rich and haunting allegory of colonization for all ages and cultures, told from the viewpoint of native animals” (*The Rabbits* publisher’s blurb) and a “partly allegorical fable about colonisation, told from the viewpoint of the colonised” (Tan “Shaun Tan”); internationally, readers seem to have little trouble generalizing beyond its regional particularity to identify a global significance in an allegory, not simply of colonization, but also of industrialization and ecological destruction more generally. It is a clever, earnest book that seemingly presses all the right buttons; it has won awards nationally and internationally (including the Children’s Book Council of Australia Picture Book of the

Year in 1999), and it has quickly made its way into school curricula. But the simple language, striking illustrations, and Picture Book of the Year Award [3] do not disguise or divert attention from the contested dialogue about Australia's history that it has entered into, nor from the problematic notions of identity (both for Indigenous and non-Indigenous Australians) that it evokes. The narrative constructs dichotomous representations of the "coloniser" (Rabbits) and "colonised" (Numbats): strong, weak; modern, ancient; civilised, primitive; centre, peripheral; conqueror, victim. Such binary oppositions are a legacy of pre-Mabo colonialist discourses in Australian children's literature and reveal the text's seemingly neutral colonialist discourses to be rooted in colonialist ideologies and legacies.

While the Rabbits in the illustrations look like Europeans (long ears excepted), walk upright like Europeans, and dress like Europeans, the marsupials look like small furry animals; they are, moreover, for the most part helpless bystanders. In *Reading Race*, Clare Bradford has argued that *The Rabbits* contributes to the history of "Aboriginalism" in Australian children's literature: "the first-person account of the events of colonisation constructs the Indigenous as stupid and helpless, locking them into the posture of victims... the indigenous creatures who tell their story are naked and vulnerable, always the objects of the gaze of the colonising Rabbits" (113) and Aboriginality is further essentialized by the idea that Indigenous peoples are "primitive victims incapable of assuming agency in their own interests, unable to adjust or adapt to new and troubling times" (114). While we wish to extend the analysis of this essentialised and Aboriginalist version of Australia's history as represented in *The Rabbits*, we also want to trace another consequence of white Australia's "psychological *terra nullius*" on the depiction of colonial occupation. It is not just the representation of the "Numbats" that is problematic, but also the text's struggle to depict and position the "Rabbits".

The Rabbits overtly acknowledges that the landscape was inhabited before colonisation: its narrative, illustrations and themes attempt to deal with the coming of the Rabbits, their impact on the land and its original inhabitants (including the stealing of children), the losing battle the original inhabitants face, and the final question of a needed saviour. While the white Rabbits represent the British colonisers, the Indigenous peoples are represented by a nameless marsupial – variously identified by reviewers as bandicoots, tree kangaroos, even "bush babies", but most closely resembling a numbat, a small, furry, white-banded creature, with a long bushy tail, that feeds mainly on termites and is currently classified, ominously enough, as an endangered species. The narrative is ostensibly from the original creature's point of view, yet in the telling the colonized are perceived from the colonisers' point of view, and, in the illustrations and in the outcome, the overall impact is one of the destructiveness of colonisation and the potential demise of the colonised. It is a one way, linear master narrative of history and events, an allegory of the dominance of the colonisers, their slow destruction of the land and its creatures and of the experience of loss, sickness and surrender by those who have been colonised. The Rabbits arrive, they conquer both the landscape and the "Numbats", and the "Numbats" are powerless to fight against them.

If we apply Behrendt's idea of psychological *terra nullius* here, we can see how the text struggles to subvert pre-Mabo narratives of Australia as an empty landscape and replace it instead with a narrative of invasion and dispossession. Non-Aboriginality is constructed on agrarian, pastoralist and scientific superiority, that is, the land was seen as empty because it was not being used the way the colonisers believed it should be. This belief provided justification for the taking of Indigenous land but the text somewhat subverts this by showing how the colonisers, with their superior ways, then destroyed the environment. The text struggles to come to terms with a non-Aboriginality that overpowered Indigenous Australians

and a non-Aboriginality that acknowledges that dispossession. The post-Mabo struggle to place the Rabbits within the landscape sees them retain their power and force to the detriment of everyone and everything around them. The narrative acknowledges a post-Mabo awareness of dispossessing the original inhabitants, but is confined by a pre-Mabo collective memory of colonialist superiority that can conceive of only one kind of story to tell.

It is a story that is framed by the act of colonisation. Both the illustrations and the text start with the arrival of the Rabbits and end with the dominance of the Rabbits. According to Tan, this was a conscious choice: the cover illustration mimics a nineteenth-century painting by E. Phillips Fox depicting the arrival of European settlement according to “a familiar ideology, all about progress and destiny, the planting of flags and the arrival of legitimate historical narrative” (Tan, “Originality and Creativity”). But even, ostensibly, in telling this story from the viewpoint of the colonised, it perpetuates that colonialist ideology (particularly for readers – young and old – unable to recognise the ideological freight carried by the framing device). The narrative seems to suggest that this is the only version of history that needs to be told – anything before it is unnecessary. The telling of the tale “from the viewpoint of the colonised” thus becomes even more problematic, imposing on the original inhabitants of the land a decidedly Western temporal perspective. In contrast, Indigenous views of time as cyclical do not always separate these acts of invasion and colonisation from other important moments in Indigenous life and knowledges. That is, in concentric circles, colonisation, particularly the removal of children, remains close in time. It is not an event that happened in the past and is nearly or easily forgotten. But in *The Rabbits*, the original creatures appear only in relation to the act of colonisation; any notion of pre-existence is unnecessary and therefore pre-historical. This serves to reinforce the Western linear approach to time, movement from one period to the next and therefore movement further away from the original period: that is, the book starts with the arrival of the Rabbits and Numbats’ existence before this is now long gone and forgotten.

The illustrations also contribute to the narrative’s struggle to re-tell the story of invasion and ultimately reinforce the colonised perspective as the marginal one. Indeed, the Numbats are peripheral in most of the illustrations, and peripheral to the Rabbit’s society. In one particular, predominantly black and white, image, the Numbats are fringe-dwellers in the Rabbits’ world, homeless, on the grog (evidenced by discarded bottles), living rough out of cardboard boxes placed beneath a “Might=Right” sign. In the middle of the book there is a double page spread where the Numbats appear to be actively resisting the invasion of the Rabbits, “but there were too many” and the following page shows them curled up underground. In most of the illustrations and accompanying text the focus is on the Rabbits, their tools and power, their destruction of the land and all of its original inhabitants and their presiding dominance over the landscape: “Rabbits, rabbits, rabbits. Millions and millions of rabbits. Everywhere we look there are rabbits”. Towards the end of the book, all colour has slowly faded and blackness dominates the illustrations. The land changes from colour and abundance to “bare and brown” and empty. While the narrative tries to readdress pre-Mabo colonialist discourses that built on the doctrine of *terra nullius*, the illustrations contribute to the belief that if the land was not empty of “natives” before the arrival of the invaders, it became emptied of them soon after. The illustrations extend the pre-Mabo framework confining the narrative, only allowing them to position the Numbats as destitute and stricken. Outlines of the Numbats, curled in tight balls resembling the imprint of ammonite fossils, appear to be dotted underground, beneath the surface which is dominated by the Rabbits and their flags. The result is that the Numbats remain peripheral to the centred power of the Rabbits. What becomes important is what the Rabbits do, not what the Numbats do. Hence

the text reverts to pre-Mabo colonialist structures and perspectives, even to the point of being reminiscent of colonial beliefs that the “natives” would eventually all die out.

While the narrative attempts to replace a pre-Mabo representation of “discovery” and “settlement” with a post-Mabo construction of invasion and destruction, it struggles to position the Rabbits in relation to both the Numbats and the land. The coloniser’s perspective is enforced in the text by the idea that the Rabbits conclusively defeated the Numbats. While the resistance of the “Numbats” is apparent in Tan’s double page illustration, in sepia-tinted cameos, of the Numbats sabotaging the Rabbits’ technology and engaging in sporadic or collective warfare, the following page blatantly states “We lost the fights”, as if subsequent ongoing fights for self-determination and sovereignty never occurred. By establishing the Rabbits as the dominant conquerors and the Numbats as the helpless victims, the Rabbits remain as invaders unreconciled with the landscape, yet it is their ideological and cultural norms that rule the land. If *The Rabbits* is portraying the history of contact, then it is a history that assumes that the Rabbits came out the winners and the Numbats still need saving. Throughout the text, in both the written narrative and the illustrations, colonisation is represented as a one way journey: the colonisers came in, they won the battles, they remain today the winners and those in positions of power: “They brought new food, and they brought other animals. We liked some of the food and we liked some of the animals. But some of the food made us sick, and some of the animals scared us”.

And what does this say about Aboriginal resistance and survival – then and now (to follow the linear idea of time as upheld by the text)? The images in the text attach colour and movement to the Rabbits’ side of the land, while the Numbats’ side is barren and brown. The barrenness of the Numbat’s world is compounded by their amorphous nonentity, they become little more than underground, fossilised skeletons. The use of a nameless creature to represent the Indigenous peoples is potentially a powerful technique, as Indigenous Australians did not refer to themselves as “Indigenous” or “Aboriginal” prior to invasion. However, the clumping together of all Indigenous Australians as one group disregards cultural diversity and the different experiences of colonisation. By establishing a colonial dichotomy of “us” and “them”, “Rabbits” and “Numbats”, the narrative also ignores the influence of other migrant peoples since colonisation, and the effects of intermarrying. [4] Furthermore, the representation of the colonised people as living in trees is, to say the least, unfortunate. In the spirit of *terra nullius*, the original inhabitants are hardly distinguishable from the other native flora and fauna as represented in the book, and one is reminded of section 127 of the Australian Constitution pre-1967, where Aboriginal Australians were not classified as people but as part of the flora and fauna. While the Rabbits look like people and act like people, the “Numbats” never cease to be animals, which pre-empt any notion that the Rabbits could learn or gain anything valuable from the colonised. The erasure of all but an impotent few Numbats erases also the opportunity that always existed, and still exists, for dialogue between non-Aboriginal and Aboriginal voices. By establishing such strict and explicit boundaries between the Rabbits and the Numbats (modern and “natural”, destructive and overwhelmed, winner and loser) the narrative struggles to re-write pre-Mabo settlement myths with a post-Mabo awareness that the land was wrongfully taken and the colonisers’ have built a whole nation on this theft. It attempts to raise and employ post-Mabo awareness and concepts, but, in fact, its passive ideologies simply re-inscribe the perceived hopelessness of pre-Mabo Indigenous peoples as subjugated and victimised.

While the text attempts to acknowledge some of the injustices done to the Indigenous peoples of Australia, it struggles to (re)define what this then means for the construction of “non-

Aboriginality” and the colonisers’ relationship with place. In presenting the Rabbits as having the power to chain, ignore, represent and even speak for the Numbats, the narrative constructs the identity of the colonised as “the passive victim on display” (Chow 29). Raimond Gaita, in relation to coercive reconciliation, has argued that

Good-hearted people find it intolerable that just treatment of the powerless should depend on the generosity of the powerful – on their pity or even on their openness to an appeal to justice. Since at least 1788, the refusal to accept this has driven the rhetoric of human rights in a noble attempt to bestow dignity on the powerless by creating the illusion that rights are a kind of moral force field, a metaphysical barrier to the indignity of being ruthlessly crushed. I do not need your pity. I do not need your justice gratuitously given. I will stand on my rights. That is the spirit of it, a spirit of defiance. It is an illusion, I fear. Unless an appeal to rights has force to back it, its acknowledgement depends entirely on the spirit of justice in those to whom the appeal was made. (304-5)

Marsden and Tan’s narrative identifies the “native” as lack – “someone from whom something has been stolen” (Rey Chow 31). Chow, employing the work of Fanon, examines how postcolonial fiction constructs the image of the “other’s” subjectivity through the gaze of the oppressor: “The image, then, is an aggressive sight that reveals itself in the other; it is the site of the aggressed. Moreover, the image is what has been devastated, left bare, and left behind by aggression” (31). And it is here that we see the text’s struggle with mainstream Australia’s psychological *terra nullius* in full colour: the presence of the Numbats, their loss and their lack is what defines the presence of the Rabbits: “Our fascination with the native, the oppressed, the savage, and all such figures is therefore a desire to hold on to an unchanging certainty somewhere outside our own ‘fake’ experience. It is a desire for being ‘non-duped’, which is a not-too-innocent desire to seize control” (53).

The final page serves to reinforce the Rabbits’ need to seize control and Numbats’ status as helpless and demoralised creatures in need of rescue: “Who will save us from the rabbits?” The text reinforces colonialist assumptions that Aboriginal Australians cannot determine their own lives or their own futures. Potentially the ending could be read as exposing the continual control Western society has over Aboriginal peoples and their lives; however, presenting the Numbats as in need of a saviour denies their ability to save themselves. Centring the colonisers’ perspective, and effectively colonising the original inhabitants’ voice, silences the colonised, denying their ability to speak for themselves, refusing them the right to their own identity and history. And while some may argue that this is an accurate reflection of the history of colonisation, the text’s attempt to acknowledge a post-Mabo landscape of invasion and dispossession is undercut by pre-Mabo suppression of Indigenous voices, leaving no space to address injustices and denial of Indigenous rights. The final illustration of the intruding blackness upon the two figures – one rabbit, one original creature, sitting opposite each other on the edge of a pond that is the last remnant of the great billabong – is ambiguous at best. There is the potential to read this final image as a sign of hope, for the possibility of equal and shared communication between Rabbit and Numbat. However, the text implies that now both the Rabbit and Numbat need help – a saviour of some sort. It removes the option for the Rabbits to change their ways and acknowledge their power in what Gaita terms “the spirit of justice”: “The Aborigines have no power worth speaking of. If their voices are to be heard, if they dare speak from their hearts seriously to challenge our assumptions, be they assumptions of the Right or the Left, then it will be because we – the non-Aboriginal population – will have been moved by the spirit of justice to listen” (305).

As an allegory of colonisation, *The Rabbits* appears to be exposing the horrors of colonial exploitation, yet in its representation of “they came, they saw and they conquered”, even this post-Mabo perspective maintains the white metanarrative of history as war and winning. If the battle was fought and won (by the Rabbits) and the Numbats are only dwelling in the peripheral shade (both physically and historically), simply sitting back and waiting to be saved, [5] then this representation upholds the idea that modernity, civilisation, progress and the white man were unavoidable and remain so today, that the tools and knowledges of the Rabbits were too much for the poor nameless creatures to deal with, and therefore at some point progress was going to arrive.

The unspoken, and often unthinking, subtext of allegory is well-argued by James Clifford in his study of its use in ethnographic writing. In *Writing Cultures*, he points out that “Allegory (Gr. *Allos*, “other”, and *agorevein*, “to speak”) usually denotes a practice in which a narrative fiction continuously refers to another pattern of ideas or events. It is a representation that ‘interprets’ itself” (Clifford 99). In the case of *The Rabbits*, the text refers to patterns and ideas from Western colonisation and reinterprets not only what this means but the impact and power it has. So once again, the cultural framework for the narrative and its reader is a non-Indigenous, colonial, Western one. The power to construct the allegory and tell it has remained with “the Rabbits” and associated with this power is its intended interpretation and moral connotations. Clifford also states that “Allegory prompts us to say of any cultural description not ‘this represents, or symbolizes, that’ but rather, ‘this is a (morally charged) story about that’” (100). *The Rabbits*, in its depiction of the power of the Rabbits and their destructive power over the land, then becomes a morally charged retelling of the nation’s collective memory of colonisation. Pre-Mabo, the collective Australian psyche, and its doctrine of *terra nullius*, depended on being “morally” and legally right (the justification for invasion, protection, segregation, assimilation etc). Post-Mabo, the nation’s psychological *terra nullius* now has to come to terms with being morally “wrong”. However, the use of allegory, with its attenuation of the specifically Australian experience of colonisation, encourages selective blindness and political forgetfulness. The specific metaphor of colonisation (in this instance a rabbit plague) carries with it assumptions about the actual process – in this instance, as an unavoidable and essentially amoral natural phenomenon (what could be more natural than breeding like Rabbits?) that efface realities that can then be ignored.

Read as an allegory of colonisation, *The Rabbits* relocates the significance of the narrative beyond the specific context in which the story takes place, so that the particular and personal are appropriated and diminished, extinguishing a sense of personal investment and responsibility in the specific Australian context. It is a psychological *terra nullius* of a particularly insidious kind, emptying the land of meaning except as it “stands for” a bigger picture and larger historical, economic and environmental issues. The allegorical nature of the text and its embedded moral attachment also imply a “right” reading of the text. Allegory does require an active reader: the connections between the narrative and symbolic levels may be obvious, but they still need to be made by the reader — though the age at which children acquire the metaphorical competence to make such connections without guidance is still hotly debated. But more so than in other types of imaginative fiction, once the connection is established, interpretative options are severely curtailed. Tan denies that the book is didactic, arguing that “It’s up to the reader to draw whatever meaning they wish” (“Originality and Creativity”), yet reviews of the book that are critical of its heavy-handedness (most obvious, perhaps, in its reference to stolen children, which Tan seems to be trying to disengage from its jarringly literal historical context by an illustration that sees the children carried off in

squadrons of box-kites) attack it for its “political correctness”, which implies not only a “closed” interpretation of the text but a “morally charged” one as well. The post-Mabo perspective relies on an allegory based on a pre-Mabo cultural framework that silences the possibility for Indigenous voices to engage in a dialogue with non-Indigenous ones.

Notes

1. For the purposes of this paper, the nameless creatures in the text will be referred to as numbats, which they most closely (though not exactly) resemble.
2. Prime Minister Rudd’s “Apology to Australia’s Indigenous People” makes specific reference to “the removal of Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander children from their families, their communities and their country” (Address to Parliament 13th February, 2008).
3. The book advertises itself as suitable “for all ages, all cultures” (back cover), though Tan claims it was “originally conceived as a book for older readers” (“Shaun Tan: Picture Books”).
4. The analogy of colonisation to an invasion of rabbits not only disregards the cultural diversity of generations of colonisers but also glosses over instances of a more malevolent dispossession. Not all of the colonisers were instruments of merely collateral damage in their destruction of the Indigenous population in pursuit of economic imperatives. Some meant to do it.
5. Unsworth and Wheeler, in their positive analysis of *The Rabbits* (in which they refer to the original inhabitants as bandicoots), identify the way in which this passivity informs the language: “In several of the beginning illustrations the bandicoots are seen holding their spears just watching the rabbits. The rabbits, however, are seen as very active right from the start, driving, studying and measuring. This is mirrored in the text by the agentive roles taken by the rabbits and the bandicoots in relation to the kinds of processes represented by different verbs. The rabbits have active agentive roles with verbs like “made”, “brought”, “came”, “spread”, “ate”, “chopped” and “stole”. The bandicoots are less involved with words of action and more involved with communicative and mental process verbs like “warned” and “liked”. When they are involved in action, it is significantly negative – “lost”. (72).

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Passionate about picturebooks

Welcome to my blog about picturebooks in ELT.

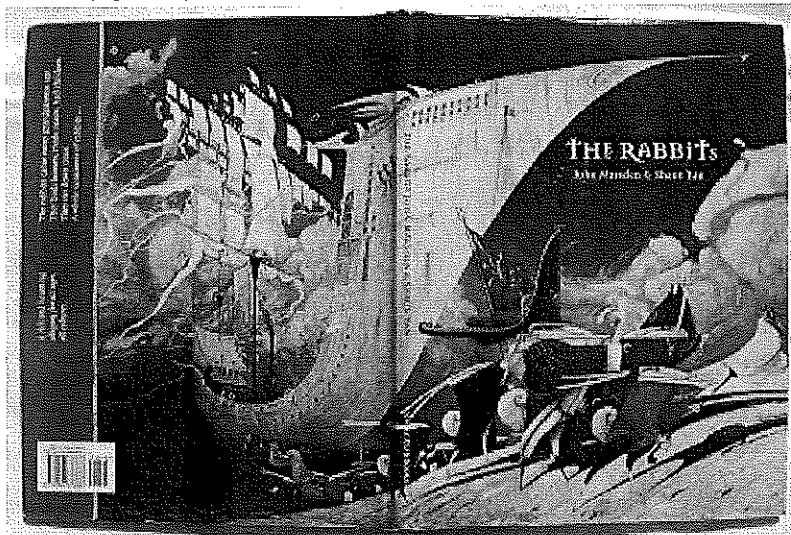
"A picturebook is text, illustrations, total design; an item of manufacture and a commercial product; a social, cultural, historic document; and foremost, an experience for a child. As an art form it hinges on the interdependence of pictures and words, on the simultaneous display of two facing pages, and on the drama of the turning page."
(Barbara Bader 1976:1)

My intention is to discuss picturebooks, in particular the pictures in them! Why? Because, in ELT we tend to select picturebooks because they contain words our students might know. I plan to write something a couple of times a month, sharing what I discover in my readings; describe new titles I come across; discuss particular illustrators and their styles and generally promote the picture in picturebooks.

From January 2008 to December 2011 I benefitted from a PhD research grant from ECT, in Portugal.

Wednesday, March 07, 2012

The rabbits came many grandparents ago



Front and back covers

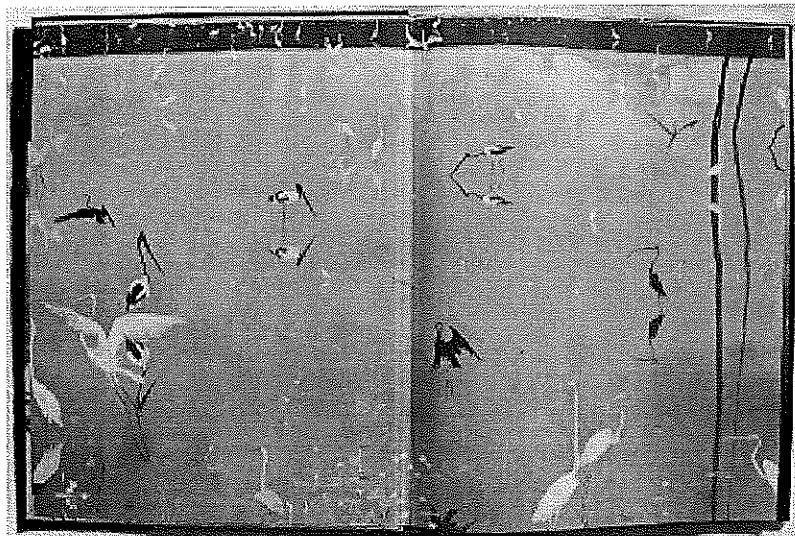
The Rabbits by John Marsden and Shaun Tan is one of those picturebooks that leaves you gaping from a mixture of shock and admiration. It was the third picturebook illustrated by Shaun Tan to reach my bookshelf and to be featured on this blog. I've featured The Lost Thing and The red tree.

Both Marsden and Tan are Australians and through this picturebook make a very clear statement about cultural awareness, expertly creating an allegorical tale of colonialism. *The Rabbits* has been used in secondary schools since it was published in 1998 in areas of the curriculum that include English, Art and Technology, Philosophy, History, Geography and Environmental Studies. But has it been used in ELT? Let's see if I can convince the readers of my blog to consider its possibilities.

I've taken a photo of the front and back covers together - the image is so powerful: a huge ship with a pointed, harpoon-like prow. Napoleon-like creatures stalk around on pin legs, we

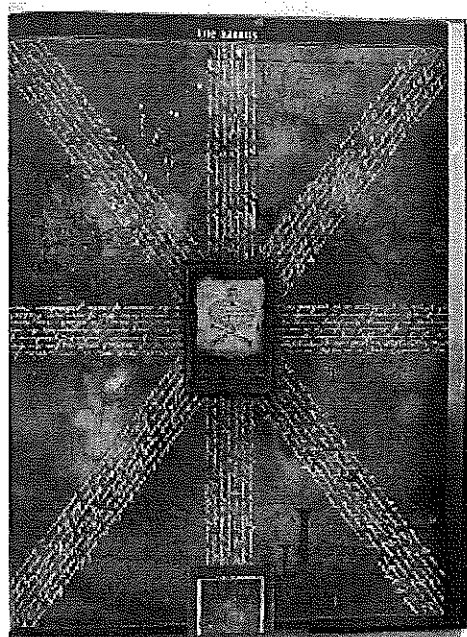
can't quite make out what they are... though from the title they have to be rabbits. That strip of red on the back cover is actually a collage, a piece of red cloth, fraying at the edges. Could it be from the flags? Or from the invader's coat? The words on this fraying piece read:

"The rabbits came many grandparents ago.
They built houses, made roads, had children.
They cut down trees.
A whole continent of rabbits ..."



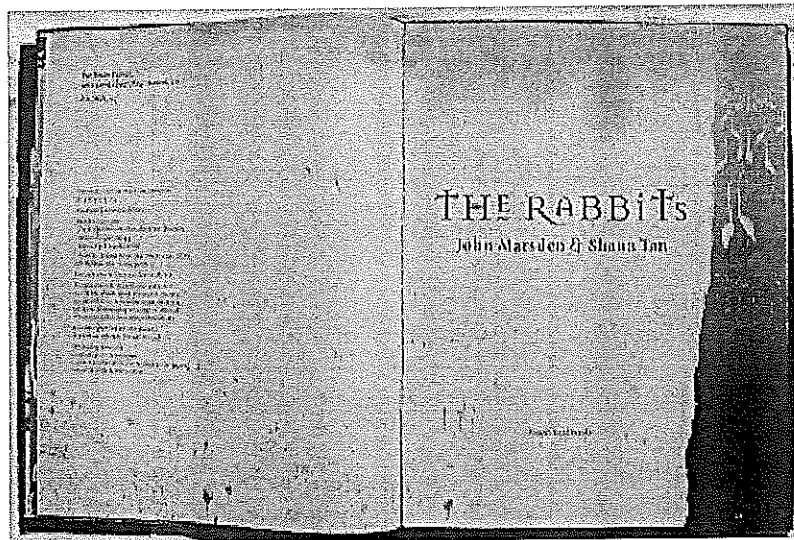
The front endpapers

The endpapers are a calm blue-lilac. Clean water, the home to graceful, long legged birds. What a contrast to the front cover. Is this the land these invaders have arrived at, that they will soon be invading?

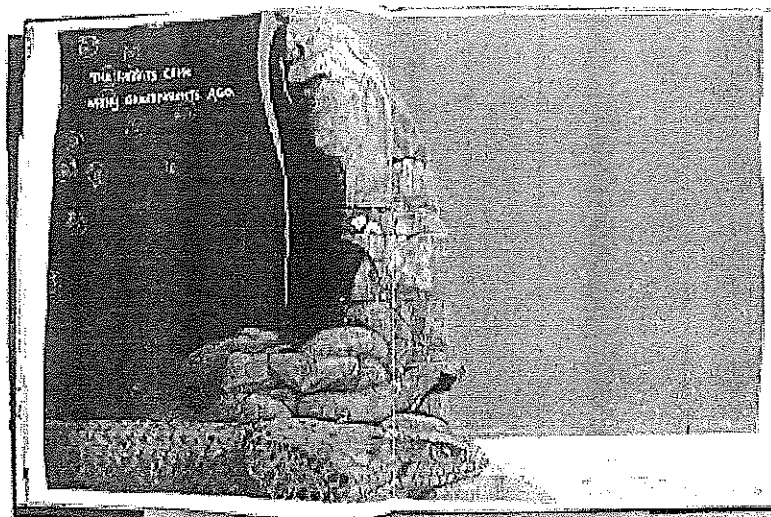


The half title page

The dark brown half title page imitates the format of a well known flag, with pen-inked squiggly writing and some sort of shield in the centre, superimposed over a map. You can peer and peer, but nothing can be discerned or made out.



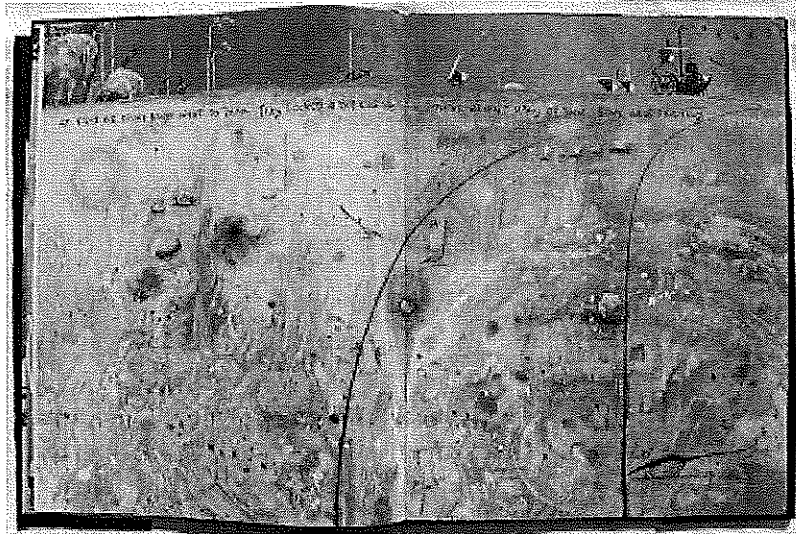
The title page comes next: a ripped sheet of paper, covering that blue-lilac bird-filled lake. We can see that some of the paper has begun to soak up the water, turning the white into a creeping grey, the birds are moving away from us, their backs are turned and they are all looking to the right, they've seen something we can't see yet. The white paper is both a cover as well as a vehicle for the pond life, as flowers are growing from its edges and dragon flies hum towards the dedications. The title font, as on the front cover, is not quite normal, the 'e' has a strange wave under it and the 't' is uncharacteristic. Are these letters from a past, letters that have changed over time to those we know and recognize today?



Opening 1

Opening 1 confirms our haunch, the birds are indeed fleeing, if the book had sound we would hear their calls of alarm, we would hear the snakes hiss in warning. What is that strange black chimney in the horizon? What are the fossil-like shapes in the dark cave behind the snakes? Does Tan want us to think of the time these fossils have taken to form?

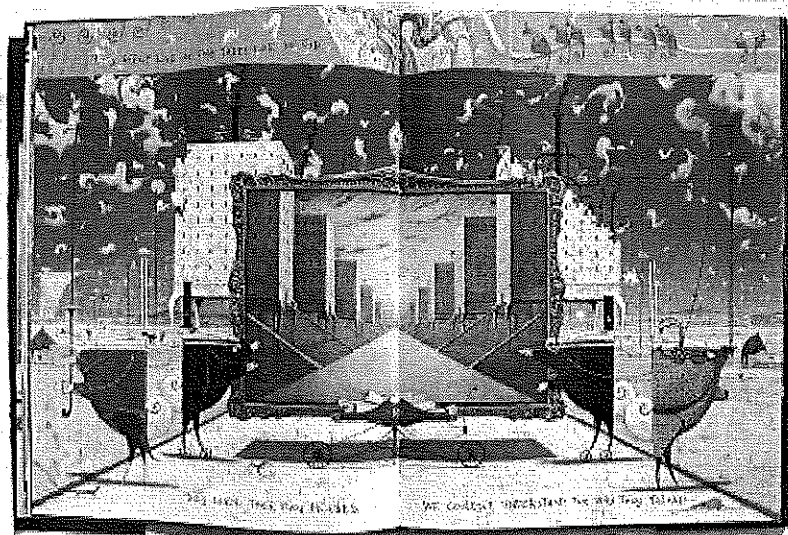
An age-old land. We read an invisible narrator's words, "The rabbits came many grandparents ago".



Opening 2

This illustration is of an immense land, home to tiny creatures, birds and insects. It has been marked by the wheels of a strange machine, which we can just make out on the horizon. Two worlds meet and wonder at each other: "They looked a bit like us ..." they were creatures, they had ears and tails, but they wore clothes and had strange machines... "There weren't many of them. Some were friendly."

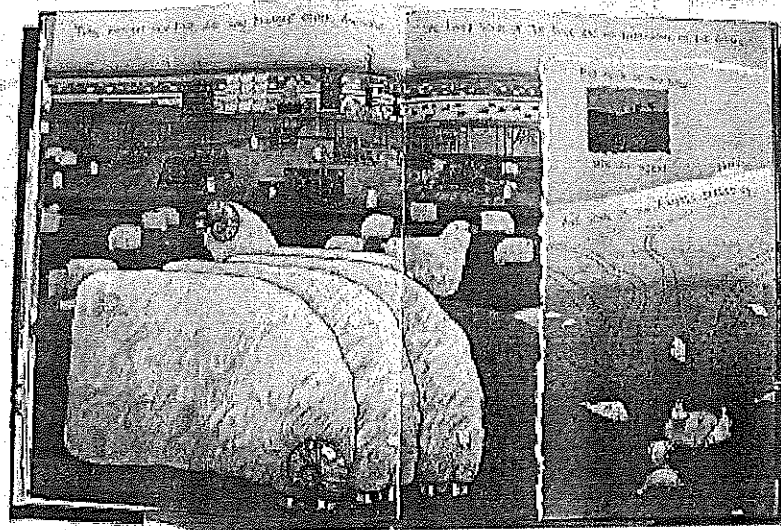
And soon more came, and the old people warned us all... "they came by water." And we see the front and back cover as a spread, even more frightening now as we have begun the story, we know the significance of these strange creatures. We are told and shown how different they are:



Opening 5

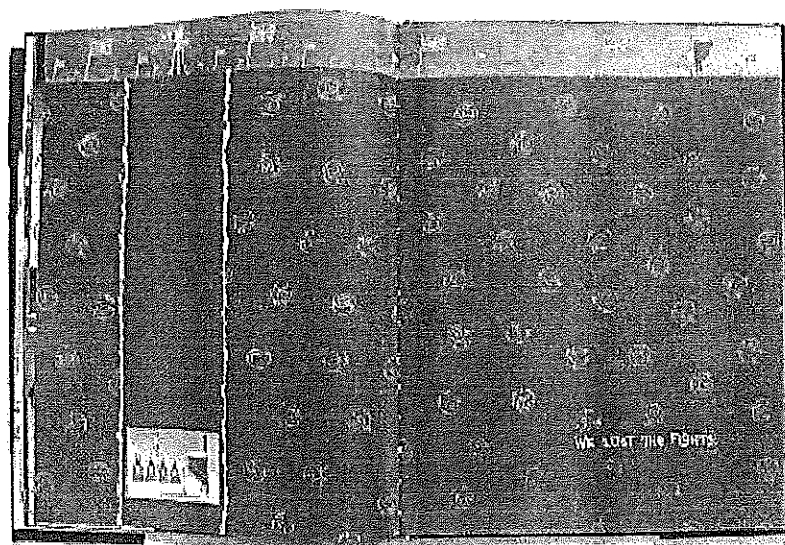
"They didn't live in trees like we did. They made their own houses." This particular spread gives us information in layers. The slightly lighter blue strip at the top is the original layer and belongs to the narrators. They are sitting in their trees, watching their world change. The darker blue is a superimposed layer, the result of the rabbits: we see both the buildings

being built and what they will look like. The buildings are like puzzles, already spewing black smoke. Everything is mechanical, even the rabbits seem so, the symmetry emphasizing the mechanical way they changed the world.



Opening 6

Not only were the rabbits' homes different, but "...they brought new food, and they brought other animals." The illustrations show us massive grass eating sheep, machines dressed in lambs' wool. Cows, already marked for the butcher's knife. The land is covered in these strange creatures, either in the fields or piled high on spindly locomotives. More words tell us that "... some of the animals scared us." But that's not all, "... some of the food made us sick" (the last three words turned upside down, as though rolling over with belly ache). The illustration shows a rabbit giving a bottle to the aboriginal creature collaged upon another illustration of a dried up water bed, littered with flapping, gasping fish. There was no stopping the rabbits, they spread across the country. There was fighting, "but there were too many rabbits"



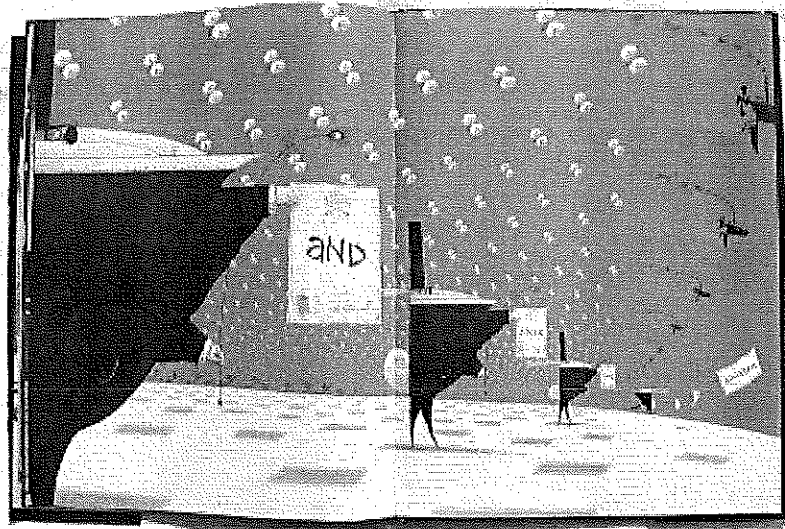
Opening 8

"We lost the fights." Those fossils we saw at the beginning, denoting an ancient world, dominated above by the rabbits' flags, the aboriginals, prisoners in their age old world,

defeated

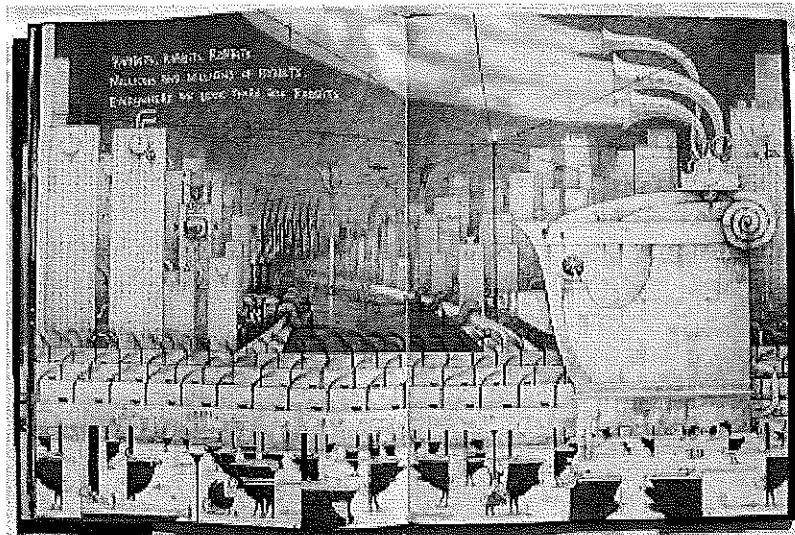
below.

The atrocities continue: "They ate our grass. They chopped down our trees and scared away our friends... "



Opening 10

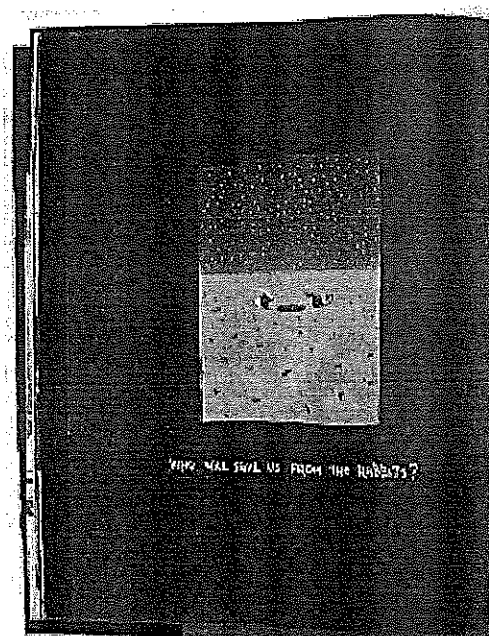
I find this spread the most shocking: hundreds of kites, with baby animals inside, being pulled by strange air machines. Mother creatures, as though dancing, hands raised towards their children, you can almost hear them moaning. And the rabbits, big and black, their vertical backs turned against the mothers. They have red and yellow eyes and the peacock feather pens mirror these evil eyes, dripping with the blood red ink they have just used to write on the certificates. These contain the verbal text of this page, each word on a separate sheet of paper, as though being spoken in jerks of distress, "and . stole . our . children."



Opening 11

"... everywhere we look there are rabbits." The statue in recto, a large rabbit, the motto MIGHT = RIGHT. A grey automated world, polluted and literally filled with rabbits, right to the very edges of the page. Can you see the only aboriginal creatures on the steps of the statue? The fallen kite? The rabbits holding masks? The gigantic curved chimneys, sucking in the blue sky and puffy clouds? A curious image, a frightening image. "The land is bare and brown and the wind blows empty across the plains. Where is the rich

dark earth brown and moist? Where is the smell of rain dripping from the trees? Where are the lakes, alive with long legged birds?" A final verso page shows a small cameo illustration against a black background. Two solitary creatures, a rabbit and an aboriginal.



Back verso

"Who will save us from the rabbits?". The land is wasted, littered with bones, lost and broken pieces of machinery and empty bottles. A small water hole reflects the stars in the sky. Can we read this as an image of hope? Is there any hope left? If we turn again to the back endpapers, we return to the bird-filled lake of cool lilac-blue water. A distant memory? A possible future?

When I first saw this picturebook I got goose bumps, and every time I look at it I get that goose bumpy feeling. It's quite something. A simple verbal text alongside such complex visual images, makes for much interpretation. There are many issues here and therefore lots of opportunities for talk and discussion. If you are teaching English through history, could this picturebook be of use? If your programme includes such topics as multiculturalism, could it be of use? Or, if you happen to have a group of interested teenagers, keen to talk and discuss, keen to put the world to rights, could this book be of use? I'd say 'yes' on all three occasions.

STAN GRANT'S SPEECH ON RACISM AND THE AUSTRALIAN DREAM

*This speech by Stan Grant was delivered during our last IQ2 debate of 2015: **Racism is Destroying the Australian Dream.** Stan's speech has been widely acknowledged as one of the most powerful ever heard on the IQ2 stage, and indeed, in recent Australian history. Stan was joined on the night by Indian Australian immigration lawyer Pallavi Sinha, American-born Iranian Australian Herald Sun columnist Rita Panahi and iconic Australian actor Jack Thompson.*

<http://www.ethics.org.au/on-ethics/blog/january-2016/stan-grant-s-speech-on-racism-and-the-australian-d>

Thank you so much for coming along this evening and I would also like to extend my respects to my Gadigal brothers and sisters from my people, the Wiradjuri people.

In the winter of 2015, Australia turned to face itself. It looked into its soul and it had to ask this question. Who are we? What sort of country do we want to be? And this happened in a place that is most holy, most sacred to Australians. It happened in the sporting field, it happened on the football field. Suddenly the front page was on the back page, it was in the grandstands.

Thousands of voices rose to hound an Indigenous man. A man who was told he wasn't Australian. A man who was told he wasn't Australian of the Year. And they hounded that man into submission.

I can't speak for what lay in the hearts of the people who booed Adam Goodes. But I can tell you what we heard when we heard those boos. We heard a sound that was very familiar to us.

We heard a howl. We heard a howl of humiliation that echoes across two centuries of dispossession, injustice, suffering and survival. We heard the howl of the Australian dream and it said to us again, you're not welcome.

The Australian Dream.

We sing of it, and we recite it in verse. *Australians all, let us rejoice for we are young and free.*

My people die young in this country. We die ten

years younger than average Australians and we are far from free. We are fewer than three percent of the Australian population and yet we are 25 percent, a quarter of those Australians locked up in our prisons and if you are a juvenile, it is worse, it is 50 percent. An Indigenous child is more likely to be locked up in prison than they are to finish high school.

I love a sunburned country, a land of sweeping plains, of rugged mountain ranges.

It reminds me that my people were killed on those plains. We were shot on those plains, disease ravaged us on those plains.

I come from those plains. I come from a people west of the Blue Mountains, the Wiradjuri people, where in the 1820's, the soldiers and settlers waged a war of extermination against my people. Yes, a war of extermination! That was the language used at the time. Go to the *Sydney Gazette* and look it up and read about it. Martial law was declared and my people could be shot on sight. Those rugged mountain ranges, my people, women and children were herded over those ranges to their deaths.

The Australian Dream.

The Australian Dream is rooted in racism. It is the very foundation of the dream. It is there at the birth of the nation. It is there in *terra nullius*. An empty land. A land for the taking. Sixty thousand years of occupation. A people who made the first seafaring journey in the history of mankind. A people of law, a people of lore, a people of music and art and dance and politics. None of it mattered because our rights were extinguished because we were not here according to British law.

And when British people looked at us, they saw something sub-human, and if we were human at all, we occupied the lowest rung on civilisation's ladder. We were fly-blown, stone age savages and that was the language that was used. Charles Dickens, the great writer of the age, when referring to the noble savage of which we were counted among, said "it would be better that they be wiped off the face of the earth." Captain Arthur Phillip, a man of enlightenment, a man who was instructed to make peace with the so called natives in a matter of years, was sending out raiding parties with the instruction, "Bring back the severed heads of the black

troublemakers."

They were smoothing the dying pillow.

My people were rounded up and put on missions from where if you escaped, you were hunted down, you were roped and tied and dragged back, and it happened here. It happened on the mission that my grandmother and my great grandmother are from, the Warrengeesda on the Darling Point of the Murrumbidgee River.

Read about it. It happened.

By 1901 when we became a nation, when we federated the colonies, we were nowhere. We're not in the Constitution, save for 'race provisions' which allowed for laws to be made that would take our children, that would invade our privacy, that would tell us who we could marry and tell us where we could live.

The Australian Dream.

By 1963, the year of my birth, the dispossession was continuing. Police came at gunpoint under cover of darkness to Mapoon, an aboriginal community in Queensland, and they ordered people from their homes and they burned those homes to the ground and they gave the land to a bauxite mining company. And today those people remember that as the 'Night of the Burning'.

In 1963 when I was born, I was counted among the flora and fauna, not among the citizens of this country.

Now, you will hear things tonight. You will hear people say, "But you've done well." Yes, I have and I'm proud of it and why have I done well? I've done well because of who has come before me. My father who lost the tips of three fingers working in saw mills to put food on our table because he was denied an education. My grandfather who served to fight wars for this country when he was not yet a citizen and came back to a segregated land where he couldn't even share a drink with his digger mates in the pub because he was black.

My great grandfather, who was jailed for speaking his language to his grandson (my father). Jailed for it! My grandfather on my mother's side who married a white woman who reached out to Australia, lived on the fringes of

town until the police came, put a gun to his head, bulldozed his tin humpy and ran over the graves of the three children he buried there.

That's the Australian Dream. I have succeeded in spite of the Australian Dream, not because of it, and I've succeeded because of those people.

You might hear tonight, "But you have white blood in you". And if the white blood in me was here tonight, my grandmother, she would tell you of how she was turned away from a hospital giving birth to her first child because she was giving birth to the child of a black person.

The Australian Dream.

We're better than this. I have seen the worst of the world as a reporter. I spent a decade in war zones from Iraq to Afghanistan, and Pakistan. We are an extraordinary country. We are in so many respects the envy of the world. If I was sitting here where my friends are tonight, I would be arguing passionately for this country. But I stand here with my ancestors, and the view looks very different from where I stand.

The Australian Dream.

We have our heroes. Albert Namatjira painted the soul of this nation. Vincent Lingiari put his hand out for Gough Whitlam to pour the sand of his country through his fingers and say, "This is my country." Cathy Freeman lit the torch of the Olympic Games. But every time we are lured into the light, we are mugged by the darkness of this country's history. Of course racism is killing the Australian Dream. It is self evident that it's killing the Australian dream. But we are better than that.

The people who stood up and supported Adam Goodes and said, "No more," they are better than that. The people who marched across the bridge for reconciliation, they are better than that. The people who supported Kevin Rudd when he said sorry to the Stolen Generations, they are better than that. My children and their non-Indigenous friends are better than that. My wife who is not Indigenous is better than that.

And one day, I want to stand here and be able to say as proudly and sing as loudly as anyone else in this room, Australians *all*, let us rejoice.

Thank you.

MISE-EN-SCENE Description	THEORIST	CLT	VISUAL TECHNIQUES	HOW THE READER WAS POSITIONED	QUOTE
1					
2					
3					
4					